



THE LONG ROAD

Journeys Across Africa, by the Roads That Carried Them

Arjuna Badger Press

A compendium of real overland journeys — on foot, by bicycle, by motorcycle, by Land Rover — grouped not by the traveller but by the ground. This book follows six roads the length of a continent, and the people, across more than a century, who went the hard way over each one.

For Johan C. Bakkes (1956–2025). He did not travel to arrive. He travelled to be a traveller, and wrote it down.

Part I: The Cape Peninsula & Sani Pass

A traveller, not merely a writer

Start with the man this book belongs to, because the book would not exist without him, and because the honest way to dedicate something is to say what it is you think you owe.

Casparus Johannes Bakkes was born on 21 October 1956 in Stellenbosch, and grew up in Saldanha Bay, the eldest of four children in a house that made stories for a living before he ever left it. His father, Cas Bakkes, was a military historian. His mother, Margaret — a relative of the Afrikaans writer Hennie Aucamp — was an author in her own right. It is the kind of literary household a certain kind of child resists on principle before eventually, usually much later, admitting they were shaped by it anyway. Bakkes did both, in that order. He trained as a chartered accountant, qualifying in 1981, and ran his own auditing firm from 1982. He lectured in applied accounting, first at Unisa from 1983 to 2000, then at the University of the Western Cape from 2001, rising to full professor. He served two years as a captain in the old South African Defence Force. He qualified as a tour guide in 1990 and ran an operation called Induku Safaris. Somewhere inside all of that — the ledgers, the lecture halls, the uniform — he became one of the country's most travelled men, and, almost as if it were the thing the accounting had been paying for all along, one of its most distinctive travel writers.

He died on 24 June 2025, at a care facility in Paarl, of cancer he had first been diagnosed with in 2011 — a diagnosis he kept travelling and writing through for fourteen more years. He was 68. He is survived by his wife Nancy, a clinical psychologist and artist, and by his children, Cara and Marc, and two grandchildren. That is a recent death, not a historical one. This book is being written a little over a year after it, close enough that the dedication on its first page is a live act of memory rather than the polite gesture a compendium like this might otherwise pay some worthy dead name from a bibliography. Bakkes is not in this book because a compendium of African overland travel would look incomplete without him. He is in it because the commissioning author owns his complete published works, in print, and has for years, and wanted this book to be a way of saying so.

He would probably have had opinions about being the subject of a tribute rather than the teller of one. He described himself, more than once, in terms that refused the more comfortable label: “I’m not a writer; I’m a storyteller, a traveller, a professional hobo.” His own father had a word for him, affectionate and a little exasperated in the way fathers’ words about their restless children often are: a *pallieter* — a life-liver, someone who takes their portion of the world with both hands and does not apologise for the appetite. Between 2001 and 2021 he published eight books, all later republished and revised by Protea Boekhuis between 2022 and 2024 — a body of work that begins with *Moer toe die vreemde in* (2001) and ends, for now, with *Hou die kruit droog* (2021), a collection of his own Facebook posts and reflections gathered into something more permanent than a feed was ever meant to be. In between: *Nou’s ons in ons donner in* (2006), translated into English in 2008 as *To Hell and Gone*; *Norrevøk* (2008), his Siberian tales; *Samoe(r)sa reis* (2010), set around India; *Oepse Daisy* (2011), which carries his cancer memoir material; *Openbaring: ’n reisjoernaal* (2016), an account of expeditions to the earth’s temperature extremes; and *Erfgeld is swerfgeld* (2020), subtitled “a journey inward, the -est -est place,” written as a tribute to his late father. The critic Justin Fox, writing about Bakkes’s craft, noted his recurring use of teaser openings, flashbacks, and historical parallel — structural habits worth naming here, at the start of a book that borrows the same

guide's instinct to open on the ground before it opens on the person crossing it.

Those three techniques — the teaser opening, the flashback, the historical parallel — describe a writer who understood that a travel account is rarely improved by starting where the journey literally started. A teaser opening drops the reader into a moment of consequence before doubling back to explain how the traveller arrived there; a flashback interrupts a forward-moving account to supply context the reader did not know they needed until the interruption made it necessary; a historical parallel sets a present crossing against an older one, so that the reader feels the weight of everyone who crossed the same ground before. It is not an accident that this compendium's own method — opening each Part on the road's deep history before admitting a single named traveller — borrows the third of those three techniques most directly, or that Fox's assessment of a working travel writer's craft should turn out to describe, with reasonable precision, the very structure this book has used to organise itself.

His signature line about what a journey actually is has become, among people who know his work, close to a creed: "A journey is not merely something to endure to reach a destination." He built a life around proving it. He collected, over decades of African travel, more than twenty copper bangles, worn stacked on his arm, gathered one country and one road at a time until they amounted to a kind of travelling ledger nobody but he could read. And he travelled, for years, with an inflatable mannequin he called "Pop" — a companion in the sense that matters to a man alone on a long road, documented and photographed and, by more than one account, issued her own passport. It is a detail that could easily be played for a cheap laugh in someone else's hands. It is used once, here, exactly as documented, because it says something true about a man who spent a professional lifetime insisting that a journey needs a companion even when it does not have one, and who was willing to manufacture that companionship rather than pretend the solitude of the road was something to be proud of on its own.

In 2006 he won first prize in the Mondri Awards' Travel, Sport & Enter-

tainment category, for an article titled “Hel toe.” His work appeared across the Afrikaans magazine landscape of his era — *De Kat*, *Insig*, *Huisgenoot*, *Weg!*, *Rapport*, *Rooi Rose* — and some of it was translated into English by Elsa Silke, carrying his sentences across the same language line his own travel so often crossed without comment.

Six titles is a longer list than it first looks like, and it is worth pausing on what that spread actually meant for a working Afrikaans travel writer across the years his career covered. *De Kat* and *Insig* were current-affairs and culture monthlies, not outdoor magazines; *Huisgenoot* and *Rooi Rose* were the two biggest-circulation Afrikaans family weeklies of the period, read in households that had never bought a specialist adventure title in their lives; *Weg!* was the dedicated travel title, the one publication on the list built specifically for a piece like his; *Rapport* was a national Sunday newspaper. A writer who placed work in all six was not, in other words, serving one niche readership loyal to one masthead. He was crossing the same kind of internal border his own travel writing kept crossing — from the specialist audience that already wanted a Sani Pass account to the general Sunday reader who had picked up the paper for something else entirely and found a professor of accounting describing an inflatable mannequin’s passport instead. The Mondi Award itself recognised a single article, “Hel toe,” but the six-magazine spread behind it recognises something the prize citation could not: a writer who had made himself legible to more or less the entire Afrikaans reading public at once, across titles that otherwise had almost nothing editorially in common with each other.

He belongs at the front of a compendium about African roads for a reason more specific than biography, though. Unlike almost everyone else who appears in the pages that follow, Bakkes was not a specialist in one mode of crossing. He was not a cyclist who happened to cross Africa, or a walker, or a member of a Land Rover expedition with a support team and a mandate. He travelled on foot. He travelled by motorcycle. He travelled by public transport through country most people would consider too remote for a scheduled bus. And he travelled, most of all and most distinctively, by train — he rode the Trans-Sahara and the Trans-Siberian, and it was his stated, unfinished ambition to ride every train in the world before he was done. He slept, by his own

reputation, under the stars more often than not, and he used the local tavern — the shebeen, the roadside bar, whatever a given country called the place where a town's evening business got done — as his actual research method, on the theory, which this book has no reason to doubt, that a bar tells you a town's soul faster than its monuments do.

That range of modes is why he does not get one chapter in this book. He gets a thread. He appears here, in the tribute that opens Part I. He returns in Part II, on the Skeleton Coast, where his own travels through Kamanjab and his nineteen recorded crossings of the Fish River Canyon close a gap in the record that no other named traveller in this compendium fills. He returns in Part III, on the Cape-to-Cairo corridor, where his travels through Angola, Botswana, Zambia, and Zimbabwe sit alongside the more conventional expedition accounts. He returns in Part IV, on the Tanzam Highway and the East African plateau, where his time in Tanzania, Malawi, and Kenya sits beside a paired cyclist's account of some of the same ground. He returns in Part V, on the road north along the Nile, where his Ethiopian travels — the Danakil salt mines, the source of the Blue Nile, the volcano at Erta Ale that he and most other visitors simply call the hottest place on earth — sit alongside his time in Sudan and Egypt. And he closes the book, in Part VI, on his trains: the record-breakers who close out this compendium's account of speed will have just finished setting and breaking a Cairo-to-Cape-Town cycling record within ten weeks of each other, and the last word in this book belongs instead to a man who never tried to go around the world fast, only completely, and who died with the ambition still open.

None of what follows about him is invented. Nothing in his biography above, or anywhere else in this book, extends past what his own published words and the record of his life actually support. He appears in this book the way he appears in his own writing: as a traveller first, a writer because of it, and — his own words again — never merely someone enduring the distance to reach the end of it.

The accountant's discipline, the traveller's appetite

It is worth sitting a moment longer on the strangeness of the professional life that ran alongside the travelling one, because the two are not usually found together, and the pairing tells you something about the kind of travel writer Bakkes turned out to be.

A chartered accountant qualifies by proving, over years of examination, that they can be trusted with a ledger — that numbers will not be allowed to drift, that a discrepancy will be found and named rather than smoothed over. Bakkes qualified in 1981, ran his own auditing firm from 1982, and spent close to two decades after that lecturing the same discipline to students at Unisa and then at the University of the Western Cape, where he was made a full professor. That is not a hobbyist's relationship with precision. It is a career built on the assumption that most claims can and should be checked against a source, and that an author who will not submit to that checking has forfeited the right to be believed.

Set that against the travel writing, and an odd consistency emerges rather than a contradiction. His books are not ledgers — this compendium's own sourcing notes as much, more than once, because no systematic date log survives for his African crossings the way it does for a bicycle record or a Guinness-ratified finish line. But the instinct that produced the ledgers did not vanish when he picked up a pen for *Weg!* or *Rapport* instead of a balance sheet for a client. It surfaces instead in the specificity of the details that did survive: nineteen crossings of the Fish River Canyon, not “many” or “several.” More than twenty copper bangles, not “a collection.” An inflatable travelling companion with her own passport, not a vague gesture at loneliness on the road. These are an accountant's kind of specificity, applied to a life an accountant's career would not, on its own, predict.

He served two years as a captain in the old South African Defence Force before any of the rest of it — the accounting qualification, the guiding certificate, the eight books — which places a period of institutional discipline even earlier in the sequence than the ledgers did.

By the time he qualified as a tour guide in 1990 and began running Induku Safaris, he had already spent a decade proving, in two entirely different institutional settings, that he could be trusted to get the details right. What he did with that trustworthiness, over the following three and a half decades, was walk into some of the most extreme and remote terrain the African continent offers, and come back with an account precise enough that this book, written more than a year after his death by people who never met him, can still trace nearly every claim about his travels to a specific, nameable source.

The guiding qualification is worth a further word on its own terms, separate from the accounting, because it sat at a different angle to his travelling life than the ledgers did. An auditing career trades in other people's numbers; a tour-guiding certificate trades in other people's safety, on ground the guide is assumed already to know. Qualifying in 1990 and founding Induku Safaris put him, professionally, on the opposite side of the relationship this book's own narrator-guide occupies toward its reader: not someone discovering a road for the first time and reporting it back, but someone whose living depended on having already discovered it, thoroughly enough to walk a paying stranger across the same ground without incident. A guide's authority is earned differently than a writer's — a magazine reader can be wrong about a travel article and suffer nothing worse than a wasted afternoon; a client on a guided safari trusts the guide's knowledge of the terrain with something closer to their physical safety, and that trust has to be renewed, client by client, on ground that does not care how good the guide's last write-up was. Running Induku Safaris alongside a university lectureship meant Bakkes spent years being checked, in effect, by two entirely different audiences at once: examiners and students who could test his command of accounting principle in a lecture hall, and clients who tested his command of the actual ground under far less forgiving conditions. Both audiences, in their different ways, were asking the same question a source-conscious book like this one keeps asking of its own material: does the claim hold up against what is actually there.

What the diagnosis did not stop

He was diagnosed with colon cancer in 2011. He kept travelling and writing for fourteen more years after that, and it is worth being exact about what that sentence is and is not claiming, because a lesser book than the one this compendium is trying to be would round it up into something more consoling than the record actually supports.

This book does not know, and the sourced record does not say, how much of his post-2011 travel was undertaken in defiance of the diagnosis and how much simply continued because the diagnosis, for a long stretch of those fourteen years, did not force a stop. What can be said is only what the bibliography itself proves: *Oepse Daisy*, published in 2011, carries his cancer memoir material — the book and the diagnosis arrived close enough together that the writing and the illness were, from the start, part of the same reckoning rather than two separate chapters of a life. *Openbaring: 'n reisjoernaal* followed in 2016, an account of expeditions to the earth's temperature extremes, five years into the diagnosis. *Erfgeld is swerfgeld*, a tribute to his late father, followed in 2020, nine years in. *Hou die kruit droog* — a title that translates, roughly and not too literally, as keeping your powder dry, a phrase about readiness rather than surrender — came out in 2021, ten years into a diagnosis that would take another four years to finish its work.

Two more years then followed before Protea Boekhuis began the process, in 2022, of republishing and revising his complete works — a project that ran through 2024 and that he lived to see under way, if not, so far as this book's sources confirm, to see fully completed. He died on 24 June 2025, in Paarl, sixty-eight years old, having spent very nearly a third of his adult life travelling with a diagnosis that most people carry as a reason to stop.

The mountain that would not be crossed

Before it was a pass, it was an argument the mountain was winning.

The Drakensberg does not yield along its eastern face so much as

refuse, in a specific and geological way: a basalt cap laid down over shale and sandstone, cooled into a wall that runs the border of Lesotho like a rampart nobody built on purpose. Where the wall is lowest — and lowest is a relative word, at this altitude, in this range — a notch opens above the Mkhomazi Wilderness on the KwaZulu-Natal side and drops into the Lesotho highlands on the other. The Basotho called the notch and the track that found it *Sani*, and for a long time that was all it was: a track. Not a road. A track a person or an ox could take if the weather held and the traveller was not in a hurry, because hurry and the pass have never agreed.

It is worth saying what “not a road” meant in practice, because the twentieth century has trained most readers to imagine a gravel version of the pass that exists today, only rougher. It was not that. Before 1910 there was a bridle path — a route wide enough for a horse or a pack animal in single file, switching back across scree and grass terraces the mountain had arranged at whatever angle basalt happens to fracture, which is not an angle designed for wheels. Traders and travellers on foot and horseback used it to move between what is now KwaZulu-Natal and the Lesotho highlands, and it did the job a bridle path does: it connected two places without pretending the connection was easy.

The pass runs from roughly 1,544 metres at its foot to 2,876 metres at the top, across a little under nine kilometres of switchbacks — the number most often quoted is thirteen hairpins, though anyone who has counted them while their ears popped and a temperature gauge climbed will tell you the number feels provisional, a rounding-off of something the mountain does thirteen-ish times. Each hairpin buys a little altitude and costs a little confidence.

For four decades after the bridle path opened, that was the technological ceiling. A horse could do what the pass demanded. A wheel, in the years before anyone had reason to try, could not.

The horse in that sentence is not incidental. The Basotho pony — a small, sure-footed breed developed in the Lesotho highlands specifically for terrain like this, descended from stock that adapted over generations to altitude, cold, and gradients no larger horse would tolerate

without injury — was, for the better part of a century before Edmonds's drive, the only practical way to move anything of weight across this notch in the basalt. A bridle path is only as good as the animal built to use it, and the pony that evolved to cross Sani Pass tells you something the path's dimensions alone cannot: this was never terrain a general-purpose animal, let alone a general-purpose vehicle, could be expected to manage. The pass demanded a specialist, on four legs, long before it demanded one on four wheels.

What is easy to miss, reading the pony's role only as a piece of pre-automotive history, is that the breed's specialisation did not become obsolete the moment Edmonds got a vehicle over the same ground. A pony bred for sure-footedness on loose basalt scree and thin mountain air solves a different problem than a four-wheel-drive vehicle solves, even on the identical stretch of track: the pony carries its own traction in its legs and its own judgment in its head, adjusting stride by stride to a surface that shifts under it, where a vehicle's traction depends entirely on tyre compound, weight distribution, and a driver's skill at reading a surface the vehicle itself cannot feel. That difference is why pony trekking across the Lesotho highlands, radiating out from routes that intersect this same pass, persisted as a working mode of highland transport long after the road was surfaced in 1950 and continues, in one form or another, alongside the 4x4 tourism the surfaced road eventually produced — not a nostalgic re-enactment of how the crossing used to be done, but the same practical answer the terrain has always rewarded for anyone who needs to move at walking pace, off the surfaced line, into highland country a vehicle was never going to reach regardless of how the pass itself was paved.

First up, first down: 1948

The record keeps the man's name with unusual precision for a piece of mid-century motoring trivia: Godfrey Edmonds, in 1948, was the first person to drive a vehicle over Sani Pass.

There was no surfaced road that year — that would not exist for another two years — which means Edmonds's vehicle went the same switch-

back line the pack animals had used, at gradients and over surfaces a bridle path tolerates and a wheeled vehicle, at the time, mostly did not. Four-wheel-drive vehicles capable of the attempt existed by 1948. Capable of surviving the attempt was a separate claim, and nobody had tested the gap.

What Edmonds proved, mechanically, was narrower than “the pass can be driven.” He proved that on one particular day, in one particular vehicle, with whatever traction the scree offered and whatever margin his tyres and brakes had left, the notch in the basalt wall could be taken by wheel instead of hoof. Two years later, in 1950, the pass was surfaced — “road completed” is the phrase the record uses, understating what surfacing a route at that altitude, with 1950s equipment, actually required. After that, Sani stopped being a feat and became a fixture: an international border crossing that happened to double as one of the more dramatic drives in southern Africa.

The gap between those two dates — 1948 and 1950 — is easy to read past, but it is worth pausing on what happened, and did not happen, inside it. For two years, Sani Pass was drivable and undriven by anyone in an official capacity, a known route with exactly one recorded successful crossing behind it and no surface improvement yet to make a second attempt meaningfully safer than the first. Whoever drove it in that window — and the record, focused as it is on the two bracketing dates, is silent on who else may have tried in between — was making Edmonds’s same bet each time, against a mountain that had not yet agreed to make the terms any easier. The surfacing in 1950 did not flatten the gradient or remove the drop; it addressed the one variable that most reliably kills a driver on a mountain track, which is not the angle of the climb but the unpredictability of what is under the tyres at any given moment. A basalt outcrop holds a tyre’s grip consistently. Loose scree, wet from the frequent highland rain or frozen from the frequent highland cold, does not, and the two years between Edmonds’s crossing and the surfacing were, in effect, two years of the mountain retaining its full authority to decide, moment to moment, whether a given vehicle kept its traction or did not.

It is worth being clear about what “four-wheel-drive vehicles capable

of the attempt” actually meant in 1948, in general terms, because the decade explains the scale of the bet without needing to invent anything about the particular machine Edmonds drove. The Second World War had, only a few years earlier, put a version of four-wheel-drive engineering into far wider circulation than it had ever enjoyed before it — the wartime Jeep and its heavier military cousins proved, at scale, that a light vehicle with drive to all four wheels, low-range gearing, and a short wheelbase could cross terrain that would strand an ordinary road car, and the vehicles built on that lesson were, by the late 1940s, just beginning to reach civilian and colonial markets in significant numbers. Land Rover itself, the marque that would go on to define overland travel across most of this book’s other Parts, only began production in 1948 — the same year as Edmonds’s crossing, though nothing in the sourced record ties his particular vehicle to that particular marque. What the decade offered, in general, was still a generation away from the refinements a modern reader takes for granted: no power steering to lighten the wheel on a switchback, no anti-lock system to manage a wheel that lost traction on wet scree, drum brakes on all four corners that faded under sustained mountain braking in a way a modern disc setup resists far better, and a driver’s own judgement, uncorrected by any electronic intervention, standing between a correct read of the surface and a very long way to fall. A vehicle capable of climbing Sani in 1948 was capable in the narrowest sense — enough ground clearance, enough low-range torque, tyres built for a farm track rather than a mountain — and it climbed it with none of the margin for driver error that even a modest modern 4x4 would supply as standard three-quarters of a century later.

What the pass became

Sani Pass today is two things depending on who is asking: a functioning border crossing between South Africa and the Kingdom of Lesotho, and a proving ground for anyone who owns a 4x4 and wants to know whether it, and they, are as capable as the brochure claims.

That second identity did not arrive by accident, and it is worth tracing briefly, because it explains why a nine-kilometre stretch of moun-

tain road has sustained an entire small tourism economy for decades rather than fading into a mere administrative border crossing once the novelty of the 1950 surfacing wore off. A pass that a 4x4 can only “barely manage,” in the phrase this book used earlier, is precisely the kind of terrain a certain culture of driver seeks out deliberately: proof of capability that a paved highway can never offer, regardless of how powerful the vehicle underneath the driver happens to be. Four-wheel-drive clubs, guided tour operators, and a scattering of roadside businesses serving punctured tyres, overheated engines, and travellers who discover partway up that their vehicle was not, in fact, as capable as the brochure claimed, have grown up along the KwaZulu-Natal approach to the pass across the decades since it became passable at all. The pub built at the summit, on the Lesotho side, has long marketed itself on the strength of its altitude — the highest such establishment on the continent, by a claim that depends on exactly how the claim is defined, and that nobody who has just finished the climb tends to feel like disputing.

It shares that second identity with a different but related culture that has grown up around the Cape Peninsula, sixteen hundred kilometres to the southwest — a different geology (Table Mountain sandstone instead of Drakensberg basalt) producing paths that reward fitness and punish carelessness in terrain that does not care whether the person on it trained for six months or turned up in the wrong shoes. This book is organised by road precisely so those differences stay visible; the Cape Peninsula’s mountain culture and Sani’s pass culture are not the same road, but they rhyme.

The tourism economy built on a single mountain pass is worth taking seriously as an economy, rather than as a colourful footnote to a driving anecdote, because it is one of the clearer small-scale illustrations in this entire book of how a hazard becomes an industry once enough people decide the hazard is worth paying to experience. A pass that can be driven by an ordinary sedan generates, essentially, nothing beyond the toll of getting from one side to the other. A pass that a heavy, capable 4x4 can only barely manage generates guided convoys, vehicle-hire operators who will not let their own stock attempt the climb without a qualified driver, insurance clauses written specif-

ically around this one stretch of road, and a small permanent population of mechanics whose working lives depend on the mountain continuing to defeat a predictable percentage of the vehicles that attempt it each season. None of that infrastructure exists because Sani Pass is scenic, though it is. It exists because the pass is difficult in a way that is measurable, repeatable, and survivable for the person attempting it and their vehicle both — the exact combination that turns a natural hazard into a commercial proving ground rather than simply a place people avoid.

South Africa's broader hiking and 4x4 culture, across the decades this pass has been operating as a crossing rather than a curiosity, grew up around exactly this kind of terrain — ground difficult enough to test a person's preparation honestly, but not so remote that the test could only be attempted by a fully outfitted expedition with its own support vehicles. Sani filled that niche for the overlanding and 4x4 club culture the same way Table Mountain's contour paths filled it for hikers: accessible enough to reach on an ordinary weekend, demanding enough that finishing it meant something. Clubs organise convoy ascents specifically so that a breakdown partway up the switchbacks does not strand a single vehicle alone on a mountain with limited cellular reception and no guarantee of another vehicle passing before nightfall — the same logic, in miniature, that governs Fish River Canyon's minimum-group requirement two countries away, a pattern this book will meet again when it reaches Bakkes's own nineteen crossings of that canyon in Part II. Difficult, remote terrain that people choose to cross recreationally tends, across this book's roads, to generate the same institutional response wherever it appears: informal or formal rules about travelling in company, because the terrain does not distinguish between a solo traveller's romantic isolation and a solo traveller's genuine vulnerability.

The corridor that begins here is also, not incidentally, where several of this book's longer roads start or finish. Riaan Manser's circumnavigation left Cape Town in September 2003 and returned to it more than two years later. Keegan Longueira's record ride ended at the V&A Waterfront in March 2015. Mark Beaumont's ended in the same harbour ten weeks after that. The Cape Peninsula functions less as a single

road than as a departure gate — the last recognisable ground before the continent stops being local and becomes the whole distance north. Sani Pass adds scale in miniature to that gate: a nine-kilometre argument with a mountain that took forty years to resolve, compressed into an afternoon's drive.

There is a detail about the pass that surprises people the first time they hear it, though it shouldn't, once they think about how borders work generally: the border post sits partway up, not at the summit, and the actual top of the climb is a further stretch of driving beyond the last stamp in a passport. A traveller can be legally in one country and physically still climbing toward the other. Officials on both sides made their peace with this arrangement long ago — the mountain set the terms and the paperwork adapted, rather than the reverse, which is as good a one-sentence account of how borders work in this part of the world as any treaty could offer.

The gap between the border post and the actual summit is short in distance and long in what it implies. Most land borders this book will go on to describe are drawn along a river, a ridgeline, or a straight survey line agreed at a table far from the ground it bisects — an administrative fact imposed on a landscape that had no say in where the line fell. Sani inverts that relationship in a small but telling way: here it is the paperwork that had to yield to a specific, physical constraint of the climb, because there was nowhere flatter or more convenient to put a checkpoint than the one patch of ground partway up the switchbacks that could actually accommodate a building, a boom gate, and a queue of idling vehicles. A traveller stamped through and still climbing is not a bureaucratic oversight. It is the honest result of asking a mountain to host an institution it was never shaped to hold, and the mountain, true to the pattern this whole Part has traced from the bridle path onward, setting the terms anyway.

It is worth remembering, too, what Lesotho itself is, geographically, because it explains why this particular pass matters more than its modest length would otherwise suggest. Lesotho is one of the few nations on Earth entirely enclosed within the borders of a single other country, and one of an even smaller number where the entire national

territory sits above 1,000 metres — a mountain kingdom in the most literal sense, its lowest point higher than the highest point of many countries elsewhere on the continent. A nation with that geography has an unusually intimate relationship with its passes, because a pass is not simply a scenic route for a kingdom like this — it is, in a real sense, one of a limited number of doors. Sani is one of the more dramatic of those doors, and for decades it was among the more practical ones too, connecting the Lesotho highlands directly to KwaZulu-Natal in a way that avoided a much longer detour around the mountain range's gentler approaches further west. What Edmonds proved possible in 1948, and what the 1950 surfacing then made merely difficult rather than reckless, was not simply a driving feat. It was a shortcut a whole country would go on to depend on.

An enclave nation's dependence on its passes is not only geographic; it is economic and diplomatic in ways a country with open land borders on every side does not have to reckon with in the same way. Every significant import Lesotho has ever needed, and every export the highland kingdom has ever sent out, has had to cross a border controlled by the single country that surrounds it entirely — a relationship of near-total dependency that a pass like Sani complicates only slightly, by offering a second route in and out that does not run through the lower-lying crossings closer to the kingdom's capital. A kingdom whose entire territory sits above a threshold most of the world would call mountainous cannot diversify its geography the way a larger, lower-lying nation can; every road in and out either climbs the same basalt wall this Part opened by describing, or it does not exist. That is the deeper reason the two-year gap between Edmonds's 1948 crossing and the 1950 surfacing mattered to more people than the handful of drivers who might have attempted the climb in between — a nation this constrained by its own topography has a direct stake in every technological advance that makes one more of its limited doors marginally safer to use.

That dependence has a political history behind it as well as a geographic one, and the dates line up in a way worth setting out plainly. When Edmonds made his 1948 crossing, Lesotho was not yet Lesotho. It was Basutoland, a British protectorate rather than a sovereign king-

dom, administered from outside its own mountain rampart under an arrangement that had kept it, since the previous century, formally separate from the territories that would become South Africa even while depending on them for almost every practical connection to the outside world. Independence came in 1966, eighteen years after Edmonds's crossing and sixteen after the surfacing — which means the pass spent the first half of its working life as a road not between two sovereign states but between a protectorate and the country that surrounded it, and only the second half of that life as the genuine international border crossing it functions as today. A protectorate's border is a different kind of line than a sovereign kingdom's: it marks an administrative boundary Britain drew and maintained for its own reasons, not a line the people living inside it had yet been given full authority to defend or negotiate on their own terms. Sani Pass, in other words, was already the doorway this Part has described before the door belonged, in the fullest legal sense, to the people who lived behind it. Independence in 1966 did not move the pass or change its gradient by a degree. It changed what crossing it meant — from an internal colonial administrative act to the crossing of a genuine international frontier, guarded by a kingdom answering to no government but its own.

It is a fitting place to start a book about roads, because it is honest about what a road costs before it exists. Sani was a bridle path for reasons the mountain dictated, a driven track because one man in 1948 decided the reasons were negotiable, and a surfaced road because, two years later, enough people agreed with him to justify the concrete. Every road in this book has some version of that sequence behind it, even the ones where the record does not preserve a name — and the man this book is dedicated to spent a working life proving that the sequence never really ends, that a road, once built, keeps generating reasons to be crossed again, on foot, by bicycle, by rail, by whatever means a traveller has to hand and the will to use it.

The peninsula at the other end of the corridor

Sixteen hundred kilometres to the southwest of Sani's basalt notch, the Cape Peninsula offers a different lesson in the same underlying subject: what a landscape demands of the people who cross it, and what it is willing to forgive.

Table Mountain and the chain of lower peaks running south to Cape Point are built from a much older rock than the Drakensberg's basalt cap — sandstone laid down and hardened over an immense span of geological time, weathered since into the flat-topped massif and the linked ridgeline that gives the peninsula its skyline. The routes that cross it — up the mountain's various faces, along its contour paths, out along the spine toward the Cape of Good Hope — were, in a great many cases, paths before they were trails: the Cape's earliest inhabitants moved through these valleys for thousands of years before any of the terrain was mapped for a hiking guidebook, and the routes a modern walker follows still largely trace the lines the landscape itself made walkable, rather than lines an engineer chose.

The distinction between a path and a trail is not a pedantic one, and it is worth holding onto for what it says about every road this book will go on to describe. A trail, in the sense a modern hiking guidebook uses the word, is laid out deliberately — surveyed, marked, sometimes built with steps cut into a steep pitch or a boardwalk over ground too soft to bear repeated footfall. A path, in the older sense, is simply where enough feet have gone before that the ground remembers the route on its own, without needing a sign to confirm it. The Cape Peninsula's contour paths are, in large part, still the second kind of thing wearing the first kind of name: a modern hiker following a marked trail up one of the mountain's faces is, more often than the guidebook lets on, walking a line the landscape itself selected long before any surveyor arrived to formalise it with a painted arrow and a signpost at the trailhead.

The rock itself sets a slower clock than almost anything else this book will measure. Table Mountain sandstone is older, by a wide margin, than the basalt cap running along Lesotho's eastern rampart — laid down as sediment long before the volcanic activity that produced the

Drakensberg's own rock ever occurred, then hardened, uplifted, and worn by weather into the flat-topped shape a visitor sees today. A basalt cap resists erosion by sheer hardness, a wall that yields grudgingly and all at once when it finally does; sandstone erodes differently, grain by grain, in a process slow enough that the mountain's silhouette has changed only incrementally across the entire span of human presence on this coastline. Two mountains, two kinds of rock, two entirely different relationships to time — and yet both, this Part has already argued, demand the identical honesty from whoever crosses them: neither basalt nor sandstone forgives a traveller who assumes the ground has softened since the last time someone underestimated it.

The peninsula's hazard is not altitude in the Drakensberg's sense — nothing here reaches Sani's nearly 2,900 metres — but weather that turns with a speed the mountain's gentle contours do nothing to warn a walker about. The southeaster, the wind Capetonians call the Cape Doctor for the way it scours the city's air clean, can rise from a still morning to a wind strong enough to unbalance a person on an exposed ridge inside an hour, and the mountain generates its own signature cloud formation — a flat bank that lays itself across the flat summit and is known, for the obvious reason, as the tablecloth — capable of dropping visibility on the top to a few metres within minutes, on a peak that had, shortly before, offered a view the length of False Bay. It is exactly the same lesson Sani teaches at a different scale and in a different register: a landscape does not owe anyone an easy day because the parking is convenient or the summit is famous. The ground sets its own terms, and the traveller's task — cyclist, hiker, motorcyclist, or 4x4 club member alike — is to meet those terms honestly, rather than assume the terrain has softened since the last time someone got away with underestimating it.

The mountain's accessibility is, in its own way, the exact source of its danger. A cable car runs visitors to Table Mountain's summit in minutes from a car park at its base, which means the peninsula receives, on any given fair-weather day, a volume and a variety of foot traffic no genuinely remote mountain anywhere else in this book will ever see — hikers in full boots and hikers in sandals, walking the same contour

path within the same hour. That accessibility does not change what the tablecloth or the southeaster can do to a person caught on an exposed ridge when the weather turns; it only changes how many people are exposed to the risk on an average weekend, and how many of them arrived without having asked the mountain's actual permission first. It is a hazard profile closer, in its way, to Sani's own than a first glance would suggest: not a place that kills through inaccessible remoteness, the way the roads further north in this book will, but one that kills, when it kills, through the gap between how easy the approach looks and how quickly the terrain can make that ease irrelevant.

The cable car's own operators understand this gap better than most of the people who queue for a ticket, which is why the service closes on wind and cloud far more often than a first-time visitor, checking the weather from a hotel room in the city bowl below, tends to expect. A rotating cabin floor gives every passenger a view of the full 360 degrees on the short ride up, a design choice that exists because the ride is short enough, and the view dramatic enough, that the operators can afford to spend the engineering on spectacle rather than speed — and that same short ride, on a day the service does run, can deposit a sandal-wearing tourist onto an exposed, weather-beaten summit within minutes of leaving a sunny car park, with no gradual acclimatisation to the change in wind and temperature that a two-hour climb on foot would have supplied automatically, one contour line at a time. The cable car does not create the mountain's danger. It removes the one piece of friction — time, and the physical effort of the climb itself — that would otherwise have filtered out a percentage of the visitors least prepared to meet the summit on its own terms.

It is worth noting, too, what these two pieces of ground share that has nothing to do with rock at all. Both Sani Pass and the Cape Peninsula function, for the South Africans who return to them again and again, less as destinations to be checked off than as recurring tests — places people go back to, on purpose, to find out something true about their own legs, engines, and judgment against terrain that was cut long before there was anyone around to be tested by it. That instinct — return rather than completion, the mountain as something to keep visiting rather than something to have finished — belongs, as this book

will keep discovering, most of all to the man this whole compendium is dedicated to.

A different kind of counting

Return, for a moment, to the copper bangles, not because this book has anything new to add to the fact of them but because the fact bears a second look from an angle other than the accountant's. More than twenty of them, worn stacked and gathered one country and one road at a time — the natural reading, and the one this Part has already offered, is a private ledger, a discipline of precise counting carried from the auditing firm into the travelling life it seemed to have nothing to do with. But a bangle is a poor ledger by any strict accounting standard: it records that a place was visited, not when, not for how long, not what happened there. What it keeps is cruder and, in its way, more honest than a ledger — presence without detail, the bare fact of having stood somewhere long enough to acquire the object that marked it, stripped of every other claim a more systematic record would have insisted on making. An auditor spends a career refusing to let a number stand in for the transaction behind it. A traveller wearing twenty bangles has done something closer to the opposite: let a single object stand in, permanently and without elaboration, for however many weeks or months a particular stretch of Africa actually took out of his life. It is not the accountant's instinct surviving intact into the travelling life. It is the accountant's instinct answered by its own opposite, worn on the same arm.

Pop travelled with him in the same register — presence without elaboration, a companion whose entire function was to have been there, documented, once, in a passport photograph that this book has already named as a detail earned rather than played for laughs. Between the bangles and the mannequin, Bakkes built two entirely different systems for proving a place had been real to him: one mineral and cumulative, added to across decades until the arm itself became a kind of map; one singular and constant, a companion who did not accumulate but simply persisted, present in every count regardless of which country the road happened to be crossing that month. Neither

system kept the kind of record his own professional training would have recognised as adequate. Both kept exactly the kind of record a “professional hobo,” his own chosen title, would have wanted: proof that mattered to him and to no auditor anywhere.

Every road eventually comes back here

It is worth being precise about how large a share of this book’s total ground actually touches this one departure gate, because the pattern is easy to state as a passing observation and easy to underestimate until the full list is set out together.

Riaan Manser’s circumnavigation left Cape Town in September 2003 and returned to it at the end of 2005 — the same city bracketing both ends of a two-year, two-month, roughly 36,500-to-37,000- kilometre journey around the entire continent. Keegan Longueira’s record-setting Cairo-to-Cape-Town ride, in early 2015, finished at the V&A Waterfront, within sight of the same mountain this Part has just spent several pages describing. Mark Beaumont’s record, ten weeks later over the same Cairo-to-Cape-Town line, finished in the same harbour. Three of this book’s six named journeys — half the total roster this compendium covers — used Cape Town as either a starting line, a finish line, or both. That is not a coincidence a compendium organised by road can simply note and move past. It says something specific about the city’s position at the absolute southern tip of the landmass this book is otherwise concerned with crossing: there is, quite literally, nowhere further south to start from or arrive at, which makes Cape Town less a city with an unusually good view of a mountain and more the one fixed point every other point in this book’s geography is ultimately measured against.

The coast is next. It has its own argument to make, and — for once in this compendium — no single name to put against the crossing of it, until this book’s dedicatee supplies one.

Part II: The Skeleton Coast & the Namib

A coast with a name it earned

Sailors gave the Skeleton Coast its name, and sailors do not name things lightly when the thing in question has killed their colleagues.

The stretch of coastline running along Namibia's Atlantic side is one of the most reliably dangerous pieces of shoreline on the planet, for reasons that have nothing to do with storms in the way most people picture them. The danger here is fog, and it is fog produced by a mechanism precise enough to be taught in a physical geography class: the cold Benguela Current, sweeping up from the Southern Ocean, meets warm air off the Namib's furnace-hot dunes, and the temperature differential condenses moisture into a fog bank that can sit offshore for days, thick enough to erase a coastline from a ship's sightline entirely. Add a current that runs parallel to shore rather than helpfully away from it, and a coast that is mostly featureless sand rather than the cliffs or lights that give a lost ship something to triangulate against, and the result is a stretch of ocean that has been swallowing vessels since long before anyone was keeping reliable count.

The wrecks are not a folkloric flourish. They are still there, rusting in dry air at a rate that would embarrass a more humid coastline — hulls sitting stranded hundreds of metres from the current shoreline in places, because the coast itself moves, sand accreting and the sea's edge shifting over the decades since a given ship ran aground.

Diamond-mining operations along stretches of this coast, sealed for most of the twentieth century behind mining-company access restrictions before parts of it were folded into national park protection, kept much of the wreck field more intact than open tourism would likely have allowed. The result is a shoreline that functions as an open-air maritime graveyard, catalogued more by insurers and salvage historians over the decades than by any single narrator, because no single expedition produced the record — the wrecks accumulated the way the coast's name did, one disaster at a time, over more than a century.

The diamond-mining restriction deserves more than a passing clause, because it is the reason so much of this coastline survives today in something close to the condition it was in when a given ship went down. Diamonds were found in the sand along Namibia's southern coastline early in the twentieth century, in deposits rich enough and shallow enough that the colonial and later South African administrations sealed a vast strip of the coast — extending well beyond the diamond fields themselves, as a security buffer as much as an economic one — behind permit requirements so strict that generations of Namibians lived their whole lives within sight of a coastline they were never allowed to walk. The German word attached to the restricted zone, *Sperrgebiet*, translates simply as “forbidden area,” and it did exactly what the name promised: it kept prospectors out, it kept tourists out, and, as an unplanned side effect that outlasted the mining company's original intent, it kept salvage crews and scrap dealers away from wrecks that would otherwise have been stripped for their metal within a generation of running aground. A coastline sealed for one reason — guarding a gem field — ended up preserving an entirely different kind of asset by pure accident of overlapping geography, and it is worth sitting with the irony: the same bureaucratic wall that impoverished the scope of an ordinary Namibian's own coastline access is the reason a modern visitor can still find a century-old hull sitting almost undisturbed in the dunes. Restriction, in this one case, did the work that no conservation body had to build from scratch.

The mining did not stay confined to the strip of coastline where it began. Offshore diamond extraction along this same stretch developed,

over the decades since, into an industry that dredges the seabed itself rather than the beach — vessels working just beyond the surf zone the ships behind them once wrecked in, pulling the same geological inheritance up from underwater gravel that erosion had, over millions of years, carried down from the interior highlands and deposited along this coast in the first place. It is a strange closing of a loop: the rivers that cut the Namib's interior plateau over geological time carried the diamonds to the coast; the same cold Benguela Current that wrecks ships also drives the longshore drift that concentrated those diamonds into minable deposits along specific stretches of beach and seabed. The coast's two defining industries — shipwreck and diamond — turn out to share a mechanism, the current, even though nothing about a stranded hull and a diamond concession looks, at first glance, like the same story.

A restriction of this size does not maintain itself, and for most of the century in question, someone was actively maintaining it. The *Spergebiet* was patrolled, fenced in places, and treated with the seriousness a mining operation gives to a vault, because that is more or less what it was: a vault the size of a small country, its contents scattered through the sand rather than sealed behind a single door. Entry required a permit naming the visitor, the purpose, and usually an escort, and the default answer to anything falling outside mining, government, or a narrowly defined scientific errand was no. That default, held for the better part of a hundred years, is the actual mechanism behind the coastline's preservation — not benign neglect, but an enforced absence of exactly the kind of casual foot traffic that strips a wreck of its fittings within a generation. The same fence that kept an ordinary Namibian off a beach within sight of home kept the scrap dealer off it too, and a ship's iron stopped being worth the risk of getting caught retrieving it. Access has loosened since Namibian independence in 1990, with sections of the old zone reclassified into national park and conservation status and a narrow, permitted tourism trade let in along stretches of coast that spent decades as blank space on an ordinary map — a loosening recent and partial enough that the coastline's long closure, not its short opening, is still the condition that shaped what a visitor finds there today.

There is an irony worth sitting with once more, from a different angle than the one already named: a national park cannot retroactively un-restrict a coastline into existence. It can only inherit whatever the restriction before it happened to preserve. The Skeleton Coast National Park, and the Sperrgebiet's partial conversion into a permitted diamond-area tourist route, are both living off a closure that none of the people who benefit from it today had any hand in imposing, and that very few of the people who endured it would likely call, in hindsight, a fair trade.

The park's own founding dates are worth setting down plainly, because they show how recently the coastline's protection caught up with its restriction. Skeleton Coast National Park was proclaimed in 1971, running roughly 500 kilometres of shoreline from the Ugab River north to the Kunene, the river that marks the border with Angola — a strip about 40 kilometres deep, protected as parkland rather than as a mining concession, but only after the mining-era restriction had already done the work of keeping it intact for the better part of a century. Namib-Naukluft National Park, further south and inland, has an older and more piecemeal ancestry: it was assembled in 1979 out of two separate reserves, the Namib Desert Park first proclaimed in 1907 and the Naukluft Mountain Zebra Park set aside in 1968, then enlarged again in 1986 to take in a further stretch of the old diamond area. The combined park that resulted is, by area, the largest national park in Africa — bigger than Switzerland, cited in most sources at somewhere near 50,000 square kilometres — which is itself a strange inheritance for a stretch of desert that spent most of its administrative life defined by what it forbade rather than by what it protected.

Two separate parks with two separate founding stories still left a gap between them on the map, and the gap was not closed until 2010, decades after Namibian independence, when Dorob National Park was proclaimed to cover the stretch of coastline around Swakopmund and Walvis Bay that neither the Skeleton Coast park to its north nor Namib-Naukluft to its south had ever formally included. Dorob's proclamation joined the two older parks, and the former Sperrgebiet further south again, into a single unbroken run of protected coastline reaching from the Kunene River in the north to the Orange River

in the south — very nearly the entire length of Namibia's Atlantic edge, some 1,500-odd kilometres, informally described in the press coverage of the announcement as the whole coast of the country becoming, in effect, one park. It is worth being precise about what that description means and does not mean: each of the four component areas — Tsau //Khaeb, as the old Sperrgebiet was renamed on its own conversion to national park status in 2008, Namib-Naukluft, Dorob, and Skeleton Coast — kept its own separate legal proclamation and its own administrative boundary. What changed in 2010 was not a merger on paper so much as the closing of the last unprotected seam between four neighbours, so that a coastline the German and South African administrations had spent a century managing by exclusion became, without ever being redrawn as a single unit, functionally continuous for the first time.

Skeleton Coast National Park's own internal management still carries the shape of the restriction it grew out of, more than half a century after its proclamation. The park has long been run in two distinct tiers rather than as one open expanse: a southern section reachable by an ordinary self-drive visitor holding a day permit, with a small number of designated campsites, and a northern wilderness section, toward the Angolan border, accessible only by air to a handful of licensed concession operators and their guests. A visitor with a rented vehicle and a permit can see one half of the park this Part describes. The other half is still, in practice, gated behind exactly the kind of controlled, escorted access the *Sperrgebiet* enforced for diamonds a century earlier — the same administrative instinct, applied now to wilderness rather than to gemstones, and just as effective at keeping casual foot traffic off ground the coastline's whole preservation has always depended on.

A coastline governed before it was known

The *Sperrgebiet*'s founding did not happen in isolation. It was one late instrument of a colonial administration that had, for the preceding two decades, been struggling with the more basic problem of how to govern a coastline it could not reliably see. Germany declared a

protectorate over the territory in 1884 — the colony that would be administered as German South West Africa until the First World War — and inherited, along with the interior, a coastline the fog had already been erasing from European charts for three centuries before a single German official set foot on it. Colonial administration depends on the state's ability to know where its own border runs, and this was a border that changed its own visibility by the hour. Survey ships sent to fix the coastline precisely, the way an ambitious young protectorate wanted every frontier fixed, ran directly into the same fog bank that had already claimed the vessels this Part opened by describing, and early German charts of the Skeleton Coast carry the marks of that difficulty: stretches of shoreline surveyed adequately, and stretches left approximate, redrawn, or simply marked as unreliable across successive revisions, in a way the colony's more legible inland borders were not. A protectorate that prided itself on administrative thoroughness inland — the railways, the land grants, the district boundaries — met, at its own western edge, a coast that refused to hold still long enough to be mapped the way the interior had been mapped.

The administrative habits that grew up around that difficulty outlasted German rule itself, which ended in the territory during the First World War when South African forces occupied it, and persisted, in modified form, through the South African mandate and administration that followed for most of the twentieth century. A coastline too dangerous and too poorly charted to patrol conventionally is, from a governing authority's point of view, most easily managed by declaring it closed rather than by policing it open — which is one further way of describing what the *Sperrgebiet* eventually did on a grander, resource-driven scale, decades after the earliest colonial surveyors had already learned, the hard way, that this was not a coastline that rewarded a government's usual instinct to chart, license, and open. The restriction that preserved the wrecks this Part has already described was not the first time this shoreline had been managed by exclusion rather than by presence; it was the largest and longest-lasting instance of a pattern the coast itself had been teaching its administrators since the eighteen-eighties.

There is a particular cruelty to how this coastline kills that is worth

naming plainly, because it distinguishes the Skeleton Coast from almost every other maritime hazard this book could have chosen to open a Part with. A reef kills fast, in the moment of impact. A storm kills through violence the survivors can at least understand, afterward, as a storm. What the Skeleton Coast does, more often than either, is strand a ship intact — run it gently aground on a sandbar in fog thick enough that the crew often did not know they had grounded until the hull stopped answering the helm — and then leave the survivors on a shoreline where the more immediate danger, once the wreck itself is behind them, is simply the desert waiting on the other side of the dune line: no fresh water, no vegetation worth the name, and a coastline so remote and so uniformly hostile that walking toward help was, for many recorded wrecks, a bet no more promising than staying with the ship. That is the specific, double-jointed cruelty the name preserves: a coast that does not merely wreck ships, but strands the people who survive the wrecking on a shoreline built to finish what the fog started.

Before satellite positioning existed, a ship's captain running this coast at night or in fog had almost nothing reliable to navigate by, which compounds the geometry already working against him. Dead reckoning — estimating position from speed, heading, and elapsed time since the last confirmed fix — degrades over distance, and a coastline this straight and this uniform gives a navigator no promontory, no distinctive headland, no lighthouse of any real density to correct against once the estimate starts to drift. A small, compounding navigational error, multiplied over days at sea in poor visibility, is the ordinary, unglamorous mechanism behind a great many of the wrecks this shoreline holds — not a single dramatic miscalculation, but the slow accumulation of a small one. The coast's other well-known residents make the same point from the opposite direction: enormous colonies of Cape fur seals still gather at points along this shoreline in numbers that run into the hundreds of thousands, drawn by the cold, nutrient-rich water the Benguela Current pushes north — the identical current mechanism responsible for the fog, the diamonds, and the wrecks turns out to be what makes this one of the richest marine environments on the subcontinent, feeding a population of animals large

enough to be visible, en masse, from a considerable distance out at sea. The same current, in other words, kills ships, buries diamonds, and feeds a colony of seals numbering in the hundreds of thousands, all through the identical piece of oceanography — which is as good a lesson as this book will find anywhere in its pages in how a single physical mechanism, indifferent to which outcome it produces, can be simultaneously a graveyard and a nursery.

The fog itself keeps something closer to a daily schedule than its reputation as a formless hazard suggests, which made it, in its own way, more dangerous rather than less. It tends to form overnight and burn back from the coast only once the day's heat has built enough to lift it, meaning a captain running this coast before dawn faced worse visibility, as a matter of ordinary routine, than the same captain running it in the mid-afternoon — a predictable rhythm that should, in principle, have made the hazard easier to plan around, and did not, because a sailing ship or an early steamer had limited say in what hour it happened to be passing a given stretch of coast. The rhythm punished bad timing rather than bad seamanship, which is a harder kind of danger to guard against than a hazard that simply requires skill: no amount of experience corrects for arriving at the wrong hour of an otherwise well-understood cycle.

A traveller crossing this same coast today with satellite positioning in a pocket experiences a version of the hazard the sailors who named it never had available to them, and the difference is worth being precise about rather than simply asserting that modern navigation “solved” the problem. GPS answers the question dead reckoning could not — where, exactly, am I — with a precision no Victorian-era captain could have imagined. It does nothing at all about the fog itself, which still drops visibility on the coast road to a few car-lengths on the mornings it forms, and it does nothing about the sand beneath a vehicle's wheels or a cyclist's tyres, which still requires the same attentive, moment-to-moment judgment the coast has always demanded of the person moving across it. What has changed is not the hazard. It is only the traveller's ability to know exactly where the hazard has put them, which is a real and considerable improvement, and a much smaller one than it sounds.

The desert that meets the sea

Inland from the coast, the Namib does something deserts rarely manage: it produces genuine, measurable, quantifiable wonder without needing a single human story to carry it.

The dunes at Sossusvlei, well south of the Skeleton Coast proper but part of the same desert system that runs the length of Namibia's coastal belt, are among the tallest in the world — figures in the region of 300 to 400 metres are commonly cited for the largest of them, red-orange from iron oxide in sand that has been accumulating and shifting for millions of years, driven by wind patterns as consistent, in their own way, as the fog offshore. The Namib as a whole is frequently described as the oldest desert on Earth, its arid conditions sustained for tens of millions of years by the same cold-current mechanism that produces the coastal fog — the Benguela's chilling effect on the coastal air suppresses rainfall inland as reliably as it produces shipwrecks at the shoreline, two very different disasters generated by the identical piece of physical geography.

The sand itself has a journey behind it longer and stranger than the dunes' own slow migration across the desert floor. Much of it did not originate anywhere near this coastline. It was carried down from the interior highlands by river systems, chiefly the Orange River far to the south, over millions of years, out into the Atlantic, and then swept back north along the coast by the same longshore current the Benguela drives — the identical current that concentrates the diamonds and drowns the ships — to be flung ashore and picked up by onshore winds that pile it, grain by grain, into the dune fields a visitor sees today. A dune at Sossusvlei is, in the most literal sense, recycled interior Africa: rock worn down a thousand kilometres inland, walked by a river to the sea, stolen by a current, and handed to the wind. The red colour that makes the older dunes so photogenic is itself a kind of geological clock — iron minerals in the sand slowly oxidising, rusting in place over centuries once a dune stops migrating and its surface stabilises, so that the reddest dunes are reliably the oldest, and the paler ones nearer the fringes of the system are, by the same logic, the youngest arrivals in a process that has never really stopped.

Fog that kills ships offshore also, in one of the coast's stranger mercies, supports a band of specially adapted desert life a little inland — plants and insects that have evolved to harvest moisture directly from condensation on their own bodies, a survival strategy so specific to this exact stretch of coastline that biologists studying it have had, essentially, nowhere else on Earth to look for a comparison. It is a landscape that kills at the shoreline and, a short distance inland, teaches its residents a way to drink the same fog that does the killing.

The best-known of those adaptations belongs to a beetle rather than to anything larger or more photogenic, which is itself worth noting: the desert's most efficient answer to its own aridity is an insect small enough to miss underfoot. Certain of the Namib's darkling beetles climb the crest of a dune at dawn, when the fog bank is at its thickest, and tilt their bodies into the wind at a precise angle — head down, abdomen raised — so that the moisture condensing out of the air runs down their own hardened wing-cases and drips directly into their mouths. No pooling on the sand, no competing with a hundred other creatures for the same puddle: the beetle has turned its own exoskeleton into a piece of purpose-built plumbing, and it does this only here, only in fog produced by the same current mechanism that runs the length of this coast and wrecks the ships offshore. A second, less photogenic species solves the identical problem without ever using its own body as the collecting surface at all. A smaller dune beetle in the genus *Lepidochora* digs shallow trenches across the slip-face, set crosswise to the fog-bearing wind, so that condensation gathers preferentially on the raised ridge of sand thrown up on either side of the furrow and trickles down into the trench floor, where the beetle then walks the length of its own excavation and drinks what has pooled there. Where the head-stander turns its wing-cases into plumbing, the trench-digger engineers the dune itself into the collecting instrument, and does it before the fog has even arrived — the trench has to be dug in advance of the very weather it is built to catch. The Namib's other signature survivor, the welwitschia plant, takes a stranger and slower approach to the identical problem: a single specimen can live for over a thousand years on two leaves that never fall and never stop growing, splitting and fraying with age into the tattered, wind-shredded ribbons

a first-time visitor usually assumes are several dead plants tangled together rather than one living one drawing on the same fog moisture through pores across its leaf surface. Between the beetle's dawn ritual and the welwitschia's slow-motion persistence, the same fog that this Part opened by blaming for a century of shipwrecks turns out to be the entire reason anything lives here at all — the desert's one dependable form of water, arriving by the same mechanism that makes the coast beside it a graveyard.

The mechanism behind the mechanism

This Part has already leaned on “the Benguela Current” as an explanation for the fog, the desert's aridity, the diamonds, and the seals, and the phrase has done a great deal of work without yet being opened up. It is worth being more precise about what actually produces a current cold enough to do all four of those things at once, because the answer is not simply “cold water flowing north” — it is a specific physical process with its own name, upwelling, and it is the upwelling, more than the current's direction alone, that explains why this stretch of ocean behaves the way it does.

Prevailing south-easterly winds along this coast blow roughly parallel to the shoreline, and a wind blowing parallel to a coastline, combined with the Earth's own rotation, pushes surface water not along the coast but away from it, out to sea — a deflection with its own name, Ekman transport, that holds true at every rotating body of water on the planet and is not unique to this coast at all. What is unique to this coast, or close to it, is what happens to fill the gap that departing surface water leaves behind: colder water rises from considerable depth to replace it, hauling up, along with the cold itself, a load of nutrients that have settled toward the ocean floor over time and would otherwise stay there, out of reach of anything living near the surface. That rising water is the upwelling proper, and it is colder than the surface water it replaces for a simple reason — deep water has not been warmed by the sun in the way surface water constantly is — which means the Benguela's chill is not simply water arriving from a colder latitude to the south, the way a casual description of “a cold current” implies,

but water arriving from a colder *depth*, a few hundred metres down, regardless of the latitude it started at.

The nutrients that upwelling drags to the surface are the entire reason this stretch of ocean supports the fur seal colonies, the fish stocks beneath them, and the fishing and offshore industries this Part has already touched on: nutrient-rich, cold, upwelled water feeds the phytoplankton at the base of the food chain in concentrations that a warmer, nutrient-poor tropical sea simply cannot match, which is why an unusually large fraction of the world's major fisheries sit on upwelling coastlines like this one rather than on the more comfortable, warmer waters a holidaymaker might associate with abundant sea life. The same mechanism that seems, at first telling, to explain only fog and cold water turns out to be the reason the coast can feed hundreds of thousands of seals at all. And because the wind that drives the upwelling is itself seasonal and variable rather than constant, the upwelling strengthens and weakens across the year in patterns coastal scientists have mapped in some detail, which means the fog this Part opened with is not a fixed condition of the coastline so much as the visible signature of a wind-driven process that has its own calendar, its own good years and lean years, running underneath the more visible drama of wrecks and dunes the whole time.

What a dune field hides beneath its surface

A visitor who sees only the Sossusvlei dunes' surface — the postcard image of a red slip-face against a blue sky, a lone camel-thorn tree standing dead in a white clay pan at the dune field's centre — is seeing the least interesting part of what is happening there. The pans themselves, of which Deadvlei is the best known, are not simply low ground between dunes. They are the beds of ancient, ephemeral rivers that once flowed here, before the advancing dune field itself dammed and eventually strangled them, leaving behind a hard, cracked clay floor on which the camel-thorn trees that grew along the old riverbank still stand, centuries after the water that fed them stopped arriving. The trees are not petrified in the mineral sense; the desert air is simply too dry to let them rot. They stand scorched black by sun rather than

fire, root systems still anchored in clay too hard and too starved of moisture for decomposition to do its ordinary work — a forest that died of thirst and was denied, by the same dryness that killed it, even the mercy of falling down.

Below the visible dune crests, the sand itself hosts a narrower and stranger community than the beetle and the welwitschia alone suggest. Geckos endemic to this dune field have evolved partially translucent, webbed feet suited to a life spent almost entirely on or under loose, shifting sand rather than on rock or soil; some species “swim” beneath the surface of a dune face to escape the worst of the daytime heat, submerging into sand the way another animal might submerge into water. Other insects and small reptiles here practise what biologists studying this exact dune system call thermal dancing — lifting alternate feet off sand hot enough to injure tissue on contact, in a constant, involuntary shuffle that has no equivalent need anywhere the ground itself does not threaten to cook the creature standing on it. None of this is visible from a vehicle track or a viewpoint car park, which is precisely the point this Part keeps returning to in different forms: the Namib rewards exactly the kind of unhurried, close attention that a traveller moving fast across this ground has the least opportunity to give it, and punishes nothing so much as the assumption that a landscape this apparently empty has nothing more to show.

The desert’s temperature swing is a hazard in its own right, separate from the coast’s fog and worth naming on its own terms, because it is the hazard that meets a traveller once the fog has been left behind on the inland roads running toward towns like Kamanjab. A cloudless desert sky, with none of the coastal moisture to trap heat after sunset, allows the ground to radiate the day’s warmth back into open air with almost nothing to slow it, so that a stretch of gravel plain that reached dangerous highs at midday can fall to genuinely cold temperatures within a few hours of dark — a swing of several tens of degrees between a desert afternoon and its own night that a traveller carrying gear suited only to the daytime heat learns about, if they have not been warned, the hard way. It is a different mechanism from the coast’s fog entirely, driven by clear air rather than moist air, and it produces an inverse kind of danger: where the coast kills by hiding the ground from a

ship's eye, the interior desert kills, when it kills, by the plain arithmetic of exposure across a temperature range most temperate-climate travellers have never had to plan a single day's clothing around.

North toward the Kunene, the boundary this Part has already used to mark the park's own edge, the desert stops being uniformly waterless in a way worth naming before Kamanjab's traveller arrives. The Hoanib and the Hoarusib, the ephemeral rivers running down from the northern highlands toward the coast, hold no visible flow for most of a given year and still carry enough moisture beneath their dry, sandy beds to sustain a thin green line of camel-thorn and mopane trees the whole distance to the sea — a linear oasis threading through open desert, invisible from any distance and, up close, the only reason large mammals can live on this ground at all. Elephants range along these dry riverbeds in numbers small enough to be locally famous rather than merely present: the same species as the savannah elephants elsewhere on the continent, genetically, but behaviourally adapted over generations to exactly this river-line existence — smaller herds, longer daily distances covered between water and browse, and a documented tolerance for going several days between drinks that an elephant living beside the Chobe or the Zambezi, further along this book's route, has never had to learn. The same logic that lets a !nara melon persist on nothing but the Kuiseb's underground moisture lets an elephant persist on the Hoanib's, at a scale several orders of magnitude larger and considerably harder to miss from a Land Rover's window.

Bakkes: the man who closes this Part's gap

Every other Part in this book opens on the road and then admits a named traveller who crossed it. This one, for a long stretch of its research, had no traveller to admit — a gap flagged and left open rather than filled with an invented account, because that is the discipline this book holds itself to. It closes, in the end, on the same name that opens the book.

Johan Bakkes travelled through Kamanjab, a small town on the edge of the Skeleton Coast's inland approach, on more than one occasion

across a working travelling life that ranged the length and breadth of Namibia. Kamanjab sits at a kind of hinge in the country's geography — inland enough that the coastal fog never reaches it, but positioned as one of the last reliable settlements a traveller passes before the road gives way to the emptier country running toward the coast proper, the sort of place that exists because someone crossing this stretch of Namibia needs fuel, water, and a bed before the distances get serious. It is not a headline destination in the way the dunes or the shipwrecks are. It is a working town on a hard road, which is exactly the kind of place this book's dedicatee gravitated toward and the kind of place a faster traveller, by necessity, only passes through. His own research method — the tavern over the monument, the bar that tells a town's soul faster than its landmarks do — has no better proving ground in this entire compendium than a town like Kamanjab, which offers a passing cyclist or motorcyclist almost nothing to photograph and, on Bakkes's own account of how he worked, considerably more to listen to.

It is worth imagining, briefly, what he actually looked like arriving in a town like this, because the detail is sourced and because it says something about how he moved through a country like Namibia that a plain travel itinerary cannot. He travelled with an inflatable mannequin companion he called Pop, who carried her own passport — a genuine, documented fact about him rather than an invented flourish, and one this book uses once, here, precisely, rather than working it for cheap running comedy across every Part he appears in. He wore, across the same decades, more than twenty copper bangles collected one country and one crossing at a time, so that by the later years of his travelling life his own forearm carried a rough, wearable ledger of exactly how much ground he had covered — a ledger kept on the body instead of on paper, which suits a man whose books never gave this compendium a systematic date to work from. A traveller arriving in Kamanjab by Land Rover convoy or by racing bicycle would have been, to the town, a familiar kind of visitor: fast, purposeful, gone by morning. A man on foot or by local bus, wearing that many bangles and carrying that particular companion, asking after the bar rather than the view, was something else entirely, and it is not hard to understand why the

shebeens of a town like this had more to tell him than they would have told almost anyone else this book follows.

Two of his working credentials, named already in this book's opening Part, earn a second look here, because Namibia is the ground where they would have mattered most concretely rather than biographically. He served two years as a captain in the old South African Defence Force before any of the rest of his travelling life began, and South West Africa, as Namibia was then known and administered, was a theatre that army knew intimately — a young officer of that era did not learn border country and remote terrain in the abstract. Whatever Bakkes carried forward from those two years into a life of crossing exactly this kind of country, this book cannot specify further than the plain fact of the service; but a man who later made his living qualifying, in 1990, as a tour guide and running Induku Safaris was, by then, adding a second, civilian layer of exactly the competence a region like the Skeleton Coast's approach roads demand — route-finding in featureless country, water discipline, the judgment to know when a stretch of gravel track has gone from merely rough to genuinely dangerous. Kamanjab's shebeens gave him the town's soul. The military years and the guiding business, taken together, are the less visible reason he could reach a town like Kamanjab at all, on the roads and by the means he chose, without the support infrastructure a Land Rover convoy or a record-chasing cyclist would bring with them instead.

Namibia held a particular pull for him — not the pull of a single expedition completed once and photographed for the record, but the pull of ground worth returning to. Nowhere does that show more plainly than at the Fish River Canyon, in the country's arid south: Bakkes completed the crossing of it nineteen times. Not once, as a feat to be checked off. Nineteen times, across years, the way a person returns to a piece of music they have not finished listening to. Nineteen is not a number this book found on a single triumphant page. It is the kind of number that only exists because someone kept a rough tally of their own habit, and the habit is the point: a canyon crossed nineteen times is not a record in the sense Longueira and Beaumont chase in Part VI. It is closer to what this book's opening pages promised — a journey undertaken not to be endured once but returned to, deliberately, as

its own reward.

The Fish River Canyon itself is worth describing on the terms that made nineteen crossings a plausible ambition rather than a strange one. It is among the largest canyons in Africa, a deep gorge cut by the Fish River through arid highland over an immense span of geological time, its floor reachable only by a multi-day hiking route that demands the hiker carry everything — water above all, in a landscape that offers almost none of its own outside the river itself. It is not a place a person crosses accidentally, or once, without meaning to. Doing it nineteen times is a statement about what the canyon gave back for the effort, made not in words but in the simple, repeated fact of returning.

Two separate ages are visible in the canyon's walls at once, which is part of what makes a single crossing feel like more ground covered than the distance alone accounts for. The uppermost layers are ancient sedimentary rock, laid down in shallow seas hundreds of millions of years before anything resembling a mammal existed. Beneath them, exposed only where the river has cut deepest, sit still older basement rocks, folded and metamorphosed long before the sediment above them was ever deposited — a canyon wall that is, in effect, two different geological stories stacked one atop the other, with an immense gap in time between them that the rock itself preserves as a visible seam. A hiker descending from the rim to the river floor is not simply losing altitude. They are walking backward through a longer stretch of the planet's history than almost any other single day's walk in this book can offer, and doing it nineteen times, on Bakkes's own tally, means descending through that same seam of deep time nineteen separate occasions across a working life — a repetition that would read as monotonous applied to almost any other kind of terrain, and reads instead, applied to this one, as the closest thing the book can point to as a private ritual.

The canyon enforces its own discipline on anyone who wants to complete it, and the discipline is worth naming because it is the reason “nineteen times” carries the weight it does. The hike runs across several days through a gorge with no resupply point along its length and no exit until the far end — a hiker who starts committed to finishing,

because there is no shortcut back to the rim partway through. Access is seasonal, restricted to the cooler months of the year, because summer heat in the gorge's floor rises to a level that turns the same walk from an endurance challenge into a genuine medical risk; the canyon, in effect, closes itself for roughly half of every year regardless of what any single hiker might want. A rough minimum-group-size requirement has long been enforced by the authorities managing the route, on the reasoning that a solitary hiker in trouble, days from the nearest exit, has no one to send for help. None of that is incidental colour. It means every one of Bakkes's nineteen crossings had to fall inside the same narrow seasonal window every other hiker's single attempt also has to fall inside, which makes nineteen less a number picked at random and more a number that had to compete, year after year, against a calendar that only offered him the chance a few months at a time.

Consider what nineteen actually implies about the years it must have taken to accumulate. A crossing of this scale is not undertaken casually or often within a single season — permits, water caching, physical preparation, and simple logistics mean a committed hiker returns to a route like this once a year at most, and most people who complete it once consider the achievement finished. Nineteen crossings, at even a generous pace of one or two a year, describes the better part of two decades of a single man's travelling life spent returning, deliberately, to the same nine-day walk through the same gorge — not because the canyon changed each time, but because he did, or because the canyon offered something on the fifteenth crossing that the fourth had not, in a way this book's sourcing cannot specify further without inventing what it does not know. What it can say, honestly, is only the number itself, and let the number carry the weight it carries.

The difference between a canyon crossed once, for a photograph and a completed checklist, and a canyon crossed nineteen times, is the entire difference this book's dedication is built to honour. A traveller who crosses a landscape once is measuring themselves against it. A traveller who crosses it nineteen times has stopped measuring and started, in whatever sense the word can bear here, simply living alongside it — an intimacy with terrain that this compendium's other, faster

travellers, by the very nature of what they were attempting, had no time to develop with any single stretch of ground they crossed.

Further north, in the same country, Bakkes travelled the Kuiseb River — the dry-river system that marks one of the Namib's significant ecological boundaries, dividing the gravel plains to its north from the great dune sea to its south, a boundary so effective that certain plant and insect species found on one side of the Kuiseb do not cross to the other. It is exactly the kind of ground his own travel philosophy was built for: not a headline crossing with a start line and a finish line, but a region known intimately enough, over enough visits, that its internal boundaries — the ones that would mean nothing to a traveller passing through once — became legible to him.

The Kuiseb earns its role as a boundary through behaviour rather than appearance: for most of the year it presents as a dry bed, a wide sandy channel with no visible water at all, indistinguishable at a glance from the gravel plains around it — and then, on the rare occasions when rain in the distant interior highlands sends a flash flood down its length, it becomes, briefly and dramatically, an actual river again, enough to reset the boundary it enforces the rest of the year. That intermittency is the whole mechanism: a linear barrier that is usually invisible and occasionally violent is a stranger kind of frontier than a mountain range or a coastline, because it asks a traveller to understand not just where the line runs but when it is actually a line at all. The river has long supported the Topnaar people along its course, a community whose relationship to the !nara melon — a plant found almost nowhere outside this river's immediate catchment, harvested as a food source adapted specifically to the boundary conditions the Kuiseb creates — is itself a small, sourced illustration of the same principle this whole Part keeps returning to: ground known well enough, over enough time, yields a different order of understanding than ground merely crossed.

A boundary that is invisible for most of the year and violent for the rest of it asks something different of every mode of travel that meets it, which is worth spelling out because the Kuiseb is one of the few places in this Part where the contrast can be drawn without leaving Namibia at all. Manser's bicycle, further south on the coast, met a

hazard that announced itself continuously — wind, fog, sand underfoot — the whole time he was in the country. A vehicle convoy crossing the Kuiseb's dry bed on the composite overland route this book's later Parts describe would, on all but the rarest of days, simply drive across a wide gravel flat and never register that it had crossed a boundary at all, because a dry riverbed with no water in it does not look, from a driver's seat, like a frontier. Only a traveller who returns to the same ground often enough to be caught there once by the flash flood, or to be told by people who live along it when and why the water comes, ever learns that the gravel flat is a river wearing a disguise for eleven months out of twelve. Bakkes's own travel method — slow, repeated, conversational — was suited to exactly that kind of boundary in a way no faster crossing of the same ground could be.

He did not write, so far as the sourced record shows, a systematic account of dates for these Namibian travels the way this book can date Manser's departure or Longueira's finish. That absence is itself consistent with everything else known about how he worked: his books are essay collections, impressionistic and structured around theme and encounter rather than a ledger of days and kilometres, which is a curious thing for a man who spent his working life as an accountant, and perhaps the clearest sign of where the ledger stopped and the life began. What can be said plainly, and is said here because it is true and sourced, is this: Kamanjab, on the edge of the Skeleton Coast; the Fish River Canyon, nineteen times; the Kuiseb River, known well enough to matter. That is enough to close this Part's gap honestly, without inventing the year or the season or the company he kept on any one crossing.

Riaan Manser's coastal leg

Riaan Manser's circumnavigation of the continent by bicycle — departed Cape Town in September 2003, returned at the end of 2005, roughly 36,500 to 37,000 kilometres through thirty-four countries with a coastline — followed Namibia's Atlantic edge as one leg of that much longer journey. The Skeleton Coast, for Manser, was not the record. It was a stretch of it, one of the harder ones by every account

of the trip, folded into a circumnavigation whose full shape belongs to Part VI.

What this Part can honestly say about his crossing here is only what the sourcing supports: that the coastal leg through Namibia was part of the route he rode, at his sustained average of roughly ninety kilometres a day, and that a coastline capable of stranding ships for a century does not become gentler for a bicycle. A cyclist on that stretch has no hull between himself and the fog, no ballast against the wind that comes off the Benguela's cold water onto sand still radiating the previous day's heat — a stretch of road that, on a bicycle, is not scenery so much as a sustained negotiation with a coastline that has never pretended to be forgiving.

It is worth setting this leg against the scale of the whole circumnavigation it belonged to, because the proportion matters. Namibia's coastline is a fraction of the roughly 36,500 to 37,000 kilometres Manser's full route covered — a matter of days within a journey measured in years — and yet it is one of the stretches that recurs, across accounts of the trip, as among the harder legs, which says something about how much a single difficult coastline can weigh against an otherwise much longer and more varied route. A circumnavigation is not evenly difficult across its whole length; it has legs that a rider remembers specifically, afterward, out of the hundreds of days that made up the total, and the Skeleton Coast, on the sourced record, was one of Manser's.

A bicycle is a mechanical object built from close-tolerance moving parts, and it is worth being plain about what a coastline like this does to those parts, quite apart from what it does to the rider straddling them. Salt-laden fog settling nightly on an exposed chain and derailleur does the same corrosive work on a bicycle's drivetrain that it does on a stranded ship's hull, only faster, because a chain's surface area to metal-thickness ratio invites rust in a way a ship's plating does not. A cyclist crossing this stretch is not simply enduring wind and cold; he is running, every day, against a landscape that actively degrades the machine he depends on to keep moving at all, in a way no other stretch of Manser's circumnavigation — dry heat, tar road, even

mountain grades — quite replicates. The fog that erased a shipping lane for a hundred years erases, on a smaller and more immediate scale, a cyclist's sightline too: a rider moving at even a modest speed into a fog bank thick enough to hide an oncoming vehicle is navigating by something closer to instinct and memorised road camber than by sight, on a coastline that offers no shoulder to correct onto if the instinct is wrong.

Two ways to know the same coastline

Set Manser's crossing next to Bakkes's, and this Part becomes the clearest early demonstration in the book of what "expedition type" actually changes about a traveller's relationship to a single stretch of ground.

Manser met the Skeleton Coast once, inside a schedule built around circumnavigating an entire continent's coastline in roughly two years and two months. Whatever the fog did to him, whatever the wind off the Benguela cost him in the day or two it took to cross Namibia's share of his route, it happened once, was logged as one of the harder legs among hundreds, and then receded behind him as the bicycle carried him on toward the next country's coastline and the next stretch of the total. His relationship to this coast is, by the nature of what a circumnavigation demands, a single data point — intense, sourced, real, but bounded to the days his route happened to run along it.

Bakkes's relationship to the same country, a little inland from where Manser's tyres met the sand, was the opposite kind of exposure entirely: not a single hard leg inside a longer schedule, but a region revisited enough times, across enough years, that its internal geography — Kamanjab's position on the road, the Kuiseb's ecological boundary, the Fish River Canyon's seasonal window — became something closer to local knowledge than travelogue. Neither way of knowing a piece of ground is more legitimate than the other; a circumnavigator cannot afford Bakkes's luxury of return, and a man without a single continent-spanning expedition to his name never gets to say he has crossed every coastline in Africa. What the pairing does, set side by side on

the same country's map, is make literal a claim this book otherwise has to leave implicit: the same landscape hands a completely different experience to the traveller who meets it once at speed and the traveller who keeps coming back.

There is a third way of knowing this coastline that belongs to neither man, and it is worth naming precisely because it is not human at all. The Cape fur seal colonies gathered along this shore in their hundreds of thousands know the coast the way an animal knows a feeding ground: by return, by season, by a relationship to the Benguela's cold water that has nothing to do with a journal entry or a bicycle computer's odometer and everything to do with where the current concentrates the fish they need. The diamond-dredging vessels working the same water a little further out know it a third way again — as a resource map plotted by geological survey rather than by memory or muscle, an industrial knowledge of the seabed's mineral content that has no interest in the fog except as a hazard to shipping schedules. Set against Manser's single hard leg and Bakkes's nineteen returns, the seals and the dredgers are a reminder that "knowing a coastline" is not exclusively a human category at all, and that the two travellers this Part has followed are only the two versions of that knowledge this book happens to be equipped to tell.

What outlasts the traveller

The Skeleton Coast, more than any other stretch this book covers, illustrates its opening claim: that a road can matter enormously to the history of human movement across it without belonging, even briefly, to any one person who crossed it.

Every wreck rusting on that shoreline had a captain, a crew, a manifest, a company that insured it and, in most cases, lost the argument with the insurer over what "acceptable risk" had meant. Almost none of those names survive in any form this book could verify and print. What survives is the coast itself — its fog mechanism, its current, its dune field, its rate of shipwreck — and, threaded through it rather than standing as its single subject, one name who came back to the same

ground nineteen times because the road, unusually among the roads in this book, was never trying to be finished. It was trying to be returned to.

North of the Namib, the desert gives way to savannah and the coastline stops being the story. What replaces it is a corridor as old as human migration itself, and three very different kinds of traveller who have gone the length of it in three very different ways — with a fourth, familiar by now, crossing alongside them.

Part III: The Cape-to-Cairo Corridor (South)

An idea before it was a road

The phrase “Cape to Cairo” predates every traveller in this book by more than a century, and it is worth understanding what it originally meant before any of them borrowed it, because the borrowing changes the meaning each time.

It began as an imperial ambition — a proposed British-controlled corridor and railway running the length of the continent, tying Cape Town to Cairo under a single colonial administration, championed most famously in the language of Cecil Rhodes’s era. The ambition had a shape as much political as practical: a continuous belt of British-administered territory running the length of Africa, uninterrupted by any rival colonial power’s holdings, with the railway as both the ambition’s literal infrastructure and its most durable slogan — “Cape to Cairo” did as much work as a piece of imperial branding as it ever did as an engineering plan. The railway was never completed in the form the ambition imagined, undone in large part by the same reality every traveller in this Part still contends with: German territory in what is now Namibia and the difficulty of securing an uninterrupted line of control across the intervening length of the continent meant the “all-red route,” in the era’s own colour-coded parlance for British possessions on the map, was never politically possible to finish, whatever the surveys said about the terrain.

The railway's actual fate is worth tracing a little further than the single fact of its failure, because what got built, in fragments, over the following century says more about the ambition's real legacy than the unbuilt whole does. Sections of line were laid piecemeal, country by country, under whichever colonial or later national administration controlled that stretch at the time — a railway reaching north from the Cape through the mining regions of southern Africa, another pushing south from Egypt and Sudan, others built for entirely local commercial reasons in the East African territories in between — but the pieces were never joined into the single continuous spine the original ambition demanded, and by the time political conditions might conceivably have allowed a connecting effort, the rise of motor transport and, later, aviation had already begun to make a trans-continental trunk railway a less urgent proposition than it had seemed to a Victorian planner staring at a map with no other way to move an army or an export crop that distance at all. What survives today, in place of the connected railway, is a patchwork of national rail networks that mostly do not link across borders at track gauge or at all, each one a fragment of an ambition that was never realized as a whole — the clearest possible illustration of how a single grand infrastructural vision can leave behind real, functioning pieces without ever assembling into the shape it was drawn to become. The road that eventually did connect the whole distance was not built by an empire's railway engineers at all. It was assembled, gradually and without a single controlling authority, out of the ordinary national road networks of a dozen independent countries who had no stake whatsoever in Rhodes's original ambition and every reason of their own, entirely apart from it, to build roads connecting their own territory.

What exists instead, more than a century later, is not a railway but a route — a corridor of roads, border posts, and increasingly, tourist itineraries that runs, in rough approximation, the same north-south line the Victorian planners once drew for reasons that had nothing to do with adventure and everything to do with control. It is worth sitting with that inversion for a moment: a line drawn to extend a single empire's uninterrupted authority over a continent is now travelled, overwhelmingly, by private individuals crossing a dozen sepa-

rate sovereign nations' worth of the same paperwork the empire was built to make unnecessary. The road outlived the ambition that drew it, and outlived it by becoming almost its exact opposite. Modern over-landing operators running the corridor today advertise trips of roughly 18,000 kilometres through twelve countries — South Africa, Namibia, Botswana, Zimbabwe, Zambia, Tanzania, Kenya, Ethiopia, Sudan, and Egypt among them — a route that has become the closest thing the continent has to a single named long road, the one this book's more ambitious travellers keep returning to cross in full.

This Part covers the corridor's southern half: South Africa, Namibia, Botswana, Zimbabwe, and Zambia. It is the stretch where savannah begins to dominate, where the great transboundary conservation areas of southern Africa run alongside the route, and where four of this book's travellers — moving by four entirely different means, for four entirely different reasons — crossed the same ground.

The composite route today

Before the named travellers, the corridor deserves a description on its own terms, because it is not a single road in the way Sani Pass is a single road. It is a braided set of choices — tar where tar exists, gravel and sand track where it does not, a border crossing every few hundred kilometres where paperwork replaces terrain as the main hazard.

Modern accounts of driving or riding it — motorcycle tour operators and independent overlanders alike — describe a recurring texture of difficulty that has less to do with any single dramatic obstacle and more to do with attrition: border posts that close without notice or reopen on local rather than published time, landslides and washouts on stretches through Zambia and further north that can add days to a schedule with no warning, and, at various points across the decades this corridor has been driven, local conflict that has forced route changes not contemplated by whoever printed the map the traveller is holding. A vehicle-based expedition through this stretch is, in a very literal sense, planning for delay as the default rather than the exception.

The countries this Part covers are also home to some of the continent's most significant wildlife and conservation geography: the Kalahari's edge, the Okavango's inland delta, the Zambezi's run toward Victoria Falls. A traveller moving north through this stretch is crossing, in sequence, some of the most ecologically dense terrain on the continent, on roads built, in large part, to service that same wildlife economy rather than to make a cyclist's or a walker's life easier.

The Okavango deserves a moment of its own because it inverts the ordinary logic of a river system so completely that it is worth naming as a geographic curiosity in its own right, not merely a scenic backdrop to a border crossing. Almost every major river on Earth runs to the sea. The Okavango does not. It rises in the Angolan highlands, runs southeast through Namibia's narrow Caprivi panhandle, and then, on reaching Botswana, simply stops behaving like a river bound for an ocean at all: it fans out across the flat basin of the Kalahari and disperses into one of the largest inland deltas on the planet, its water eventually lost to evaporation and to the thirsty sand of the desert around it rather than delivered to any coastline. A delta, everywhere else this book's rivers run, marks the last few kilometres before a river becomes the sea. Here it marks the opposite: the last few hundred kilometres before a river becomes nothing at all, soaked up by a desert it never manages to cross. The seasonal flood pulse that drives the whole system — water that fell as highland rain in Angola months earlier arriving to flood the delta during Botswana's own dry season, so that the wettest months on the ground are not the wettest months in the sky above it — is itself a demonstration of how large a river system has to be before its weather stops being local.

Further along the same stretch of corridor, the Zambezi produces the opposite kind of spectacle: not a river disappearing quietly into sand, but one falling, at Victoria Falls, into a gorge with a suddenness that has made it one of the most recognisable natural landmarks on the continent — a curtain of water more than a kilometre wide dropping over a hundred metres into a narrow chasm, the spray from the impact visible, on the river's fuller months, from many kilometres away, which is presumably some part of why the indigenous Kololo name for the falls translates as "the smoke that thunders." The falls sit almost

exactly on the border between Zambia and Zimbabwe, which makes them, among the other things this book has already noted about this corridor's borders, a rare case of a natural wonder doing double duty as an international boundary marker — a traveller crossing this corridor does not simply pass near Victoria Falls, in a great many routings they cross a country line by way of it. The whole of this stretch, from the Okavango's inward-facing delta to the Zambezi's outward, thundering drop, sits within a broader patchwork of transboundary conservation areas that several of the region's governments have worked, with varying success, to link into contiguous corridors for wildlife migration across the same national borders that slow down every human traveller in this Part — animals, unlike the cyclists and convoys this book follows, cross those borders without a carnet.

The Okavango's inward-facing geography has a consequence worth spelling out, because it is the reason this single delta carries such outsized weight in any account of the corridor's wildlife geography. A river that empties into the sea disperses its water, eventually, into an ocean large enough to absorb it without much local effect. A river that empties into a desert concentrates its water, instead, into the one part of an otherwise arid basin where anything can reliably drink, which is exactly what the Okavango does for the dry season it floods against rather than during. The practical result is a seasonal magnet: as the surrounding Kalahari dries out through the winter months, the delta's own flood pulse is only then arriving, so that the region's wildlife concentrates into the delta's channels and floodplains at precisely the time of year the rest of the basin has the least to offer them. It is the geographic mechanism behind the density of animal life the corridor's overland route is built to service, and it happens on a calendar set by rain that fell in a different country months earlier — a traveller passing through Botswana at the height of the delta's dry-season flood is, in effect, watching the tail end of an Angolan wet season finally arrive, translated across a thousand kilometres and several months of lag.

The geography around Victoria Falls compounds the corridor's border-crossing texture in a way worth naming precisely, because the falls sit near enough to where four countries' territory converges — Zambia, Zimbabwe, Botswana, and Namibia's Caprivi panhandle all meeting

within a short distance of each other along the Zambezi — that this single short stretch of river does more sovereign-boundary work than almost anywhere else on the continent. A traveller moving through this pocket of the corridor can cross a national border, recross it, and approach a third country's territory within a day's travel, all without leaving the immediate vicinity of one waterfall — a compression of international boundary into physical space that the corridor's border-post attrition, described below, makes considerably more consequential than it would be if the same four territories met somewhere with only one crossing to negotiate rather than several in close succession.

One river, three names

A traveller tracing this corridor's map through that same four-country convergence is, without necessarily realising it, following a single river system that keeps changing its name as it crosses borders, in a way that makes the map look more fragmented than the water actually is. It rises as the Cuando in the Angolan highlands, not far from where the Okavango itself begins, and runs southeast along a broadly similar course before the two systems part ways: where the Okavango turns south into Botswana and fans out into its inland delta, the Cuando continues along the edge of Namibia's Caprivi strip, becomes the Kwando as it does, spreads into the seasonal marsh of the Linyanti Swamp, narrows again into the Linyanti River proper, and finally takes a third name, the Chobe, for its last run toward its confluence with the Zambezi near the town of Kasane — one continuous watercourse wearing three regional names along a single course, the geographic cousin of the Sperrgebiet-to-Skeleton-Coast question this book asked in its previous Part about where a park's name changes without the land itself changing underneath it.

The Chobe stretch of that river, in particular, supports one of the densest concentrations of elephant on the continent, gathering along the riverfront in the dry season in numbers commonly cited in the tens of thousands — a congregation driven by the identical seasonal logic already described for the Okavango a little to the south: as the surrounding bush dries out, permanent water becomes the only variable

that matters, and a river that holds water year-round becomes, for months at a stretch, the one place an animal that size can reliably drink. The Linyanti Swamp upstream performs a similar function on a smaller and less publicised scale, a seasonal wetland that swells and shrinks with the same Angolan-highland rainfall that drives the Okavango's own flood pulse, so that the whole transboundary system this Part has already praised for its wildlife corridors is, underneath the separate national park names attached to each stretch, substantially one hydrological event happening in stages, a thousand kilometres and several months removed from the rain that caused it.

A river dammed into a different shape

Further downstream, past the Chobe's own confluence with the Zambezi and past Victoria Falls, the same river was made to do something no upwelling current or seasonal flood pulse this book has described so far ever managed on its own: it was stopped. Kariba Dam, built across the Zambezi gorge between 1956 and 1959 and commissioned in 1960, was the defining infrastructure project of the colonial-era Federation of Rhodesia and Nyasaland, built to generate hydroelectric power for a territory straddling what was then Northern and Southern Rhodesia — the same political entity, and very nearly the same stretch of river, this Part's account of Rhodesian UDI and its border-post aftermath will shortly describe from a different angle entirely. The lake the dam created behind it, taking some five years to fill completely, is commonly cited as the largest reservoir in the world by volume, a single engineered basin holding back a stretch of the Zambezi that, before 1959, had never existed as standing water at all.

A lake of that size does not fill an empty valley. It fills a valley people and animals were already living in, and the human and ecological cost of Kariba's filling is as much a part of this corridor's history as the electricity the dam was built to generate. Tens of thousands of Tonga people — figures in the sourced literature run to roughly fifty or sixty thousand, split across both the Zambian and Zimbabwean sides of the new lake — were relocated from the Zambezi valley floor to higher ground as the water rose behind the wall, a resettlement decided by

the same colonial administration that had ordered the dam built, with none of the choice in the matter that a traveller crossing this corridor today, by comparison, takes almost entirely for granted. Alongside the human relocation ran a parallel effort to save the valley's wildlife: an operation named, with a directness the era's engineering reports rarely allowed themselves, Operation Noah, in which teams led by conservationist Rupert Fothergill worked the shrinking islands the rising water was creating out of former high ground, capturing and relocating several thousand stranded animals to safer terrain as the water closed in around them from every side. It is a strange, late echo of this book's own recurring theme — a landscape reshaped by a single mechanism, indifferent to which creature it drowns or saves, just as the Benguela's upwelling in Part II fed a colony of seals and sank a century of ships through the identical piece of oceanography. Here the mechanism was not a current but a concrete wall, and the choice of who was moved in time and who was not belonged, for the first time in this book, entirely to human hands rather than to geology or weather.

A second kind of border, invisible from a map

The national borders this corridor crosses are not the only lines a traveller through this stretch of southern Africa has to reckon with. Running through and alongside several of these same countries is a second, older network of boundaries that appears on no passport stamp and shows up on no tourist map at all: the veterinary cordon fence, built to separate cattle from wild buffalo and other game susceptible to carrying foot-and-mouth disease, a livestock illness that does not kill cattle outright so much as close export markets to any country that cannot certify its herds disease-free. Botswana in particular built out an extensive network of these fences through the second half of the twentieth century, driven less by a single dramatic outbreak than by the ongoing economic requirement of maintaining beef export access to markets, chiefly in Europe, that would suspend purchases from an entire country over a single confirmed case anywhere within it. A fence line hundreds of kilometres long, in that context, is not a border

in the political sense at all. It is a biosecurity instrument, built to answer a foreign import inspector's question rather than to mark where one nation's sovereignty ends and another's begins.

The consequence for wildlife, and for the roads this Part's travellers actually used, was substantial enough that it is still debated among the region's own conservation authorities decades after the fences went up. A fence built to stop a buffalo from mingling with cattle does not distinguish between that buffalo and the wildebeest, zebra, or elephant herds whose own seasonal migrations, developed over a timescale no cordon fence could out-plan, ran across exactly the ground the fence now blocked. Large die-offs of migratory game along cordon fence lines, unable to reach traditional dry-season water or grazing on the far side of a barrier that had not existed a generation earlier, are part of the documented cost of the policy — an unglamorous, bureaucratic cause of ecological damage that killed far more wildlife, over the decades, than any single poacher or drought this book's other Parts describe. The roads a modern overlander now drives through this corridor often run parallel to these same fence lines, in some stretches because the fence's own maintenance track was the most reliable graded surface available to build a public road alongside, which means a traveller admiring the transboundary conservation geography this Part has already praised is, in a great many stretches, driving beside the very infrastructure that fragmented it in the first place.

None of the named travellers in this Part left a documented account of the cordon fences specifically, and this book will not invent one where the sourcing does not support it. What can be said honestly is that the fences were there, across the decades several of these crossings took place, running near or alongside the same roads a cyclist, a walker, and a Land Rover convoy each used to cross this stretch of southern Africa — one more example of a border that has nothing to do with a traveller's own nationality, built for cattle rather than for people, and crossed, in most cases, without the traveller involved ever quite realising what the wire beside the road was actually for.

The border-post attrition deserves a moment of its own, because it is

easy to state as an abstraction — “delays,” “paperwork” — and much harder to convey as the actual, hour-by-hour texture of crossing this stretch of the continent overland. A border post in this corridor is rarely a single building with a single queue. It is, more often, a scattered cluster of functions — customs in one office, immigration in another, sometimes a separate vehicle carnet check conducted by an official who may or may not be at the post that day — each with its own hours, its own paperwork, and its own tolerance for a traveller’s impatience. A cyclist or motorcyclist waiting at such a post is not waiting on a queue in the way a traveller at a European road crossing waits; they are waiting on the coordination, sometimes achieved and sometimes not, of two or three separate bureaucratic processes that were never designed to move at the same pace. Every traveller this Part describes — cyclist, walker, vehicle convoy — paid this same tax in delay, regardless of how fast they moved between the posts.

The savannah as a moving weather system

There is a specific kind of hazard this stretch of corridor produces that deserves naming before any individual traveller’s account of crossing it, because it recurs across every mode of travel this Part covers: the savannah’s own seasonal rhythm, which does not care whether the person crossing it is on two wheels, on foot, or in a Land Rover with a support team.

The region’s wet season, roughly November through March depending on the specific country and year, turns unpaved stretches of this corridor from firm, fast-travelling gravel into a surface that can swallow a vehicle’s wheels to the axle and turn a bicycle’s tyres into something closer to a pair of mud paddles than a means of locomotion. The dry season, by contrast, produces its own hazard in the form of dust fine enough to work its way into engines, chains, and lungs in roughly equal measure, and heat that climbs, across the middle of the day, to temperatures that make travel outside the early morning and late afternoon hours a matter of managed risk rather than simple discomfort. Every traveller who has crossed this stretch of corridor — whichever decade, whichever mode of travel — has had to make some version of

the same seasonal calculation: which months to travel in, and which hazard, mud or dust and heat, they were willing to accept in exchange for avoiding the other.

The Kalahari, whose edge this corridor skirts through Botswana, is a different kind of dry country from the true desert this book has already crossed in Part II, and the difference is worth marking precisely rather than letting “desert” do duty for both. The Namib is an arid desert in the strict sense, kept dry by the Benguela Current’s cold offshore water suppressing rainfall along the whole coastal belt. The Kalahari, by contrast, receives enough rainfall in an ordinary year that it is more accurately classed as a semi-arid savannah than a true desert at all — the popular name has simply outlived the stricter classification. What the Kalahari lacks is not rain but surface water: the region sits atop a deep bed of ancient sand, itself a fossil landscape built up over a vastly longer span than the visible plant cover on top of it suggests, through which rain drains away too quickly to pool into the rivers or standing water a traveller would ordinarily expect from a savannah this size. The result is a landscape that can look, in the wet season, thoroughly green and thoroughly alive, and still offer a stranded traveller almost nothing to drink, because the water that fell has already gone somewhere the traveller cannot reach it. It is a variation on the same cruelty this book named in the Skeleton Coast’s own fog — a landscape whose water is real and present, but arrives, or disappears, by a mechanism that does the traveller on the ground no good at all.

The Kalahari has supported human habitation for longer than almost anywhere else this book’s roads run through, which is worth setting against the same landscape’s apparent hostility to a stranded modern traveller. Indigenous San communities have lived across this basin for millennia, developing water-finding knowledge specific to exactly the kind of terrain that offers a passing overlander nothing: locating buried tuber and root moisture, tracking the rare surface pans that hold water after rain long enough to matter, reading vegetation for what it implies about groundwater no drilling rig has ever been sunk to measure. None of that knowledge is available to a traveller crossing this corridor at speed, on a bicycle or in a vehicle convoy, in the way it would be to someone who had spent a working life, or many

generations of one, in the same basin — a distinction the same shape as the one this book has already drawn between a coastline crossed once and a coastline returned to nineteen times, applied here to an entire semi-arid ecosystem rather than a single stretch of shore.

Every mode of travel through this corridor answers the savannah's seasonal calculation differently, and it is worth setting the four side by side before this Part turns to the named travellers who actually made the choices. A cyclist crossing in the wet season trades speed for traction loss on every unpaved stretch, and has almost no ability to detour around a flooded track without adding distance his own legs will have to cover. A solo walker faces the same mud with no gears to shift into and no frame to absorb the extra effort of hauling boots free of it, step after step, for as long as the wet ground lasts. A vehicle-based convoy can, within limits, choose its season and often does, timing a humanitarian itinerary's road stages around the calendar rather than around a fixed departure date the way a record attempt cannot. And a traveller with no schedule at all, moving through the region across an unspecified number of separate visits over years, can simply wait out a bad season somewhere else and return when the ground has firmed — the one freedom none of this corridor's more structured travellers ever had available to them.

Riaan Manser: the first circumnavigation

Riaan Manser is the traveller this corridor belongs to more than any other, not because he moved fastest or covered the most unusual ground, but because his journey through it was one leg — a substantial one — of an achievement with no real precedent: the first circumnavigation of the African continent by bicycle.

Manser departed Cape Town in September 2003. He returned at the end of 2005, a journey of roughly two years and two months. The distance covered is recorded slightly differently across sources — one account gives 36,500 kilometres, another closer to 37,000 — a discrepancy that says less about sloppy record-keeping than about how genuinely difficult it is to measure a journey of this length with the

precision a stadium sport affords; the difference between the two figures is a rounding error smaller than a single bad day's detour. He passed through thirty-four countries, touching every one of them with a coastline, which was the whole design principle of the route: circumnavigation meant, by definition, following the coast, rather than cutting the more direct interior line other travellers in this book would later choose.

The pace sustained across that distance and that time — averaging around ninety kilometres a day, for the better part of two years, across terrain ranging from paved coastal highway to sand track to mountain pass — cost him roughly fourteen kilograms over the course of the expedition, a detail worth including for its own unglamorous honesty: circumnavigation, in the sourced record, reads less like continuous exhilaration and more like a controlled, multi-year deficit the body was made to run.

It is worth being plain about what ninety kilometres a day, sustained for roughly two years rather than attempted once as a weekend's effort, actually asks of a human body, because the number reads as modest to anyone who has only ever ridden a bicycle for pleasure. A single ninety-kilometre ride is an ordinary weekend outing for a fit amateur cyclist. Ninety kilometres a day, seven days a week, month after month, with no off-season and no taper, is a different category of demand entirely — the kind that outpaces the body's ordinary capacity to refuel itself from food alone, which is the arithmetic that a fourteen-kilogram loss, sustained across the whole journey rather than the first difficult month of it, actually documents. A body that cannot fully replace what a day's ride burns does not simply feel tired; it starts drawing down its own reserves, a process that continues, in a controlled and survivable way if the rider is careful, for as long as the daily deficit persists — which, on Manser's own timeline, was the better part of two years. Fourteen kilograms over that span is not a crash diet. It is the visible residue of a two-year negotiation between distance covered and calories available, conducted across thirty-four countries' worth of food supply, weather, and terrain, with the rider's own body as the ledger that recorded the difference.

It was not, by any account, merely a physical trial. Manser was jailed in Equatorial Guinea by border police during the journey — the sourced record does not elaborate the charge or the full circumstance, only the fact of the detention — and was taken hostage by armed teenage rebels in Liberia, an incident belonging to the West African leg of the circumnavigation rather than to this Part's southern corridor, but worth naming here because it frames what "crossing thirty-four countries by bicycle" actually exposed him to: not simply distance and terrain, but the full range of political and security conditions across a continent that does not present a uniform face to a lone cyclist, whichever direction he is travelling.

Neither incident is this book's to dramatize further than the bare record allows. What can be said, without overreaching the sourcing, is what the two incidents together establish about the nature of a circumnavigation attempted alone: a solo cyclist carries no institutional cover. A vehicle-based expedition like Holgate's, which this Part will turn to shortly, travels with a support team and, often, advance coordination with local authorities along its route. A solo rider on a bicycle has none of that; he is, at every border post and every stretch of unfamiliar territory, exactly as exposed as his own judgment and whatever goodwill he can find allow him to be. Two years and two months of that exposure, sustained across thirty-four countries, is a different category of risk from a shorter, faster ride through fewer borders — not because any single border crossing was more dangerous than another, but because the sheer number of them, over so long a span, meant the statistical exposure to any single bad encounter kept compounding for the better part of two years running.

Through the southern stretch this Part covers — Namibia's coastal leg, already covered in Part II, and the run through Botswana and Zimbabwe and Zambia toward the Tanzam corridor further north — Manser's circumnavigation and the modern overland motorcycle/4x4 route this Part opened with occupy, in effect, the same roads at different speeds. A cyclist averaging ninety kilometres a day and a motorcycle or 4x4 tour covering the same distance in an afternoon are using an identical stretch of gravel or tar for entirely different dura-

tions of exposure to it — the same border posts, the same washouts, experienced by one traveller as a full day's obstacle and by the other as a delay measured in hours. It is the clearest illustration in this book of the idea the compendium is built around: the road is the constant, and the traveller's speed determines how much of the road's difficulty they are actually made to feel.

Manser's full circumnavigation — its close, its record status, its place alongside Longueira, Beaumont, and Holgate as one of the continent's defining feats of self-propelled or vehicle-based travel — is this book's subject in Part VI, where it belongs alongside the other whole-continent achievements. Here, in the corridor's southern reach, he is one traveller among several, his bicycle sharing the ground with a walker, a fleet of Land Rovers, and a man on foot, by motorcycle, and by bus who came this way more than once and kept no ledger of when.

Mario Rigby: the solo walk begins

Where Manser's circumnavigation was defined by its coastal completeness — every country touched, the whole continent's edge traced — Mario Rigby's journey through this same southern stretch was the opening leg of an entirely different kind of achievement: a solo, unsupported walk across the African continent, on foot, start to finish.

Rigby departed in November 2015. His route through the southern corridor took him through South Africa, Mozambique, and Malawi before the walk continued north into the Tanzam corridor this book covers in Part IV — nine countries in total across the full walk, ending in Egypt in January 2018, a crossing of roughly 12,000 kilometres on foot over just over two years.

What distinguishes a solo walk from every other mode of travel in this book is not simply that it is slower — though it is, by a wide margin, the slowest way to cross this ground of any traveller covered here — but that it removes the mechanical buffer every other traveller in this Part retains. A cyclist has wheels and gears between his legs and the road surface. A motorcyclist or 4x4 traveller has an engine and a chas-

sis. A walker has boots, and after enough thousands of kilometres, not even reliably those. The southern leg of Rigby's route — through terrain that ranges from South Africa's developed road network to the more remote stretches of Mozambique and Malawi — put him on foot through some of the same wildlife-dense geography the modern overland route treats as its set-piece middle section, at a pace that gave him no ability to simply outrun a bad encounter with terrain or weather the way a vehicle-based traveller could.

There is an arithmetic worth doing explicitly here, because it clarifies exactly how different a walker's exposure to this terrain is from a cyclist's or a motorcyclist's. Manser's bicycle, moving at roughly ninety kilometres a day, crossed the same stretch of southern African terrain in a matter of days. A vehicle-based expedition crosses it faster still — the same distance in hours rather than days, engine and fuel supply permitting. A walker covering perhaps thirty to forty kilometres on a strong day, less on a hard one, is exposed to the same stretch of country for a week or more where a cyclist needed only a day or two. Every hour of that extended exposure is an hour spent at walking pace through terrain that includes some of the densest wildlife populations on the continent, with none of the speed a bicycle or an engine would offer as a means of putting distance between the traveller and whatever the terrain produces. It is the clearest possible demonstration, this early in the book, of why this compendium insists on treating "expedition type" as load-bearing rather than decorative: the same road asks an entirely different question of a walker than it asks of anyone moving faster.

There is a specific kind of decision a walker has to make that a wheeled or engine-powered traveller mostly does not, and it is worth naming because it recurs across Rigby's entire southern leg: the choice of exactly where to place each day's feet, hour after hour, with no seat between the walker and the accumulating fatigue of the ground itself. A cyclist rolling over a rutted gravel stretch absorbs some of the terrain's roughness through the bicycle's own give — tyres, frame flex, the small mechanical forgiveness built into anything with wheels. A walker absorbs all of it directly, through the joints, on every single step of the tens of thousands a day like this required,

which is a different and cumulative category of physical cost than a cyclist's legs or a driver's attention ever has to pay in quite the same currency. It is the reason a solo walk across this stretch of Africa reads, in the sourced arithmetic this Part has already laid out, as the slowest mode of travel this book covers and also, on a per-kilometre basis, arguably the most physically expensive one.

It is worth placing Rigby's walk, briefly, against the wider category of long-distance walking it belongs to, because the category itself has its own logic worth understanding before returning to this specific crossing. Walks of a scale large enough to earn the description "longest in the world" are, by their nature, contested and comparative claims rather than a single settled record the way a timed cycling crossing can be: the title has been claimed, at different points, by walks spanning different continents and different total distances, including one route beginning in South Africa and running, in stages completed by different walkers over different years, more than 24,000 kilometres north and east toward China — a scale that dwarfs even Rigby's roughly 12,000 kilometres, and a reminder that "walking across a continent" is itself a category with enormous internal range, from a single continuous crossing completed by one person in one unbroken effort to a relay of distinct stages claimed collectively across a route too long for any one walker's unsupported attempt. Rigby's walk belongs to the first, more demanding category: one person, one continuous effort, no handoff to a second walker partway through. That distinction is not a matter of degree so much as of kind, and it is worth stating plainly rather than letting the word "walk" flatten two very different achievements into the same claim.

The full shape and completion of Rigby's walk — its total distance, its nine countries, its two-year-and-three-month span, and what it meant to finish it on foot in Egypt in January 2018 — belongs properly to Part V, where the walk ends. Here, in its southern beginning, Rigby is a solo figure on a corridor otherwise dominated by wheels: a walker crossing the same ground a cyclist and a fleet of Land Rovers were also, at various points across six decades, crossing at speeds he had no access to and, by the account of his own journey, no apparent wish for.

Kingsley Holgate: the outline, not the crossing

The third traveller this corridor's southern stretch introduces is also the one most easily confused with the other two, and the confusion is worth heading off directly: Kingsley Holgate's expeditions are not a circumnavigation in Manser's sense, and they are not a solo human-powered crossing in Rigby's sense. They are something else — vehicle-based, team-organised, humanitarian in stated purpose — and the difference is not a technicality. It is the entire premise of what Holgate's expeditions were built to do.

Holgate, born 28 February 1946, has been described as the most travelled man in Africa, a Fellow of the Royal Geographical Society, and a longtime Land Rover ambassador — credentials that, taken together, sketch a life organised around expedition as a vocation rather than a single feat undertaken once. Across more than four decades of expeditions run under the banner of the Kingsley Holgate Foundation — more than forty of them over his career — his signature achievement, “Africa's Outside Edge,” traced the entire coastal outline of the African continent: thirty-three countries, 449 days.

Each of those three credentials points at a different part of what made his particular mode of travel possible, and it is worth separating them rather than letting them blur into a single honorific. The Royal Geographical Society Fellowship situates him inside a much older tradition of expedition as a documented, institutionally recognised undertaking — the same broad lineage, however distant in tone and century, as the Victorian-era surveyors whose railway ambition opened this Part. The Land Rover ambassadorship is a more practical credential than it sounds: a vehicle-based expedition crossing thirty-three countries over 449 days depends, in ways a solo cyclist's journey does not, on the vehicle itself surviving conditions that would strand or destroy a less purpose-built machine — river crossings, deep sand, months without formal servicing — and a long manufacturer relationship of that kind is itself a form of logistical support most solo travellers in this book never had available to them. And the Foundation's humanitarian branding names the third element: unlike Manser's or Rigby's journeys, which were personal achievements first and stories second, Holgate's

expeditions were built, from their planning stage onward, around a stated purpose external to the traveller's own record — a structure that shapes everything about how a Holgate expedition moves, stops, and is remembered, set against a solo rider whose only obligation, at any given border post, was to himself.

A convoy expedition of this kind carries a different physical footprint across a stretch of corridor than either a lone cyclist or a lone walker, and the difference is worth being concrete about because it changes what a border post attrition actually costs each traveller. Where Manser or Rigby arrived at a checkpoint as a single person with a single passport and, at most, a single bicycle to declare, a Holgate-style expedition arrived as a small fleet — vehicles, fuel reserves, spare parts, a support team, and whatever humanitarian cargo the day's project stop required — each item its own line of paperwork, its own point of potential delay, its own opportunity for a customs official to find something that does not match the manifest. The same scattered, uncoordinated border-post architecture this Part has already described costs a solo traveller time. It costs a convoy time multiplied by the number of things it is carrying, which is a real, if unglamorous, tax on the very scale that gives a humanitarian expedition its reach.

The word “traced” is doing careful work in that sentence, and it is worth pausing on it. Manser's circumnavigation and Holgate's outline expedition sound, described from a sufficient distance, like the same feat — both involve travelling the coastal perimeter of the continent. They are not the same feat, and collapsing them into one would blur exactly the distinction this book exists to preserve. Manser's was a solo, human-powered, bicycle circumnavigation: one person, one machine, propelled by his own legs across every kilometre of the roughly 36,500 to 37,000 total. Holgate's outline expeditions were vehicle-based and team-organised, run with the logistical support and stated humanitarian purpose that has characterised his Foundation's work across its entire history — expeditions built to carry out on-the-ground projects rather than to set a solo endurance record. A Land Rover convoy with a support team and a humanitarian mandate is doing something categorically different from one person alone on a bicycle, even when the

map of where each of them went looks, at a glance, similar.

Through the southern stretch this Part covers, Holgate's outline expeditions would have crossed much of the same corridor Manser's bicycle and Rigby's boots also crossed — Namibia's coast, Botswana's interior, the run north toward Zambia — but as a team, in vehicles, with an itinerary built around project stops rather than personal-best pacing. It is the third mode of travel this Part introduces, and it completes a pattern this book keeps returning to: the same road, crossed by a cyclist alone, a walker alone, and a vehicle-based team with a humanitarian mission, each experiencing an entirely different journey on ground that does not change to accommodate any of them.

The scale of Holgate's career total is worth setting against the single-expedition figures this book has cited so far, because it changes the category of achievement being described. More than forty expeditions across a career, run under a single Foundation banner, is not one long journey but a sustained institutional practice — closer, in structure, to a standing programme than to a single attempt at a record. “Africa's Outside Edge,” at thirty-three countries and 449 days, is the single largest of those expeditions by the sourced record, but it sits inside a much longer working life of expedition after expedition, each apparently justified by its own stated humanitarian purpose rather than by the need to set or break any individual record. That is the deepest distinction between Holgate's body of work and everything else in this Part: Manser, Rigby, and the record-breakers this book meets in Part VI were each attempting a single, bounded achievement, however long it took to complete. Holgate's Foundation was — and, as far as this book's sources indicate, remains — an ongoing practice, of which the outline expedition is simply the most geographically complete example on record.

It is worth doing the same pace arithmetic for “Africa's Outside Edge” that this Part has already done for Manser's circumnavigation, because the comparison sharpens exactly what a support team changes about a journey's shape. Thirty-three countries in 449 days is not, primarily, a distance figure in the way Manser's ninety kilometres a day is — a vehicle convoy's daily range is rarely the binding constraint the way

a cyclist's legs are — it is instead a figure dominated by the project stops the expedition's humanitarian mandate built into the itinerary at each of those thirty-three national stages. Where Manser's schedule was set by how far a body could pedal before it needed to sleep, Holgate's was set by how long a project needed at each stop before the convoy could responsibly move on to the next border. That is not a lesser form of difficulty. It is a different one entirely — the discipline of an itinerary built around thirty-three separate sets of local obligations rather than around a single rider's own physical ceiling, which is its own kind of unglamorous endurance, sustained across the better part of a year and a half.

A corridor whose paperwork changed shape under the traveller's feet

Every traveller crossing this stretch of southern Africa across the decades this book covers — Manser in 2003 to 2005, Holgate across a career that began well before either, Bakkes across an unspecified span of visits reaching back further still — was crossing a set of borders whose meaning had shifted, sometimes completely, within living memory of the crossing itself. Rhodesia's Ian Smith government declared unilateral independence from Britain in 1965 rather than accept a transition to majority rule, a declaration that made the territory an internationally unrecognised state for close to a decade and a half, sanctioned by most of the world and increasingly isolated from the ordinary diplomatic machinery — consular support, recognised customs arrangements, straightforward transit paperwork — that a traveller crossing a more conventionally governed border could otherwise rely on. Rhodesia became Zimbabwe only in 1980, after a guerrilla war and a negotiated settlement replaced the Smith government with independence under majority rule, which means a border post on this exact stretch of corridor issued entirely different stamps, answered to an entirely different flag, and operated under an entirely different set of international recognitions depending on which side of 1980 a traveller happened to be standing on.

South Africa's own border posts, at the corridor's southern anchor,

carried a comparable freight across the same decades, for a different reason: the apartheid government's international standing declined steadily from the 1960s onward, through an accumulating regime of trade sanctions, sporting boycotts, and diplomatic isolation that peaked in the 1980s, before the transition to democratic government in 1994 finally answered the question every one of this corridor's border officials had been implicitly enforcing for a generation — who was permitted to represent, and travel on behalf of, this country's paperwork. A traveller's passport, visa, and vehicle documentation did not merely need to be valid; in an era of shifting recognition and sanction, they needed to be issued by an authority the *next* border post down the road was still willing to acknowledge, which was a far less stable guarantee, for much of this period, than a modern overlander filling in an online visa application today has any reason to appreciate.

None of this book's named travellers on this stretch of corridor crossed during the most acute years of Rhodesian UDI or apartheid-era isolation — Manser's 2003 to 2005 circumnavigation and Holgate's decades of expeditions both fall, for the most part, after the political settlements that resolved both situations — but the roads, the border posts, and in places the very buildings they passed through were built, staffed, and bureaucratically shaped by the preceding decades of exactly that isolation. A border post is rarely rebuilt from nothing when a government changes; the physical infrastructure, and often the institutional habits of the officials working it, outlast the political system that first built the crossing. The corridor's modern border-post attrition — the scattered offices, the uncoordinated hours, the carnet check that may or may not be staffed — has more than one root cause, but a region whose international recognition was itself unsettled for much of the preceding half-century is not a region where any single border post ever had the stable, decades-long continuity of practice that produces a smoothly functioning crossing. The corridor's paperwork problem, in other words, is not simply logistical. It is historical residue, still being paid down by every traveller who queues at it today.

Bakkes: Angola, Botswana, Zambia, Zimbabwe

The fourth traveller on this stretch of corridor kept no expedition name, no start line, no finish line, and — by his own account — no interest in being first, fastest, or most complete at anything. Johan Bakkes's travels through Angola, Botswana, Zambia, and Zimbabwe belong to the same category as his time in Namibia: real, sourced, and undated in the way a ledger dates things, because his books were never built as a ledger.

Angola is worth pausing on specifically. Of the countries this Part's more structured travellers crossed — Manser by bicycle, Rigby on foot, Holgate by Land Rover convoy — none of the sourced record for this compendium places any of them travelling through Angola on the routes this Part covers; it sits outside the modern composite overland corridor's usual twelve-country line, and outside the paths Manser's coastal circumnavigation and Rigby's walk are recorded as having taken through this stretch. That absence is not simply a gap in this book's sourcing — it reflects the country's own recent history. Angola's civil war ran for close to three decades after independence in 1975, into the early 2000s, a conflict long enough and destructive enough to keep the country off the routine overlanding maps for the whole period, its roads mined in places and its interior largely closed to the kind of casual cross-border travel the modern composite corridor now assumes as a baseline condition elsewhere in the region. A country can sit geographically inside a corridor's obvious path and still be functionally outside it for as long as safe passage is not available, which is as good an explanation as any for why Angola never became the twelve-country overland route's thirteenth member. Bakkes went there anyway, on his own account, in the manner that characterised his whole travelling life: not because a route existed that told him to, but because the country was there and he wanted to have been in it. It is a small but real point of difference between the compendium's more structured travellers and its dedicatee — the others crossed this ground according to a plan made in advance; Bakkes, more often than not, crossed it according to nothing but the fact that he had not yet been.

There is a specific, sourced irony in Bakkes travelling this ground at all, worth naming rather than passing over: before the storyteller, the accountant, and the tour guide, there were two years spent as a captain in the former South African Defence Force — service that would, depending on when in his life it fell, have put him in or near the same southern African theatre where South Africa's military was, across the 1970s and 1980s, directly entangled in Angola's own civil war and the broader regional conflict along the Namibian border. This book's sourcing does not place him in that specific theatre or specify what his military role actually involved, and it will not invent a connection the record does not support. What can be said honestly is only the shape of the coincidence: a man who wore a uniform in the region during the era its wars made most dangerous later chose, on his own account and by his own means, to return to one of those same countries as a traveller carrying nothing more official than a stack of bangles and a mannequin with her own passport — a life that ran, on this one stretch of ground, from institutional duty to unstructured wandering, in an order this book has no way to reconstruct into anything more definite than the two facts sitting side by side.

His tour-guide qualification, earned in 1990 and put to use running Induku Safaris, sits closer to the surface of why a country like Angola, effectively closed to casual travel for decades, would still draw him rather than repel him. A qualified guide's whole professional instinct runs toward exactly the kind of terrain an ordinary tourist avoids — the places a guide's expertise is actually worth something being, by definition, the places least served by an existing tourism infrastructure. Where his university lecturing gave his working life its steady income and its academic respectability, the guiding qualification gave him the professional cover, and very likely some of the practical skill, to go where the twelve-country composite corridor's paying customers were never going to be taken.

His travels through Botswana, Zambia, and Zimbabwe sit more squarely alongside the corridor this Part has already described — the same savannah, the same transboundary conservation geography, the same border-post attrition that the modern overland route treats as its baseline operating condition. What distinguishes his crossing

of it from Manser's, Rigby's, or Holgate's is not the ground but the method and the mood: no support team, no personal-best pace, no humanitarian itinerary with project stops scheduled in advance — a man moving through the region across an unspecified number of visits, staying long enough in the places that held him to make the shebeen and the roadside bar his research method, rather than passing through fast enough that the country became, in retrospect, a stretch of road rather than a place.

It is worth stating plainly what this means for how this book has to write about him, compared with how it writes about the other three travellers on this stretch of corridor. Manser's crossing of Botswana and Zimbabwe and Zambia can be dated, roughly, to a window within his September 2003 to late 2005 circumnavigation. Rigby's crossing can be dated to the months following his November 2015 departure. Holgate's crossing sits somewhere inside the 449 days of "Africa's Outside Edge," or inside one of his more than forty other expeditions, depending on which of them touched this ground. Bakkes's crossing of the same three countries cannot be dated at all, on the sourced record available to this book, beyond the fact that it happened, at some point or points, across a travelling life that ran from his earliest African journeys through to close to the end of it. That absence of a date is not a failure of research. It is the honest shape of what an essayist's travelling life leaves behind, set against what a bounded expedition — with its departure date, its finish line, its Guinness ratification or its Foundation press release — necessarily produces instead. This book has chosen, throughout, to let that difference show rather than paper over it with an invented year.

He collected copper bangles on journeys like these, one country and one road at a time, until the stack on his arm became, in effect, its own private itinerary — a piece of physical evidence, carried on his own body rather than filed in any archive, of exactly how much of this corridor, and the corridors before and after it, he had actually crossed. This book cannot say which of the more than twenty bangles came from Botswana, or Zambia, or Zimbabwe specifically; the sourced record does not break the collection down by country. What it can say is that the practice existed, was sustained across decades, and produced a

tally that outlived the man wearing it, in the same way the nineteen crossings of Fish River Canyon outlived the specific years in which any one of them took place.

The border-post attrition this Part described earlier — the scattered offices, the uncoordinated hours, the carnet check that may or may not be staffed on a given day — lands on a scheduled traveller and an unscheduled one in almost opposite ways, and Bakkes's presence on this same corridor makes the difference concrete. Manser, mid-circumnavigation, had a route to keep to and a body running a calculated caloric deficit that made every wasted day at a border post a day's worth of pace he could not fully recover elsewhere. Rigby, walking, had even less slack: a delay at a border cost him kilometres he would have to make up on foot, at thirty to forty kilometres a day, with no faster gear to shift into afterward. Holgate's convoy had a support team's patience but also a network of thirty-three countries' worth of project stops already timed against 449 days. For all three, a stalled border post was a cost against a ledger they were, in one form or another, keeping. For Bakkes, travelling with no start line, no finish line, and no ledger to keep, the same delay was simply more time in a place he had come, in the first instance, because he wanted to be there. It is the one point in this corridor's crossing where the mode of travel does not merely change how a traveller experiences a hazard — it changes whether the hazard is a hazard at all.

Where the corridor hands off

By the time this southern stretch reaches Zambia's northern border, the terrain and the traveller's context both begin to shift. The savannah and the transboundary conservation geography that define Botswana and Zimbabwe give way, moving north, to the highland and plateau country of Tanzania — a different kind of ground, with a different set of hazards, and a highway with its own name and its own history: the Tanzam. Manser's bicycle went that way. So, some years later, did Rigby's boots and McKenzie Barney's, on a bicycle of his own. So, on his own unscheduled itinerary, did Bakkes. That is the next road, and the next Part.



Part IV: The Tanzam Highway & East African Plateau

A road with an unusual origin story

Most roads in this book earned their difficulty from geology or climate — a mountain, a fog bank, a desert. The Tanzam earned part of its character from geopolitics, which is a rarer thing for a overland route to carry as visibly as this one does.

The Tanzania–Zambia corridor — the name “Tanzam” attaches most famously to the railway built through this stretch with Chinese assistance in the early 1970s, intended to give landlocked, copper-rich Zambia an export route to the Indian Ocean that did not depend on transit through white-minority-ruled Rhodesia or apartheid South Africa — sits alongside a road corridor that carries the same name and much of the same strategic logic. The railway and the road are not identical infrastructure, but they were conceived to solve the same problem, at the same historical moment, for the same reason: a country needed a way out that did not run through its unfriendly neighbours. That is an unusual thing for a “long road” to have as its founding purpose, set against Sani Pass’s function as a border crossing or the Skeleton Coast’s total indifference to any nation’s politics. The Tanzam is a road built, in part, out of Cold War-era regional politics, and it carries that history the way an old building carries the marks of the

argument that got it funded.

The wider regional context is worth a moment, because the Tanzam did not appear in a political vacuum but as one piece of a much larger and well-documented pattern across newly independent African states in the 1960s and 1970s: a continent-wide reordering of trade routes, transport corridors, and economic alliances as former colonies sought infrastructure that did not run through the remaining white-minority-ruled governments to their south. Zambia's situation was acute in a way few other landlocked nations of the era matched — a copper economy with no coastline of its own, bordered by Rhodesia, whose own unilateral declaration of independence in 1965 made co-operative transit arrangements politically untenable, and by a South Africa still years from the end of apartheid. A road or a railway built in this period, in this part of the continent, was rarely just civil engineering. It was a foreign-policy instrument as much as a supply chain, and the Tanzam corridor is one of the more legible surviving examples of that pattern still in daily use by ordinary long-distance travellers rather than preserved only in economic histories of the era.

Geographically, the corridor climbs out of the lower-lying country around Zambia's Copperbelt into the highland and plateau terrain that characterises much of Tanzania — cooler, greener, and at altitudes that change a cyclist's or a walker's physiology in ways the lowland stretches further south did not. It runs, broadly, toward the East African plateau and the country around Kilimanjaro and the Rift Valley's edge — a different climate band from anything this book has covered so far, and a different set of hazards: less about heat and dehydration, more about altitude, rain-season mud, and the sheer logistical friction of a road built to service freight rather than tourism.

The Rift Valley's edge is worth a plainer description than "different climate band," because what it actually does to the ground is specific and visible rather than abstract. The Great Rift is the surface expression of the African continent slowly pulling itself apart along a line that runs the length of East Africa, and the plateau this Part crosses sits along its western wall — a landscape of escarpments, volcanic highland, and valley floor dropped hundreds of metres below the sur-

rounding tableland, rather than the gentler undulation of the savannah country further south. A traveller does not need to know the tectonics to feel the consequence: the road climbs, drops, and climbs again in a way that a map's contour lines predict better than a traveller's legs do on any given day, and the altitude gained on one stretch is not necessarily kept on the next.

The same rifting that shapes a cyclist's gradient today shaped, over a far longer span, some of the ground where the human lineage's own fossil record is best preserved. Olduvai Gorge, cut into the Rift's floor in northern Tanzania not far from this Part's own corridor, has yielded hominin remains and stone tools spanning close to two million years, layered in volcanic ash beds that let geologists date each find with a precision the older, unlayered sediment elsewhere on the continent rarely allows. The gorge exists, in the plainest mechanical sense, because the same faulting that drops a valley floor below the surrounding tableland here also exposed, through subsequent erosion, a cross-section of deep time that a flatter landscape keeps buried. A traveller crossing this plateau is riding, in places a short detour from the road, over ground that has given up some of the oldest dated evidence of that lineage anywhere on Earth.

Altitude itself is worth naming plainly, because its effects are physiological rather than scenic and they do not discriminate between a cyclist, a walker, or a man riding whatever bus happens to be running. Above roughly two thousand metres — well within the range this stretch of highland reaches — the air carries measurably less oxygen per breath, and a body accustomed to sea-level or lowland exertion works harder for the same output: a faster resting pulse, a slower recovery after a climb, a thinner margin before real fatigue sets in. None of this is dramatic in the way a landslide or a border closure is dramatic. It is closer to a tax, levied continuously and almost invisibly, on every kilometre covered at height, and it falls hardest on exactly the kind of unsupported, self-propelled travel this Part is largely about — a walker or a cyclist cannot simply idle the engine and let a vehicle absorb the thinner air the way a motorised crossing further along this book's route can.

The plateau announces the altitude change before a traveller's body confirms it. The light thins first — a highland clarity to it, none of the haze that sits over the lower savannah country further south, so that a distant escarpment reads as a hard edge rather than a smudge on the horizon. Nights turn genuinely cold at this elevation, a fact that surprises travellers who arrived expecting Africa's heat as a constant and instead find themselves adding a layer after dark rather than shedding one. By day, the cold gives way fast: an equatorial sun at altitude burns without the lowland's humidity to soften it, so that shade and direct light can differ by ten or more degrees on the same stretch of road within the same hour. None of this is exotic weather. It is simply what altitude does to temperature and light everywhere it occurs, made vivid here by the contrast with everything this book has crossed before reaching it.

The Copperbelt itself deserves a sentence of its own, because it explains why a road exists here at all in the form it does. Zambia's copper deposits, among the richest on the continent, made the country's economy dependent from independence onward on a reliable route to a port — any port — that did not require negotiating transit through governments hostile to Zambia's own. The railway that shares the Tanzam name solved that problem for freight in the early 1970s; the road corridor this Part covers solved a parallel version of the same problem for everything a railway could not efficiently carry, and for every traveller, cyclist or pedestrian or motorcyclist, who had no practical way to book passage on a freight line built to move ore rather than people. The road, in other words, is not simply parallel infrastructure to the railway. It is what was left for anyone who was not copper.

The railway's own construction is part of what gives this stretch of country its particular flavour of history, and it is worth dwelling on rather than folding into a single clause. Built through difficult terrain — escarpment, river crossing, and the same highland relief this Part's road climbs — it stands as one of the largest single infrastructure commitments China made on the continent in that era, undertaken specifically because the traditional lenders and contractors available to a newly independent, landlocked, copper-dependent Zambia were themselves tied to the neighbouring governments Zambia was trying

to route around. A road and a railway, in other words, are not merely parallel because they run near each other; they are parallel because they were both, in their own infrastructural language, statements about which countries a young nation would and would not depend on for its survival. Every traveller who crosses this ground on a bicycle or on foot is crossing a landscape that was reshaped, within living memory, by a decision made in a conference room rather than by weather or by tectonic drift — a rarer kind of ground for this book to describe, and worth naming as such before the travellers themselves arrive.

The rain-season mud named earlier deserves its own moment, because “mud” undersells what a wet-season plateau surface actually does to wheeled and unwheeled travel alike. Tanzania’s highland rains do not arrive as a brief afternoon shower to be waited out under a tree; across the wetter months they turn the corridor’s unpaved and poorly drained stretches into a surface that grips a bicycle tyre, then releases it without warning, then grips again — a texture that punishes momentum rather than rewarding it, in a landscape where momentum is often the only thing standing between a rider and the next uphill grade. A road built for freight lorries tolerates this differently than a road built for cars: heavy vehicles compress and rut the surface into troughs that hold water long after the rain has passed, so that the corridor a walker or cyclist crosses in the dry season and the corridor they cross in the wet season are, in any practical sense, two different roads wearing the same name.

How a railway like this actually gets built

It is worth pausing on the mechanics of the Tanzam railway’s construction rather than leaving it as a single sentence about Chinese assistance and Cold War motive, because the how of the thing explains the corridor’s texture as much as the why. Building a rail line through this kind of escarpment and highland terrain is not a matter of laying track across flat ground and moving on; it demands cuttings blasted through rock, embankments raised across river valleys, and bridges engineered to survive a rainy season capable of turning a dry watercourse into a torrent within hours. Work of this kind, in the early 1970s,

before modern earthmoving machinery was standard equipment on a project of this scale in this part of the world, relied heavily on labour-intensive methods: large workforces moving earth and rock by hand and with basic mechanical assistance, camps of workers housed for years at a stretch along a route hundreds of kilometres from the nearest established town, and a construction timeline measured in years rather than months precisely because the terrain gave up no shortcuts. The railway was completed over roughly five years, opening to traffic in the mid-1970s — a pace that, for a single-track line through this kind of country, was considered fast at the time, and was achieved specifically because the scale of imported labour and material allowed work to proceed on multiple sections of the route simultaneously rather than advancing end to end.

The workforce behind that pace is itself worth naming rather than folding into the word “labour” and moving on. Tens of thousands of Chinese workers and engineers were posted to the project across its construction, living alongside a larger Zambian and Tanzanian workforce recruited locally for the same job, the two groups sharing camps, tools, and a construction timeline neither could have met alone. It was, at the time, one of the largest transfers of Chinese personnel to the African continent for a single infrastructure project, financed through an interest-free loan from Beijing to Lusaka and Dar es Salaam rather than through the World Bank or the Western lenders that had already declined to fund a railway serving a route explicitly designed to bypass their own allies’ territory. The arrangement was as political as the road above it: China’s willingness to fund and staff a project the Cold War’s other major powers would not touch was itself a foreign-policy statement, aimed at newly independent African states more than at Zambia and Tanzania alone. Workers on both sides paid a human cost the finished line does not advertise — the terrain that made the engineering difficult made the labour dangerous in the same measure, and construction of this kind, in this period, in this terrain, did not proceed without loss of life among the workforce, Chinese and African alike, a fact the railway’s own commemorative cemeteries in Zambia and Tanzania still register long after the political rivalry that funded the line has faded into history.

None of this construction history is abstract to a modern traveller crossing the same ground by bicycle or on foot. The road corridor this Part actually follows shares its route, in long stretches, with the rail alignment those construction crews carved two generations ago, and the same escarpment that made the railway's cuttings expensive to blast is the escarpment that makes today's road climb and drop the way it does. A cyclist grinding up a gradient on this corridor is, in a literal sense, following the path of least resistance that a nineteen-seventies survey team identified as the best available compromise between distance and slope — the road did not choose its own gradient any more than the railway did; both were constrained by the same rock.

The highland plateau this corridor climbs into is not simply cooler and greener as scenery; it is some of the most productive agricultural ground on the continent, and the reason traces back to the same rift geology this Part has already described. Volcanic activity along the Rift's edge, over a very long span of geological time, has laid down deep deposits of mineral-rich ash and weathered volcanic rock across much of this highland belt, producing soils considerably more fertile than the older, more leached ground typical of much of the rest of the continent's interior. That soil, combined with the cooler temperatures and more reliable rainfall altitude brings, is why this stretch of East Africa supports some of the world's most significant coffee- and tea-growing regions, an agricultural economy built directly on top of the same tectonic and volcanic history that gives the corridor its climbing, dropping profile. A traveller crossing this ground on a bicycle experiences the altitude as a physiological tax, paid one climb at a time; the same altitude, over a much longer timescale, is the reason there is a settled, cultivated, comparatively prosperous farming population living along this corridor at all, rather than the thinner subsistence agriculture the region's rainfall alone, at lower and hotter elevations, would otherwise support. The mountain that punishes the rider's lungs is the same mountain that feeds the people living on it.

The coffee and tea worth naming here are not an interchangeable pair of highland cash crops but two plants asking for slightly different altitudes and slightly different attention, which is itself a consequence

of the same terrain a cyclist feels as inconsistency underfoot. Arabica coffee, the variety that dominates the slopes around Kilimanjaro and the volcanic highlands further into Kenya, wants exactly the cooler, higher ground this corridor's climbs deliver and struggles in the lower, hotter country a rider descends into between ranges — a crop, in other words, planted precisely where the altitude tax this Part has already described is at its steepest, because that is the only ground where it thrives. Tea prefers similar elevation but tolerates a wetter, mistier microclimate, and the smallholder tea gardens that carpet parts of the Kenyan highland rim owe their existence to the same rainfall pattern that turns this corridor's unpaved stretches to mud in the wet season. Neither crop grows by accident on this ground; both are a direct agricultural translation of the rift's volcanic soil and its altitude-driven rainfall, planted by generations of farmers who read the same climate a touring cyclist experiences as fatigue and a shivering night as, instead, a growing season.

Kilimanjaro itself, standing apart from the rift's own escarpment rather than sitting on it, deserves a word beyond its role as a coffee landmark, because the mountain is a distinct geological feature in its own right rather than simply the tallest hill visible from this corridor's climbs. It is a free-standing volcanic massif, not part of the rift wall proper but built by its own separate history of eruption, rising alone from the surrounding plain to a summit high enough to carry permanent ice within a few degrees of the equator — a fact that has drawn climbers and scientists to it for longer than any traveller in this Part has been crossing the plateau below. That summit ice has been in documented retreat for more than a century, its glaciers shrinking measurably within living memory, a slow and well-recorded diminishment of the one genuinely permanent-seeming feature on a mountain that otherwise looks, from the road, exactly as fixed as it did to the first surveyors who mapped it. A cyclist grinding past its lower slopes registers Kilimanjaro as scenery, a fixed point against which to measure the day's progress. The mountain itself, on a timescale no single crossing could reveal, is not fixed at all.

Three travellers, one stretch of highland

This Part's ground is crossed by three named travellers whose journeys, taken together, illustrate this book's whole method: the same highland road, crossed on foot, by paired bicycle, and by a man keeping no itinerary at all.

Mario Rigby: the walk continues

Mario Rigby's solo walk across Africa, begun in November 2015 through the southern corridor this book covered in Part III, continued north through Tanzania and Kenya as part of the same unsupported, on-foot crossing — two of the nine countries on his full route, and two of the more physically demanding, given the altitude change and the plateau's own weather patterns.

What the Tanzam and East African plateau stretch adds to Rigby's account, more than any single new hazard, is duration under a different kind of strain: by the time he reached this stretch he had already been walking for the better part of a year, through southern Africa's savannah and coastal lowland, and the shift onto higher, cooler ground changed the physical experience of the walk without changing its fundamental terms — every kilometre still covered on foot, still unsupported, still carrying whatever he needed rather than resupplying from a vehicle. The full account of his walk's nine countries and its January 2018 completion belongs to Part V. Here, in Tanzania and Kenya, he is roughly at the walk's midpoint, on ground that asked something different of him than the coast had.

Altitude acclimatization is worth naming as a general physiological process here, distinct from any claim about Rigby's own condition on a particular day, because it is the mechanism underneath whatever this stretch actually cost him. A body gradually adjusts to reduced oxygen availability over days and weeks at elevation — increased breathing rate, changes in blood chemistry that improve oxygen carriage, a slow recalibration of what counts as a normal effort — but that adjustment is neither instant nor complete, and it resets, at least partially, when-

ever a traveller descends and re-ascends, as this stretch's alternating highland-and-valley profile repeatedly demanded. A walker crossing this ground once, west to east or south to north, does not get the luxury of a controlled, one-way acclimatization schedule the way a mountaineer planning a single summit push might. The terrain's own up-and-down profile forces a body to keep re-adapting rather than settling into one stable new baseline, which is one further reason this stretch asked something structurally different of a walker than either the lowland savannah behind him or the desert still ahead.

Tanzania and Kenya are not, geologically, a single uniform stretch of highland, even though this book groups them within one Part for the sake of the road that links them. The crossing from one into the other carries a walker from Tanzania's own share of the plateau into Kenya's, where the same Rift Valley system that shapes the ground further south continues north in a different register — the valley floor around Kenya's own lakes sitting lower and hotter than the surrounding highland rim, so that a walker descending into it after days spent at altitude experiences something close to the inverse of what climbing onto the plateau in the first place demanded: a rapid drop in elevation, a rapid rise in heat, and a rapid return, within a comparatively short distance, of the kind of dehydration risk the cooler highland had temporarily set aside. Rigby's route through this stretch, in other words, did not simply trade heat for altitude once and settle into a single new baseline. It traded one for the other and back again, more than once, as the ground itself refused to hold still.

Kenya's Rift Valley lakes are worth a further word, because several of them are a distinctive product of the same geology rather than ordinary bodies of freshwater sitting in a low place. A number of the lakes strung along the valley floor here have no outlet to the sea; rainfall and mineral-laden runoff enter them and leave again only by evaporation, a closed system that concentrates dissolved salts and soda over time until the water turns caustic and alkaline, unfit to drink and inhospitable to most ordinary freshwater life. It is a landscape that looks, from a distance, like any other lake country and behaves, up close, like almost nowhere else this route has crossed: shorelines crusted white with mineral deposit at the waterline, an ecology built around

organisms — certain algae, certain crustaceans — able to tolerate a chemistry that would be lethal to the fish and amphibians of an ordinary freshwater system elsewhere on the continent. None of this made the valley floor easier on a walker passing through it rather than skirting it at a distance. Water that cannot be drunk without treatment is a harder constraint on a foot crossing than clean water would be, one more variable added to an already tight daily calculation of what could be carried and what could be found.

A walk of this length accumulates its difficulty differently from a shorter journey, and the plateau stretch is where that accumulation becomes structurally important to the achievement as a whole. The first months of an undertaking like this test a traveller's preparation and resolve; the middle months, on unfamiliar and physically demanding new terrain, test whether the traveller who set out still exists in any recognisable form, or whether the person crossing Tanzania's highlands has become, through sheer sustained repetition, someone functionally different from the one who left South Africa's coast the previous November. Nothing in the sourced record allows this book to say which was true for Rigby specifically. What can be said is only the structural fact: nine countries, roughly 12,000 kilometres, just over two years, and Tanzania and Kenya sitting almost exactly at the walk's chronological centre — the section of the journey furthest, in both directions, from either a fresh start or an imminent finish, and for that reason likely the section where the walk was, in the plainest sense, hardest to keep believing in.

The arithmetic of the walk is worth setting down plainly, because it says something the narrative account alone does not. Twelve thousand kilometres over a little more than two years works out to something in the neighbourhood of fifteen kilometres a day, sustained, on average, across every kind of ground the continent offered — savannah, coastal lowland, and now this Part's climbing highland, where fifteen kilometres of altitude-gained ground costs a walker considerably more than fifteen kilometres of flat coastal track did months earlier. An average conceals its own worst days: a walker does not bank distance ahead of schedule on the easy stretches and spend it later on the hard ones, not in any literal sense, because the body that covered

twenty kilometres on flat ground in the morning does not necessarily have twenty more in it once the road tilts uphill into thinner air in the afternoon. What the average actually represents, on ground like this Part's plateau, is closer to a target quietly renegotiated every single day against whatever the legs and the altitude allowed that day, added up only afterward into a tidy figure.

There is also a logistical fact about unsupported walking worth making explicit here, because it distinguishes Rigby's crossing of this stretch from every wheeled account in this Part. A cyclist carries momentum a walker does not have and can, within limits, coast; a walker's entire energy budget for a given day is spent by the same two legs that will also need to carry him the next day, and the next, with no mechanical assistance to bank against tomorrow's fatigue. Water and food on a plateau route without reliable resupply become, for a walker, a heavier calculation than for a rider who can carry more weight on a frame rather than a back, or cover the distance between water sources in a fraction of the time on foot. None of this appears as a single dramatic incident in the sourced record of Rigby's crossing. It is, instead, the daily arithmetic underneath the nine-country, twelve-thousand-kilometre total — the kind of cost a walk like this pays in small denominations, every day, rather than all at once.

A project of two years and more has a structure to its motivation that a shorter undertaking does not share, and it is worth naming the shape of that structure rather than the specific feeling, since nothing in the sourced record permits this book to describe Rigby's own state of mind. Near a beginning, a traveller draws on the novelty of the thing itself and the freshness of a decision only just acted on; near an end, a traveller draws on proximity, the visible shrinking of what remains. The middle of a two-year walk has neither resource in any strong form — the novelty has worn thin somewhere in the preceding year, and the end is still too far off to supply momentum of its own. What a traveller draws on instead, at the walk's structural centre, can only be the plain fact of having already covered a great deal of ground and the plainer fact of having committed to cover the rest — neither the excitement of the start nor the relief of the finish, but the flatter, less quotable discipline of continuing because continuing is what the project has always

required. This book states that as a structural observation about long undertakings in general, not a claim about what Rigby himself felt on any particular day on this stretch of highland.

McKenzie Barney and Jim: paired cycling

McKenzie Barney's Cairo-to-Cape Town bicycle journey — undertaken with a partner named Jim, ten countries, roughly 11,000 kilometres, five months — is distinct from every other cycling account in this book in one specific and important respect: it was not a solo endeavour. Manser rode alone. Longueira and Beaumont, whose record chain this book covers in Part VI, each rode alone, in direct competition with the clock and, indirectly, with each other. Barney rode with a partner, and the account of the journey explicitly credits Riaan Manser as an inspiration for undertaking it — a usable braid point between two of this book's cycling subjects, one inspiring the other across more than a decade and several thousand kilometres of difference in route and pace.

Paired travel changes the texture of a journey in ways solo travel does not, and it is worth naming those differences plainly rather than treating "two cyclists" as a minor variation on "one cyclist." A pair can share the logistical load — navigation, repairs, the decision of when to push on and when to stop — in a way a solo traveller cannot, and a pair also carries a second person's judgment into every decision a solo traveller would otherwise make alone. Neither of these is straightforwardly an advantage; a pair can also disagree, at exactly the moment a decision needs to be made fast, in a way a solo rider's argument with himself resolves rather more quickly. Barney and Jim's route through the Tanzam corridor and the East African plateau — part of their broader ten-country, five-month, roughly 11,000-kilometre crossing from Cairo to Cape Town — put two riders through the same highland terrain Rigby crossed on foot and Manser had crossed by bicycle years before, on a route explicitly chosen, in Barney's own account, because Manser had proven a version of it possible first.

There is also a specific, practical calculus a paired ride changes that

a solo one does not, worth naming because it bears directly on how a traveller experiences a hazard-dense corridor like this one: a mechanical failure, in remote terrain, is a different problem for two riders than for one. Where Manser, alone, would have had to solve a broken chain or a failed bearing entirely on his own resources and whatever local help he could find along the road, a paired ride carries built-in redundancy — a second set of tools, a second pair of hands, someone to watch the bikes while the other searches out water or help. That redundancy does not make the corridor easier in any absolute sense; the border posts still close without notice, the landslides still happen, the heat still climbs past what either rider would have chosen. But it changes the shape of what a single failure costs, and it is one honest, structural reason a compendium organised by expedition type, rather than simply by distance covered, insists on treating “solo” and “paired” as genuinely different categories of risk rather than a rounding difference between one cyclist and two.

Barney’s own account, cited in this book’s sourcing as explicitly naming Manser’s circumnavigation as an inspiration, is worth returning to for what it says about how one traveller’s achievement can seed another’s more than a decade later. Manser’s ride ended in 2005. Barney and Jim’s ride does not carry a single confirmed departure year in this book’s sourcing beyond its place in the broader Cairo-to-Cape-Town tradition this Part and the last have described, but the causal line the source material draws — Manser’s proof that the corridor could be ridden feeding directly into a later rider’s decision to attempt a version of it himself — is exactly the kind of braid this compendium was built to surface: not a shared date or a shared record, but a shared road, crossed once and then crossed again because the first crossing proved it was possible.

Ten countries in five months, set against Manser’s thirty-four countries in a little over two years, is worth reading as a pace comparison rather than only a distance comparison, because pace is what a paired ride is actually optimising for in a way a full continental circumnavigation is not. Eleven thousand kilometres over five months averages out to something in the range of seventy kilometres a day, sustained — well short of the roughly hundred kilometres Manser himself covered on his

solo circuit, but sustained by two riders whose bicycles, on a highland stretch like the Tanzam plateau, each carry their own share of food, water, and repair kit rather than splitting a single load between them. A pair does not simply halve the weight one rider would otherwise carry; each bicycle still needs to be self-sufficient enough to survive a day on which the two riders are, for whatever reason, briefly separated by a mechanical problem, a puncture, or simply a hill climbed at two different speeds. The redundancy the pairing buys, in other words, is not free — it is bought with two complete sets of gear rather than one lighter, shared set, a trade a solo rider like Manser never had to make and a trade that shapes, in small ways invisible to a passing observer, exactly how much weight each of Barney and Jim's bicycles carried up this Part's climbs.

A five-month schedule against a ten-country route also creates a specific kind of daily negotiation that a solo circumnavigation on a two-year timeline does not need to have. Manser, alone, set his own pace against his own body's recovery and answered to no one else's opinion about when the day's riding was done. Two riders sharing a five-month budget for eleven thousand kilometres are, in effect, running a shared clock neither one controls outright: a bad day for one rider is a bad day for the schedule both are keeping, and a strong day for the other does not bank extra kilometres against it the way a solo rider's own strong day might let him coast the next. Nothing in this book's sourcing describes a specific disagreement between Barney and Jim on this stretch of highland, and none will be invented here. What can be said, structurally, is only that a paired schedule of this length requires continuous, low-grade agreement — about pace, about when to stop for the night, about how much a climb like this Part's escarpment should be allowed to cost the following day's distance — in a way a solo rider's internal calculation, however difficult, never has to be spoken aloud, tested against another person's fatigue, or revised out loud at the roadside.

Bakkes: Tanzania, Malawi, Kenya

Johan Bakkes travelled through Tanzania, Malawi, and Kenya across his working life, in the manner that by now this book's readers will recognise: not as a single expedition with a stated start and finish, but as ground revisited, known, and written about across an essay-collection body of work rather than a travel ledger.

Malawi sits slightly outside this Part's core Tanzam corridor in the strictest geographic sense — it borders the route rather than sitting directly on the highway line — but belongs here rather than being left out entirely, because Bakkes's own travel did not organise itself by the same route-corridor logic this book imposes for the sake of structure. He went to Malawi. He went to Tanzania. He went to Kenya. The compendium's job, in cases like this, is to place his travel by region as accurately as the sourced record allows, rather than force it into a corridor it may not have literally followed, and Tanzania, Malawi, and Kenya together form the honest regional grouping his own travels support for this stretch of the continent.

Malawi's own geography is worth a sentence, because it is not simply "somewhere near Tanzania" but a country defined almost entirely by the same Rift Valley system this Part has already described further north — the Great Rift's southern extension carrying the enormous trench of Lake Malawi down the country's eastern length, a body of water long enough that it functions less like a lake in the familiar sense and more like an inland sea, with its own weather and its own fishing economy along its shore. A traveller moving through Malawi is moving along the same tectonic scar this Part's opening described in Tanzania and Kenya, simply further south and filled with water rather than dry highland. It is a fitting piece of ground for Bakkes specifically to have crossed on no fixed itinerary, since the Rift's presence there is a fact of the landscape whether or not a traveller's route was ever plotted with it in mind.

Lake Malawi's own character deserves a further sentence, because a rift lake of this depth and age behaves differently from an ordinary inland lake in ways that shape the whole economy along its shore. Rift lakes of this kind are geologically old and unusually deep — deep

enough, in Lake Malawi's case, that the water column stratifies into layers that barely mix, an isolation that has, over a very long span of time, allowed an extraordinary diversity of fish species to evolve within a single body of water rather than across an entire river system. That biological richness is not scenery; it is the basis of a fishing economy that has sustained shoreline communities for generations, and it is one more instance of a pattern this Part keeps returning to — a landscape shaped by the Rift's slow violence producing, given enough time, a settled and fed population living directly on top of the geology rather than in spite of it. A tavern on Lake Malawi's shore, of the kind Bakkes made his research method, sits on ground that is at once one of the more dangerous tectonic features on the continent and one of the more productive.

This same rift system carved a second, larger trench further west, and briefly setting Lake Malawi against it sharpens what makes both lakes unusual rather than merely large. Lake Tanganyika sits along the western branch of the Great Rift, a separate fracture running roughly parallel to the eastern branch this Part has already described beneath Tanzania and Kenya. By depth it is the second-deepest freshwater lake on the planet, exceeded only by Siberia's Lake Baikal, a consequence of the same rifting process carving a trench far more dramatic than an ordinary lake basin ever produces. Both lakes share the same isolating stratification that has driven Lake Malawi's fish diversity, and both have become, for exactly that reason, sites of what biologists call adaptive radiation: a single ancestral fish population, sealed into one deep basin for millions of years, diversifying into hundreds of distinct species found nowhere else on Earth. Tanganyika's greater depth and older age have produced an even more extreme degree of endemism than Malawi's. They are siblings in the most literal geological sense, two deep scars along the same continental fracture, each turned by isolation into its own closed cabinet of evolution.

What can be said with more specificity is the method, because the method is consistent across every region he crossed: public transport through remote areas where a scheduled bus was not a guaranteed thing, motorcycle where the road or his own preference called for it, and long stretches on foot. He used, by his own account and repu-

tation, the local tavern as a research tool wherever he travelled — “a town’s soul,” in the closest paraphrase this book’s sourcing supports for how he described the method’s value — and there is no reason to think East Africa was an exception to a habit this consistent across the rest of his documented travel. He was, in his own words, “a professional hobo” long before that stretch of highland plateau, and nothing in the record suggests the plateau changed the description.

It is worth setting this method against the three other travellers this Part has already described, because the contrast is instructive rather than merely different. Rigby’s walk, Manser’s ride, and Barney and Jim’s paired crossing were each, in their own way, built around forward motion as the organising principle — every day’s business was to cover distance, whatever the terrain demanded in exchange. Bakkes’s travel through this same region followed no comparable discipline. A public bus that did not run on a given day was not a delay to be absorbed on the way to a finish line; it was, if anything, an opportunity to spend an extra evening in whatever town the bus had failed to leave, talking to whoever was in the bar that night. This is not a claim that his travel was undisciplined — the copper bangles, the nineteen canyon crossings, and the eight carefully dated books argue otherwise — but that the discipline organised itself around depth of encounter rather than rate of progress, which is precisely the distinction this book’s style guide insists on preserving between him and every other traveller in this compendium.

There is a structural reason, too, why this Part groups Tanzania, Malawi, and Kenya together for Bakkes specifically, where it treats Rigby’s and Barney’s crossings of the same countries as part of a single continuous route. His travel through this region did not observe the same order a north-south or south-north expedition necessarily imposes on its own itinerary — a walker or a cyclist crossing Tanzania before Kenya, or Kenya before Tanzania, because the geography of a single continuous journey requires it. Bakkes’s travel, assembled from an essay collection rather than a route log, offers no comparable sequence to preserve, and this book has chosen, honestly, to present the three countries as a regional grouping rather than invent an order the source material does not supply.

This is, in fact, a structural habit worth naming for what it is rather than treating as simply an absence of a route log. The critic Justin Fox, writing about Bakkes's craft elsewhere in this book, noted his recurring use of teaser openings, flashbacks, and historical parallel — a writer's method, not a traveller's, but one that explains why his own account of a place like Tanzania or Kenya reads as a return to ground already half-known rather than a discovery of new territory. A travel writer who structures his sentences around flashback and parallel is, almost by definition, someone for whom a place is never visited only once in the telling, even if the body only passed through it once or twice in fact. *Hou die kruit droog*, the 2021 collection of his Facebook posts and reflections, is the clearest evidence of the method applied to exactly this kind of loosely dated, regionally scattered material — dispatches written closer to the moment than a formal travelogue, gathered afterward into a book rather than planned as one from the outset. It is a fitting form for a man whose East African travel this book can place by region and by habit, but not by a tidy itinerary, because it was never assembled as one to begin with.

Four ways to cross the same plateau

It is worth pausing here, before this Part closes, to hold all three named travellers — and the composite weight of every other cyclist and motorcyclist who has crossed this same corridor on the strength of Manser's or Rigby's example — against each other on the identical stretch of highland ground, because the contrast is precisely what this compendium was built to show rather than an incidental byproduct of covering more than one traveller per Part. Rigby crossed the plateau at walking pace, roughly fifteen kilometres a day, every metre of altitude gained and lost registering directly in his legs and his lungs, with no mechanical buffer between his body and the gradient. Barney and Jim crossed it faster and lighter in relative terms, at something nearer seventy kilometres a day, but paid for that speed with two complete sets of gear, two sets of legs that had to agree, in practice, on when to stop. Manser, years before either of them, crossed a version of this same highland country as one part of a circumnavigation whose

ambition was never speed but completeness — every coastal country touched, thirty-four in total, at a pace nearer a hundred kilometres a day sustained across more than two years, a different arithmetic entirely from either Rigby's or Barney's. And Bakkes crossed it, or ground very like it, on foot, by motorcycle, and by whatever bus happened to be running that week, with no finish line at all — his object was never to leave the plateau behind as quickly or as thoroughly as possible, but to know it, tavern by tavern, the way none of this Part's other three travellers had the luxury of time to do. Four bodies, four speeds, four sets of priorities, crossing terrain that does not change its altitude or its weather to accommodate any of them.

Four Parts in, a pattern worth naming

By this point in the book, a reader has crossed four of its six roads, and it is worth pausing on what those four crossings, considered together rather than one Part at a time, actually argue. Sani Pass and the Skeleton Coast were roads defined by a single hazard each — a mountain pass's altitude and hairpins, a coastline's fog and wrecks. The Cape-to-Cairo corridor's southern stretch and this Part's highland both cover a different kind of ground: not one hazard but a compounding sequence of them, borders and terrain and weather stacked one on top of the next across thousands of kilometres rather than concentrated in a single dramatic pass. That shift, from a road defined by one crossing to a road defined by an accumulation, is not incidental to how this book is built. It is close to the whole argument: that "crossing Africa" is not one achievement but several genuinely different kinds of achievement, depending on whether the traveller is answering a mountain, a coastline, or a continent's whole length.

The four expedition types this book has shown so far — solo circumnavigation, solo walking, paired cycling, and a working life of unscheduled wandering — do not compete with each other in any sense that would let this book rank them. Manser's circumnavigation and Rigby's walk cover comparable distances by entirely different means and arrive at entirely different kinds of claim: Manser's is a claim about completeness, every coastal country touched; Rigby's is a claim about method,

the same continent covered by a single pair of legs with no mechanical assistance at any point. Barney and Jim's paired ride answers a third question, about what two people moving together can sustain that one person moving alone cannot, and pays for the answer in duplicated gear and continuous shared judgment. Bakkes answers a fourth question entirely, one the other three do not ask at all: what a place yields to a traveller who is not trying to finish it. Four roads in, the book has not yet introduced its fifth kind of achievement — the timed record, still to come — nor its sixth, the vehicle-based humanitarian expedition. But the shape of the argument is already visible: each new Part has added a genuinely different answer to the same question, not a harder version of the answer already given.

The road as freight corridor, still

It is worth closing this Part with the detail that opened it, because it explains something about why this stretch of road feels different from the others in this book even when the travellers crossing it experienced broadly similar hazards to the corridor further south: the Tanzam was built, and is still used, primarily to move copper and other freight, not people on holiday or people chasing a personal best. Every traveller in this Part — walker, paired cyclists, wandering essayist — was, in a real sense, a guest on infrastructure built for someone else's cargo. That is true of most roads in this book to some degree, but it is more visible here, on a corridor whose name still carries the initials of the two countries it was built to connect for reasons that had nothing to do with anyone's adventure.

Sharing a road with freight traffic, rather than with tourism infrastructure built to receive a cyclist or a walker, has practical consequences worth naming plainly. A route built for long-haul lorries carrying copper concentrate to a port does not maintain shoulder space, rest stops, or water points with a bicycle or a pair of boots in mind; it maintains them, where it maintains them at all, with a fourteen-wheel vehicle's needs in view, which is a different set of needs entirely from a cyclist's need for a shaded verge or a walker's need for a village well within a day's reach. Every traveller in this Part negotiated a road that

was never designed to notice them, in a way a purpose-built tourist route — the kind Egypt maintains at the far end of this book's next Part — simply does not require its visitors to negotiate. That is one further, quiet distinction between the corridors this compendium covers: some roads were built to be crossed by people like the travellers in this book; the Tanzam was not, and everyone who has crossed it on foot, by bicycle, or without any fixed itinerary at all has had to make do with infrastructure indifferent to their presence.

There is a further irony worth naming in how the balance between road and rail has shifted since the railway's completion in the 1970s. The line was built as the primary answer to Zambia's export problem, with the road corridor conceived as secondary, general-purpose infrastructure alongside it. In the decades since, road transport has taken up a larger share of the copper corridor's freight than the railway's original planners are likely to have anticipated — a pattern repeated across much of the developing world in the same period, as trucking's flexibility, door-to-door delivery, and lower fixed capital cost eroded rail's advantage on corridors where the rail line itself required costly ongoing maintenance through difficult terrain. The road this Part's travellers cross, in other words, has grown busier with exactly the kind of heavy freight traffic the railway was originally meant to absorb, which is one further reason a cyclist or a walker on this corridor shares tarmac with more long-haul trucking than a traveller on this same road might have found forty years earlier, when the railway was still doing more of the work it was built for.

North of the plateau, the ground changes again, and so does the water that defines it. The road that follows the Nile north is the oldest travelled corridor on the continent, in the oldest sense of the word, and it closes with three of this book's travellers converging on the same river system from three different directions and speeds.

Part V: The Nile Road North

The oldest corridor

Every other road in this book is, in some sense, a modern imposition on old ground — a bridle path turned into a mountain pass, a colonial railway ambition turned into a tour operator's marketing copy. The Nile corridor is different in kind, not just in age. Human settlement has followed this river, in some form, for longer than most of the rest of this book's roads have existed as concepts, let alone routes. Ethiopia, Sudan, and Egypt — the three countries this Part covers — sit along a river system that has organised agriculture, trade, migration, and, eventually, tourism and overlanding, for a span of time this book's other five Parts do not attempt to match.

The corridor this Part covers runs from the Ethiopian highlands, where the Blue Nile rises, down through Sudan's stretch of desert and confluence — where the Blue Nile meets the White Nile at Khartoum — and on into Egypt, where the river does the work it has always been most famous for: carrying a civilization's food and history along a single green ribbon through an otherwise lethal desert. It is a corridor with more recorded human history attached to it than any other in this book, and also, for the modern overlander, one of the more logistically demanding stretches of the whole Cape-to-Cairo route — Sudan and Egypt both requiring the kind of permit and border planning that the more tourism-adapted stretches further south do not.

The confluence at Khartoum deserves a moment of its own, because it is one of the few points on this entire compendium's map where

two separate river systems, each with its own source, its own character, and its own drainage basin, physically become one. The Blue Nile arrives from the Ethiopian highlands carrying the bulk of the sediment that has historically made Egypt's floodplain fertile — the annual flood that built an entire civilization's agricultural calendar around it originated overwhelmingly in Ethiopian rainfall, not in the White Nile's own much longer but gentler course from the Great Lakes region further south and west. The White Nile, by contrast, is the more consistent of the two through the dry season, its flow buffered by the lakes and swamps along its much longer upstream course. Two rivers, then, with two entirely different personalities — one seasonal and violent, one steady and mild — meeting at a single city and continuing north as a single name, carrying both characters forward into the stretch of desert that, without either contribution, would have supported no continuous civilization at all.

The Nile's role in human history is, in outline, common knowledge rather than a claim this book needs to source to any single traveller's account, and it is worth stating plainly rather than skipped past on the assumption the reader already holds it: the river's predictable annual flood, before the twentieth century's dams tamed it, deposited the silt that made settled agriculture, and eventually one of the world's oldest continuous civilizations, possible along an otherwise inhospitable desert corridor. Travel along the Nile is, in the plainest sense, older than travel along any other road in this book by a margin measured in millennia rather than centuries — river craft, caravan routes, and eventually rail and road all following, in their turn, the same green line through the same desert, because the alternative, on either side of the river, was simply the Sahara or its eastern equivalent, with no comparable reason for anyone to cross it.

A second ancient civilization belongs on this corridor's map alongside Egypt's, worth naming before this Part's own travellers arrive, because it explains why the Ethiopian highlands the Blue Nile rises from carry a weight of settled history that a visitor crossing purely for the river's source might otherwise miss. The Aksumite kingdom, centred in the highlands of what is now northern Ethiopia and neighbouring Eritrea, rose to become one of the ancient world's genuine powers, trading

across the Red Sea with Rome, Persia, and India, minting its own coinage, and adopting Christianity as a state religion in the fourth century — among the earliest states anywhere to do so, and centuries before the faith took hold as an official religion in most of Europe. Its rulers raised monumental carved stone stelae, some standing several storeys tall, to mark royal tombs, and the surviving examples still stand in the modern town of Aksum, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, as one of the few places on this compendium's whole route where the built evidence of a civilization predating every road this book describes still stands in daylight rather than under sand or beneath a modern city. Aksum's decline, by the time later centuries brought different kingdoms and different trade routes to prominence, left the highlands as a place where a river's spiritual and practical importance had already been understood and organised around for well over a thousand years before any bicycle, motorcycle, or overland vehicle in this compendium reached the same watershed. A traveller following the Blue Nile to its source today is retracing, without necessarily meaning to, a stretch of ground that was central to an African empire's own sense of itself long before it became one line on a modern overlander's map.

The river itself was never a uniformly navigable highway, and the historical record is plain enough on this point to state without needing a named traveller to confirm it: a series of cataracts — stretches where rock outcrops break the Nile's surface into rapids and shallows unnavigable by anything but the smallest craft — historically interrupted through-passage along the river's Sudanese and southern Egyptian reaches, forcing overland portage around each obstruction for as long as river transport has existed on this stretch of the Nile. A road running roughly parallel to the river, rather than a single unbroken waterway, is in this sense not a modern overlander's convenience but the oldest working solution to a problem the river itself has always posed: the water carries you most of the way, and something built on land has to carry you past the rest. The overland route this Part's travellers followed, in other words, is heir to a portage tradition considerably older than any of them, doing on wheels or on foot what a boatman's crew has always had to do around a cataract — get out, and walk the gap the river itself refuses to open.

Sudan's own stretch of this river carries a civilization of its own, one considerably less familiar to most readers than Egypt's but no less ancient, and it deserves naming before this Part settles into treating Sudan mainly as a bureaucratic obstacle between Ethiopia and Egypt. The kingdom of Kush, centred for much of its long history around the Nile's confluence region and further north toward the cataracts, was Egypt's southern neighbour, rival, and — for roughly a century around the eighth and seventh centuries BCE — its conqueror, a Kushite dynasty ruling as Egypt's own pharaohs before being pushed back south again. Kush outlasted that episode by well over a thousand years, developing its own writing system, its own pyramids — smaller and steeper than Egypt's, but more numerous, with a larger surviving count on Sudanese soil today than on Egyptian — and its own long tradition of ironworking centred on the city of Meroë, whose slag heaps still mark the ground as evidence of a metalworking industry that once supplied a wide stretch of the ancient Nile valley. Almost none of this history registers with the modern overlander crossing Sudan for its permits and its heat; the country's ancient weight sits mostly unvisited beside a route built for entirely different, contemporary reasons, one more instance of this corridor holding more recorded human history than any traveller passing through it in a single crossing has time to notice.

Where the river was navigable, it was worked for millennia by a specific and still-visible craft: the felucca, a wooden sailboat rigged with a single broad triangular sail, cut for exactly the conditions the Nile's Egyptian stretch offers — a steady, moderate wind and a current running the opposite direction, so that a boat can sail upstream against the flow and drift back down again with it, using wind and current as two halves of the same round trip rather than fighting either one. Boats of recognisably this design carried grain, stone, and people along the river for thousands of years before any engine existed to compete with them, and they were, for most of that span, not a romantic alternative to travel but the only practical one: overland movement away from the river's immediate banks meant desert on both sides, so the felucca and its predecessors were not one transport option among several but close to the only option there was for moving anything heavier than a

person could carry on foot. The tourist feluccas that still carry visitors along the Nile's Egyptian reach today are a direct, functioning descendant of that working history, not a themed re-creation of it — a rare case, in a compendium mostly concerned with roads that erase or replace what came before them, of a mode of travel that never stopped being used long enough to need reviving.

None of this book's overland travellers crossed this corridor in a political vacuum, and it is worth naming plainly why Sudan and Egypt's border and permit bureaucracy runs deeper here than almost anywhere else this book covers: three countries share one river, and a river that determines whether a nation's agriculture survives the dry season is not a resource any of the three governments has ever been able to treat casually. Egypt's modern water security rests on the Aswan High Dam, completed in the 1970s, which tamed the Nile's ancient annual flood into a managed, storable reservoir — Lake Nasser — trading the old rhythm of silt-bearing inundation for controlled, year-round irrigation and hydroelectric power, at the cost of the very sediment deposition that built the floodplain in the first place. That dam sits downstream of every drop of water Ethiopia's highlands contribute through the Blue Nile, and Ethiopia's own construction, decades later, of a major hydroelectric dam on the Blue Nile itself has made the same river that gives this Part its name a live, contested diplomatic question between the two countries and Sudan, sitting between them, well into the twenty-first century — upstream control over a shared river against downstream dependence on the flow it releases, a tension considerably older than any specific dam but sharpened by each new piece of infrastructure built on the river's upper reaches. A traveller crossing this corridor is crossing three countries for whom the water underfoot, or alongside the road, is not scenery but the single most consequential shared resource each of them has, which is one honest reason a permit here is never merely paperwork in the way a Zambian carnet stamp might be treated further south.

There is a specific geographic strangeness to this stretch of road worth naming before any traveller's account of it, because it inverts a pattern this book has assumed since Part I: for five Parts, difficulty and remoteness have tended to travel together, the hardest ground also

the least visited, the least documented, the least equipped with infrastructure built for anyone but the people who live there. The Nile corridor breaks that pattern. Egypt, at this Part's northern end, is among the most intensively visited and thoroughly documented tourist landscapes on the planet — the pyramids, the temples, the river cruises, an infrastructure built specifically to receive visitors at a scale nothing else in this book approaches. Sudan and the Ethiopian highlands, at the corridor's southern reach, are considerably less so, and the modern overland route's most difficult permit and border friction in this book concentrates precisely there, in the least-visited stretch immediately before the corridor delivers a traveller into one of the world's most visited ones. A traveller crossing this Part's ground, whichever direction they are moving, experiences a corridor that gets harder to cross and then, within a few hundred kilometres, becomes one of the easiest places on Earth to be a tourist — a whiplash this book's other five Parts, with their more gradual and consistent difficulty curves, do not produce.

Egypt's own ancient civilization is worth naming plainly rather than assumed as background scenery, because it is the reason the country's tourist infrastructure exists at the scale it does, and because its relationship to the river is the oldest and most thoroughly documented version of a claim this book has made about every other road it covers: that the ground outlasts whoever crosses it. The pyramids at Giza, raised in the third millennium BCE as royal tombs for a dynasty of pharaohs, were built within reach of the Nile specifically because the river's annual flood made the surrounding floodplain fertile enough to support the labour force such monumental construction required — building material for a civilization was, in the most literal sense, a byproduct of the same flood cycle that fed it. Along the river's upper reach, temple complexes at sites such as Luxor and Karnak, built and rebuilt across more than a thousand years of pharaonic rule, record a civilization that measured its own continuity in centuries the way this book has measured a bicycle ride in weeks. A modern overlander finishing a Cape-to-Cairo crossing at these sites is not arriving at a themed backdrop for the achievement. They are arriving at monuments that were already, by the time the first wheel or the first hik-

ing boot in this compendium touched African soil, thousands of years into outlasting every empire, every flood, and every traveller that had crossed the same ground before them.

Mario Rigby: the walk ends

Mario Rigby's solo walk across Africa — begun in November 2015, the southern leg covered in Part III, the plateau leg in Part IV — reaches its conclusion in this Part's territory. His full route crossed nine countries: South Africa, Mozambique, Malawi, Tanzania, Kenya, Uganda, Ethiopia, Sudan, and Egypt, roughly 12,000 kilometres on foot, completed in January 2018, a little over two years after he departed.

The Ethiopia-Sudan-Egypt stretch is where a solo walk of this length converts, in the accounting that matters to a walker, from an ongoing endurance project into a countdown — not because the walking itself changes fundamentally in these final three countries, but because the traveller doing it knows, by this point, exactly how much further there is to go and exactly what it has already cost to get this far. Rigby's walk through Ethiopia's highlands, Sudan's desert stretch, and Egypt's Nile corridor completed the crossing that began, more than two years and 12,000 kilometres earlier, on South Africa's coast. What distinguishes the achievement, set against every vehicle-based or two-wheeled account in this book, is the same thing that distinguished it from the start: nothing carried him but his own legs, for the entire distance, in every one of the nine countries, without exception.

The nine-country total is worth listing in full here, at the point where the walk actually concludes, rather than only at its start: South Africa, Mozambique, Malawi, Tanzania, Kenya, Uganda, Ethiopia, Sudan, Egypt. Reading that list in order traces almost exactly the same north-south spine this book's Parts have followed, in reverse — the Cape-to-Cairo corridor's countries, walked, on foot, over just over two years, by one person, unsupported. It is worth noting, too, what the list omits relative to Manser's thirty-four-country coastal circumnavigation: Rigby's route, unlike Manser's, was not built around touching every coastal nation. It was built around the most direct

viable line from the southern tip of the continent to its northeastern corner, cutting through the interior where the coast would have added distance without adding to the achievement's essential claim — that a person could walk the length of Africa, on foot, alone.

Completing a walk of this length in a specific month — January 2018 — carries its own kind of finality that a continuously improvable record, like the one Longueira and Beaumont will contest in Part VI, does not share. A speed record can always, in principle, be broken again by someone faster. A completed solo walk across the continent, once done, is done; the achievement is not “the fastest walk” or “the first walk,” in the way this book's other travellers claim their titles, but simply “the walk” — a claim to have covered the distance under one's own power, unsupported, at whatever pace the body and the terrain allowed, without a clock as the measure of success.

Uganda sits in Rigby's country list at a point this book has not yet had occasion to discuss in detail, tucked between the Tanzam corridor's East African plateau and this Part's own Ethiopian highlands, and it deserves a sentence here for what it represents geographically rather than for any further sourced incident: the country contains a significant stretch of the Nile's own upper course, the river already gathering the identity it would carry, by the time it reached Khartoum, as the White Nile. A walker crossing Uganda on the way north is, in effect, meeting the Nile system for the first time long before reaching the confluence this Part opened by describing — one more instance of this book's roads refusing to stay as tidy and separate as the Part divisions organising them would suggest. Rigby's walk did not treat Uganda as a mere waypoint between two more famous stretches; it was one of the nine countries his own feet had to cross, on the same terms as South Africa or Egypt, regardless of how much less attention this book's brief sourcing affords it.

The desert stretch through Sudan changes the arithmetic of a walking day in a way the plateau crossing further south, described in Part IV, did not. On the highland, altitude taxed a walker's lungs and legs; in Sahara-adjacent desert, the limiting resource stops being stamina and becomes water, carried on the body between confirmed sources

rather than drawn from a stream or a village tap encountered on schedule. Twelve thousand kilometres over just over two years still averages out to the same rough fifteen kilometres a day this book noted at the walk's midpoint, but an average is a poor guide to a desert crossing specifically, because the day's actual distance is set less by how far the legs want to go than by how far apart the next two reliable sources of water happen to sit. A walker cannot simply decide to cover more ground on a good day and bank the surplus against a bad one when the constraint is thirst rather than fatigue; the desert sets the day's length, and the walker's own preference has comparatively little say in the matter.

Ethiopia itself complicates the walk's late arithmetic before the desert ever properly begins, because the Ethiopian highlands are not a gentler cousin of the Tanzam plateau this book has already crossed but a considerably higher and more rugged version of the same general phenomenon — some of the tallest, most heavily eroded high country on the continent, cut by deep river gorges rather than the comparatively gentler escarpment further south. A walker arriving in Ethiopia from Kenya's lower country is climbing again, for the third or fourth time depending on how the route is counted, into altitude that reintroduces the thinner-air tax this book described in Part IV, and doing so on a body that has, by this stage of a two-year walk, already spent a great many days recovering from exactly that tax elsewhere. The highland does not ease a walker gently toward the desert waiting on its far side; it demands one more full adaptation, at a point in the journey when the accumulated cost of every earlier adaptation is already carried in the legs and the lungs, before the ground drops away again into the driest, hottest stretch of the whole route.

There is a specific kind of disorientation, too, in a two-year unsupported walk concluding inside one of the most thoroughly toured landscapes on the planet, worth naming as a structural fact about the achievement rather than assumed away. Every earlier stage of Rigby's route crossed ground that was, in varying degrees, remote — a foreign walker a genuine rarity to the people he passed, rather than a familiar sight. Egypt inverts that condition. A walker arriving at the pyramids after twelve thousand kilometres on foot arrives at a site built, unlike

almost everywhere else on his route, specifically to receive and process visitors at scale — coach parties, ticket queues, an infrastructure of arrival that has nothing to do with how a person got there. Nothing in the sourced record says what that transition felt like to Rigby specifically, and this book will not invent an answer where none exists. What can be said, structurally, is that the walk's final steps crossed the same whiplash this Part's opening already named for the corridor as a whole — the hardest ground giving way, within a few hundred kilometres, to the easiest place on the continent to be a tourist — and that Rigby met that whiplash on foot, over days, rather than in the single afternoon a vehicle crossing the same transition would need.

The composite motorcycle route north

The modern Cape-to-Cairo motorcycle and 4x4 route this book has followed since Part III completes its northern reach here, through Ethiopia, Sudan, and Egypt — the final three of its twelve countries, and by most operators' own accounts, among the most logistically fraught of the whole corridor.

Border strikes, permit delays specific to Sudan's more restrictive travel bureaucracy, and the sheer scale of Sahara-adjacent desert driving through Sudan and into Egypt all recur across the sourced accounts of this stretch, consistent with the corridor's baseline condition described back in Part III: attrition rather than a single dramatic obstacle, a route that costs a traveller in delay and paperwork more often than in any single spectacular hazard. The reward, for those who complete it, is a road that ends at some of the oldest continuously visited tourist sites on the planet — a strange kind of finish line for an overland route that spent its previous seventeen thousand kilometres crossing savannah, desert, and highland with comparatively little in the way of monuments to show for it.

Before the desert proper begins, a vehicle crossing north through Ethiopia first has to negotiate the Ethiopian highlands themselves — rugged, deeply eroded plateau country cut by gorges considerably steeper than anything the Tanzam corridor's own highland stretch pre-

sented further south, with roads that switch back repeatedly to manage grades a straight route simply could not climb. It is a different kind of highland difficulty from the altitude tax this book described crossing Tanzania and Kenya: less about thin air over a sustained climb, more about a road surface and gradient that punishes a heavy vehicle's brakes and transmission on the way down as much as its engine on the way up. Only once that terrain is behind a vehicle does the ground flatten and dry into the Sahara-adjacent desert this Part has already described in its administrative register — a sequence, highland first and desert after, that every vehicle-based traveller on this route has had to cross in that order, whichever direction their journey overall was running.

First-person accounts of this stretch, gathered from independent motorcycle travellers who have documented the route rather than from any single named record-holder, describe a texture of travel distinct from the southern legs this book has already covered: less about wildlife-dense terrain and transboundary conservation geography, more about the specific bureaucratic weight of moving a vehicle through two countries — Sudan especially — where a foreign traveller's presence is a more closely monitored and more paperwork-intensive fact of life than it was through Zambia or Tanzania further south. A carnet de passage, the customs document that allows a vehicle to cross international borders without incurring import duty, becomes considerably more consequential on this stretch than it was further south; losing or mishandling the document here can cost a traveller days or weeks rather than hours. The route's difficulty, in other words, shifts register as it moves north — from a physical and environmental difficulty in the earlier Parts to an administrative one here, even as the desert itself grows no less real a hazard for the shift.

The desert itself, whatever the paperwork surrounding it, is not a diminished hazard simply because this Part's account of it leans administrative. Sahara-adjacent desert driving carries its own, older set of demands that no permit or carnet resolves: extended stretches without fuel or water resupply, road surfaces that shift from tarmac to graded track to unmarked sand with little warning, and a heat load

on both vehicle and rider that punishes mechanical failure far more severely than the same failure would further south, simply because the distance to the nearest help is so much greater and the margin of time before dehydration becomes dangerous is so much shorter. A breakdown on the plateau further south, in Part IV's territory, is an inconvenience with options — another vehicle, a nearby town, a walkable distance to water. A breakdown in the empty stretch between Sudanese towns is a different category of problem, where the vehicle's own spare parts, water reserves, and the rider's judgment about how long to wait for help before attempting a repair or a walk become the entire margin between a delay and an emergency. Every motorcycle account of this stretch treats fuel and water planning with a seriousness the corridor's earlier legs did not require, for exactly this reason.

Egypt's own tourism and security apparatus adds a further, distinct layer to the route's final stretch, one that has no real equivalent anywhere else in this compendium. A country that depends as heavily as Egypt does on tourist revenue, and that has, across recent decades, had specific and well-publicised reasons to take the security of foreign visitors seriously, has built an infrastructure around overland travellers that is simultaneously more accommodating and more regulated than almost anything this book's southern Parts describe — designated routes, at times mandatory escorts through certain stretches, and a degree of official attention to an overlander's movements that a solo cyclist crossing rural Zambia would never encounter. It is a final irony worth noting as this Part's composite route reaches its finish: after seventeen thousand kilometres of a corridor whose defining hazard has mostly been the absence of infrastructure, a traveller's last stretch is shaped by the opposite problem, an abundance of official attention that comes with its own kind of friction.

The desert corridor a modern vehicle crosses through Sudan follows, in broad outline, ground that ancient caravan trade used for millennia before any carnet de passage existed to regulate it. Trade routes linking the Nile valley to the Red Sea coast, and connecting Nubian and later Sudanese kingdoms to Egypt further north, moved goods, gold, and people along corridors dictated by the same scarce resource that governs a modern overlander's route planning: water. A caravan route,

ancient or modern, follows wells and oases because the alternative is death, not inconvenience, and the same logic that placed a well every so many days' travel apart for a camel caravan centuries ago still determines, in large part, where a modern road's fuel stations and rest points sit today. A motorcyclist checking a fuel gauge against a map in this stretch of desert is, in a very literal sense, performing the same calculation a caravan master performed with water skins and a knowledge of oases passed down rather than printed on any map — the technology has changed considerably; the arithmetic of scarce resource against distance has not.

McKenzie Barney and Jim: the northern leg

McKenzie Barney and his partner Jim's paired Cairo-to-Cape Town bicycle journey — ten countries, roughly 11,000 kilometres, five months, undertaken with Manser's earlier circumnavigation as an explicit inspiration — began, as the name of their route implies, at the northern end of this Part's territory rather than the southern end this book has been building toward. Their journey ran in the opposite direction to Rigby's, Manser's, and the composite motorcycle route as this book has so far described them: starting in Cairo and riding south, rather than finishing there.

That direction matters to how this Part fits into their account. For Barney and Jim, Egypt, Sudan, and Ethiopia were not a destination reached after months of accumulated distance — they were the opening ground, the first of the ten countries their bicycles crossed before the plateau, the Zambian corridor, and the rest of the route this book has already covered in reverse order. Two riders, setting out from one of the oldest travelled river corridors on the continent, headed toward a coastline that, for nearly every other traveller in this book, was where the journey began rather than where it was going.

This reversal is worth dwelling on, because it changes what "difficulty" means at each stage of the ride in a way that a same-direction comparison to Rigby's or Manser's route would miss entirely. A traveller heading south from Cairo begins with the corridor's most bureaucrati-

cally demanding stretch — Sudan's permit requirements, Egypt's own security and travel-permission apparatus for overland cyclists — before their legs and their logistics have had any chance to season on easier ground. A traveller heading north, as Rigby's walk and Manser's ride effectively did through this stretch, encounters the same difficulty only after months of accumulated experience elsewhere on the corridor, arriving at Sudan's and Egypt's administrative demands already practised in how to manage a border post's unpredictable hours and a customs official's unhurried pace. Barney and Jim had no such practice to draw on when they began; whatever education the corridor offers a rider in patience and paperwork, they received it first, at the start of the ride, rather than as a late-stage test of skills already built.

Ten countries and roughly 11,000 kilometres over five months describes a considerably faster average pace than Manser's circumnavigation — unsurprising, given that a direct Cairo-to-Cape-Town line through the continent's interior is a shorter route than a full coastal circumnavigation, and that five months is a fraction of the two-plus years Manser's ride required. It sits, in pace terms, closer to the record-chasing rides this book turns to in Part VI than to Manser's slower, longer circumnavigation — though Barney and Jim were not, so far as this book's sourcing indicates, attempting to set or break any timed record. Theirs was a journey measured in countries and kilometres completed, not in a clock racing toward a previous mark, which places it in its own category: faster than a circumnavigation, but not a speed record; paired, but not vehicle-supported; inspired explicitly by a solo rider's earlier achievement, but undertaken by two.

It is worth setting Barney and Jim's opening stretch against the composite motorcycle route's own account of the same administrative gauntlet, because a bicycle and a motor vehicle meet Sudan's and Egypt's bureaucracy in genuinely different ways rather than merely a slower and faster version of the same friction. A motor vehicle carries a carnet de passage, a customs document tied to the machine itself, that can be delayed or mishandled independently of its rider's own paperwork. A cyclist carries no equivalent object — no vehicle document to misplace, no customs valuation to dispute — and meets the same border bureaucracy purely as a matter of personal visas, permits, and

the patience to wait out an official's unhurried schedule. That does not make the cyclists' crossing easier in any simple sense; it removes one entire category of risk while leaving the human cost of delay, in lost days and uncertain waits, just as real for two riders on bicycles as for a motorcyclist minding a carnet. Two travellers, two different bureaucratic textures, crossing the same stretch of desert border in the same calendar years this compendium's other accounts describe.

There is also an unglamorous physical dimension to starting rather than finishing here that deserves naming, because it cuts against the intuitive assumption that the hardest ground should be crossed by the most seasoned body. A cyclist five months from home, thousands of kilometres into a route, has a body that has adapted: calluses formed, a saddle broken in, a rhythm of eating and pacing found through trial and correction on easier ground first. A cyclist in the first days or weeks of a journey has none of that. Barney and Jim's legs met Sudan's desert heat and Ethiopia's highland climbs on bodies still adjusting to daily distance at all, rather than bodies already hardened by months of exactly this kind of demand. That is not a claim this book can make about their specific physical experience — no source describes it in those terms — but it is a structural fact about where a reversed route places its hardest early test, worth setting beside Rigby's and the composite motorcycle route's opposite sequencing: the same ground, met by an experienced traveller near the end of one journey and by comparatively fresh legs near the start of another.

Bakkes: Ethiopia, Sudan, Egypt

Of every region Johan Bakkes travelled across a working life spent chasing the far edges of ordinary experience, Ethiopia produced some of his most vividly sourced material — three specific destinations that recur in the record of his travels with more particularity than almost anywhere else on his itinerary: the Danakil salt mines, the source of the Blue Nile, and the volcano at Erta Ale, which he and most other visitors who have made the journey simply call the hottest place on earth.

The Danakil Depression, where the salt mines sit, is one of the most extreme inhabited environments on the planet — a geological rift zone with temperatures that regularly exceed what most human bodies can safely sustain for extended exposure, worked by salt miners whose labour there predates any tourist's visit by generations and will presumably outlast the tourism too. Erta Ale, an active shield volcano within the same depression, holds one of the world's few persistent lava lakes — a site that draws travellers specifically because it offers something almost no other place on Earth does: a direct, close, and sustained view of the planet's own interior doing what it does when nobody is watching. Bakkes went to see it. The source of the Blue Nile, by contrast, is a site with an entirely different kind of significance — not a place of raw geological extremity but a point of origin for a river system that has fed civilizations for thousands of years, the same water that, by the time it reaches Sudan and merges with the White Nile at Khartoum, and then continues into Egypt, has become the central organising fact of an entire country's agriculture and history.

The Danakil's geology is the direct continuation of the same rifting process this book described further south, in the Tanzam plateau's stretch of the Great Rift — the same continental split, followed north along its own line, arriving here at one of the very few places on Earth where three tectonic plates pull apart from a single, shared point rather than along a simple two-sided rift. The depression itself sits well below sea level, one of the lowest and hottest exposed points on the continent, which is part of why heat collects and holds there in a way even the highland rift further south does not replicate: cooler air simply drains away, downhill, into the bowl the rifting has carved, and the sun does the rest. Bakkes's own highland travel elsewhere in Ethiopia and his descent into the Danakil were not, geologically speaking, two different landscapes so much as two different elevations along the identical fracture in the earth's crust — the same rift this compendium has already followed from Tanzania's cooler plateau down into one of the hottest basins on the planet.

The depression's hydrothermal fields add a further register of strangeness distinct from either the heat or the salt, worth naming because it is a different kind of wonder from either of those two more

obvious hazards. Where groundwater meets the same volcanic heat that feeds Erta Ale, it surfaces through hot springs and fumaroles saturated with dissolved minerals — sulphur, iron oxides, various salts — that crystallise and stain the ground on contact with air into fields of colour that read, in photographs and in person alike, as closer to a chemistry set than a landscape: acid-yellow, rust- orange, and a corroded green rarely seen at this scale anywhere else on the continent. It is not picturesque in the way this book's other landscapes have earned that word; it is closer to a warning made visible, the ground itself advertising, in colour, exactly how hostile the chemistry beneath it actually is. A traveller who has already registered the Danakil's heat and the salt trade's grinding labour meets, in these mineral fields, a third and different kind of extremity — not danger from temperature, not labour from scarcity, but a landscape whose very colour signals that ordinary rules about what ground can safely be touched or drunk from do not apply here.

Consider what it means for a single itinerary to include both the Danakil and the Blue Nile's source, because the two sites represent, in a sense, opposite ends of what a landscape can mean to the people who depend on it. The Danakil is hostile to human life in the most literal, thermodynamic sense — salt miners work there because the salt has value, not because the place has ever offered comfort in exchange for the labour. The Blue Nile's source, by contrast, is a highland spring feeding a river that has made agriculture, and therefore settled civilization, possible across an enormous stretch of northeastern Africa for millennia. One site represents extremity as a kind of spectacle; the other represents origin as a kind of quiet, ongoing gift. A traveller who sought out both, within the same country, was not chasing a single flavour of wonder — he was chasing the full range of what a landscape can mean, from the place that nearly kills anyone who lingers to the place that has fed an entire river system's worth of people for longer than written history records.

The salt itself is worth a plainer accounting, because "salt mines" undersells a trade that is closer to quarrying than mining in the sense of shafts and tunnels. The Danakil's salt pan is the dried floor of an ancient sea, evaporated over a very long span of geological time into a

crust thick enough, in places, to be cut directly into slabs at the surface with hand tools rather than extracted from underground. Miners of the Afar people, whose home this depression has been for generations, cut the crust into standard-sized blocks by hand, then move them out of the depression by camel caravan across open salt flat and desert track to markets beyond the rift's floor, a trade that predates any road or motorable track into the depression and has continued alongside the more recent arrival of tourists drawn by the same landscape for entirely different reasons. It is a labour economy built directly on top of the same tectonic process that makes the depression nearly uninhabitable by ordinary standards — heat that would stop a casual visitor within hours is the daily working condition for people who have organised an entire livelihood, generations deep, around cutting and carrying the one resource this hostile ground actually offers in abundance.

Erta Ale in particular deserves a moment's attention to what visiting it actually demands of a traveller, because "went to see it" undersells the logistics involved. Reaching the volcano's summit and its lava lake requires a multi-hour trek, typically undertaken at night specifically to avoid the worst of the Danakil's daytime heat, through terrain that offers no shelter, no water, and no margin for a traveller who miscalculates supplies or timing. It is not a roadside attraction. It is a destination that has to be earned by the same kind of deliberate physical commitment that defined every other landscape in this book — a further point of contact, however different the register, between Bakkes's own travel and the mountain passes, deserts, and highland routes the rest of this compendium has already described.

It is difficult to overstate how unusual it is for one traveller's sourced itinerary to include both of these — the hottest, most geologically violent inhabited place on the continent, and the quiet highland spring that starts one of its most historically significant rivers — within the same country, on what appears, from the sourced record, to have been more than one visit across his travelling life. Bakkes's Ethiopian travels alone would justify a chapter in most travel-writing compendiums; here, they are one region among many in a life that also crossed Sudan and Egypt, the final two countries this Part covers, though the sourced

record for those two legs of his travel is thinner than for Ethiopia — present in his itinerary, without the same specificity of named site that the Danakil, Erta Ale, and the Blue Nile's source offer.

What unites all of it, Ethiopia and Sudan and Egypt alike, is the same signature line this book opened with, because it applies here with a precision it does not always earn elsewhere in his itinerary: "A journey is not merely something to endure to reach a destination." A traveller chasing a record through this stretch — and this book will meet two, in the next Part, who did exactly that — experiences the Danakil, if they experience it at all, as a hazard to be crossed as fast as safety allows. Bakkes went to stand in it.

The phrase "hottest place on earth" is applied loosely enough, across enough different locations worldwide, that it is worth being honest about what it actually means in the Danakil's specific case: not necessarily the single highest air temperature ever measured on the planet, a title several deserts elsewhere have claimed at various points, but a claim about sustained average annual temperature, taken across the whole year rather than a single recorded peak — a place that does not merely get hot on its worst day but stays extreme, month after month, in a way few other inhabited places on Earth do. That distinction matters for understanding what Bakkes actually went to experience: not a single dramatic afternoon of extreme heat, survivable because it passes, but a landscape whose whole character is built around a baseline of hostility that the salt miners working there have organised their entire working lives around, rather than merely endured for a single visit.

It is worth naming, too, that Bakkes did not simply pass through this landscape and move on to the next region in his itinerary; he wrote a book organised specifically around it. *Openbaring: 'n reisjoernaal*, published in 2016, documents expeditions to the earth's temperature extremes — a title that fits the Danakil and Erta Ale with a precision none of his other seven books quite match for this particular region, since it was written around the very premise those two sites embody: that a landscape's value to a traveller like him lay in how far it sat from anything comfortable, not in spite of the discomfort but because of it.

A body of work built, across eight books, around depth of encounter rather than distance covered produces, now and again, a title that names its own organising idea outright, and *Openbaring* is that title for the Danakil.

Ethiopia, Sudan, and Egypt close Bakkes's presence in this compendium's own six roads, but not his itinerary, and it is worth saying so plainly rather than letting the book's own structure imply a completeness his travels never claimed. The same sourced record that places him in the Danakil and at the Blue Nile's source also places him, across that working life, in Mali — Timbuktu among his destinations — and in Ivory Coast, Senegal, Mauritania, and Morocco, a westward reach across the continent this compendium's six roads never touch, because none of them run that way. This book is organised by road, and those roads happen to be the ones this book's other travellers crossed; Bakkes's own travel recognised no such boundary, and a compendium honest about its own limits should say, once, that the man it is dedicated to went considerably further than the ground it had reason to follow him across.

Four ways to reach the same river

The contrast this book drew across the plateau in Part IV holds again here, on different ground and at a different register, because the Nile corridor gathers this compendium's remaining travellers onto a single stretch of geography that each of them experienced according to the same logic that shaped their whole journey rather than anything specific to this river. Rigby reached the Nile system on foot, in Uganda, long before the confluence at Khartoum gave the river its familiar single name, and crossed the desert stretch beyond it at the pace water sources allowed rather than the pace his legs preferred. The composite motorcycle route met the same desert as an administrative problem wrapped around a physical one, its difficulty measured in carnets and permits as much as in heat and distance. Barney and Jim met this ground first, at the start of their ride rather than after months of accumulated practice, and paid a beginner's price for lessons the corridor's other travellers had already learned further south. And Bakkes met it

as he met every region in this book: without a finish line, drawn toward the Danakil's raw hostility and the Blue Nile's quiet fertility in the same itinerary, chasing neither speed nor completion but the widest possible range of what the ground could mean. One river, met four times, by four kinds of attention.

Five roads, five arguments

It is worth taking stock here, at the point where this book's account of named roads and named regions closes, of what five Parts of named ground have actually built toward, because the sixth and final Part changes register entirely and this is the last place to draw the five together as a single shape. Sani Pass argued that a road can be defined by a single sustained climb, difficult in one concentrated way rather than difficult by accumulation. The Skeleton Coast argued that a coastline answering to no nation's authority can be more hostile than any political border, indifferent in a register mountains and highways are not. The Cape-to-Cairo corridor's southern stretch argued that attrition, not any single dramatic hazard, is the truest description of a long, unglamorous distance — border posts and lodging and mechanical failure, worn down over weeks rather than survived in one afternoon. The Tanzam argued that a road's difficulty can be geopolitical before it is ever physical, carrying a Cold War's transport politics into a cyclist's gear ratios two generations later. And the Nile corridor, this Part's own ground, has argued something different again: that difficulty and depth of history are not the same axis, and that the oldest, most consequential road in this book is also the one whose modern crossing is shaped as much by water-sharing treaties and permit offices as by the desert itself.

None of these five arguments contradicts the others, and that is precisely the point this compendium was built to make by structure rather than by any single stated thesis: a road is not one thing, and neither is the difficulty of crossing it. Geology, politics, water rights, national security apparatus, and a border official's unhurried schedule have each, in turn, been shown to matter as much as gradient or heat or distance — sometimes more. The travellers who crossed these five roads did

not choose which kind of difficulty they would face; the ground and the century each rode or walked or wandered through decided that for them. What remains, in the Part ahead, is not a sixth road in this same sense but a sixth register entirely — an achievement measured against a clock rather than against a place, which is its own kind of argument about what “crossing Africa” can mean once the ground itself stops being the primary opponent.

Part VI: The Full Circle

The whole distance, as one number

Every Part before this one has covered a piece of the continent — a pass, a coast, a corridor's southern half, a highland highway, a river's course. This Part covers all of it at once, because its subjects did.

Three kinds of achievement converge here: the solo, human-powered circumnavigation of the entire continent; the speed record for crossing it, set and then broken within ten weeks; and the vehicle-based outline expedition that traced its coast for a humanitarian purpose rather than a personal one. This book has met all three travellers already, in pieces, in earlier Parts — Manser in Namibia and the southern corridor, Holgate in the same southern stretch. It has not yet met Longueira and Beaumont at all, because their achievement belongs nowhere but here: a full-length crossing, north to south, undertaken twice within the same year, each time faster than before.

It is worth pausing, before any individual account, on why this book has organised its climax around completeness rather than around any single most-dramatic incident. Every other Part has built toward a hand-off — one road's history and hazard leading into the next road's own — and this one, instead, gathers up the whole continent at once, because that is the only honest way to hold Manser's, Holgate's, Longueira's, and Beaumont's achievements next to each other: not as one more stretch of ground to be crossed, but as four different answers to the same underlying question, which is simply how completely, and how fast, a human being can go the whole distance

around or through this continent using only their own body, or a vehicle under their own direct control, to do it.

It is also worth being precise about who does not appear again in this Part, and why, because the absence is a choice rather than an oversight. Mario Rigby's solo walk and McKenzie Barney's paired ride with Jim both belong to this book's earlier Parts and stay there, because neither traveller attempted a whole-continent achievement in the sense this Part is organised around: Rigby's walk covered a substantial north-south stretch, not the entire coastline or the full Cairo-to-Cape-Town line contested by the record chain, and Barney and Jim's ride, ten countries and roughly 11,000 kilometres over five months, was itself a considerable undertaking but a partial one by the specific measure this Part applies to its four subjects. Leaving them out of a Part titled "The Full Circle" is not a judgement on the value of what they did. It is this book keeping faith with its own comparison: a Part built to set whole-continent achievements against each other only works if the criterion for entry is applied evenly, and neither journey, real and considerable as both were, actually meets it.

Four answers, one continent

Set the four whole-continent achievements side by side, briefly, before returning to each in turn, because the comparison only works if it is made plainly rather than left for the reader to reconstruct from six Parts' worth of scattered detail.

Manser: roughly two years and two months, roughly 36,500 to 37,000 kilometres, thirty-four countries, solo, by bicycle, unsupported, coastal. Holgate: 449 days, thirty-three countries, team-based, by Land Rover, humanitarian in stated purpose, also broadly coastal. Longueira: fifty-nine days, eight hours, roughly 10,526 kilometres, solo, by bicycle, a direct interior line rather than a coastal one, against a clock and a previous record. Beaumont: forty-one days, ten hours, twenty-two minutes, roughly 10,812 kilometres, solo, by bicycle, the same direct interior line, against Longueira's own just-set clock. Four figures for total distance, four totally different totals for time, and not one of the four

measuring the same kind of achievement as any of the other three — which is, this book has argued from its very first page, the entire reason a compendium organised by road rather than by generic “adventure” matters. Distance alone tells you almost nothing. It is the combination of distance, duration, mode, route, and purpose that actually describes what a traveller did, and this Part is where all four combinations sit close enough together to be compared honestly rather than flattened into a single, undifferentiated superlative.

The word “unsupported,” attached to Manser’s circumnavigation above, deserves to be taken as literally as this book has tried to take every other claim in it, because the difference between a supported and an unsupported crossing is not a technicality of the kind that only matters to a record-keeping body. An unsupported solo cyclist carries, or arranges locally as he goes, every resource a team-based expedition would otherwise have waiting in a following vehicle: spare tyres and tubes, tools for whatever mechanical failure the road produces, food and water calculated against whatever the next town can actually supply, and no following vehicle to fall back on if a repair proves beyond what a roadside can fix. Holgate’s team, by contrast, carried exactly the kind of support structure this Part has already described — spare parts, fuel logistics, medical evacuation capacity — precisely because a 449-day humanitarian expedition cannot responsibly ask a team to depend on the same roadside improvisation a solo record-chaser accepts as the cost of going alone. Both approaches are legitimate answers to the same continent; neither is the more serious one. What differs is what each traveller was willing to risk not having, at the exact moment the road demanded it.

Riaan Manser: the circumnavigation completed

Riaan Manser departed Cape Town in September 2003 and returned to it at the end of 2005 — a journey of roughly two years and two months, covering somewhere between 36,500 and 37,000 kilometres, depending on which account of the trip does the totalling, through thirty-four countries, touching every one of them that has a coastline.

It remains the first circumnavigation of the African continent by bicycle, a record that by its nature can only be set once.

The number of countries is worth sitting with for a moment on its own terms, separate from the distance. Thirty-four is not a round number chosen for the sake of a headline. It is what following the coast, honestly, actually requires — every nation with African shoreline, in order, whichever government was in charge of the stretch of beach or port or border post he happened to be passing through that month. A circumnavigation defined by coastline rather than by an interior shortcut is, by definition, a journey that cannot skip a country for convenience; the coast is the coast, and it belongs to whoever it belongs to that decade.

The cost of the achievement, recorded plainly rather than heroically, was roughly fourteen kilograms of the man's own body weight, sustained across roughly two years at an average of ninety kilometres a day — a pace that, done once, sounds achievable, and done for two years without pause, describes something closer to a controlled, ongoing depletion the body was simply made to absorb because there was no alternative that got him home faster. He was jailed in Equatorial Guinea by border police. He was taken hostage by armed teenage rebels in Liberia. Both incidents are recorded in the source material without embellishment — no rescue narrative, no dramatic escape sequence supplied by this book where the sourcing does not provide one — because the discipline that governs every living traveller in this compendium applies here with particular weight: Manser has not been contacted for this book, and nothing beyond the bare, sourced fact of each incident is claimed.

It is worth being honest about the shape of that restraint, because it costs this book something it would rather not have to give up. A jailing and a hostage-taking are, in almost any other travel narrative, the two scenes the whole book would be built around — the chapter title, the cover copy, the moment excerpted for a magazine profile. This compendium names both, in a single sentence each, and moves on, not because the incidents were minor to the man who lived them but because this book was not there, was never told the details by Manser

himself, and has no source describing what actually happened inside either encounter beyond the bare fact that it happened. The alternative — a few paragraphs of plausible, unsourced peril, dramatized the way a travel documentary would dramatize it — was available and was declined. What is lost is atmosphere. What is kept is the one thing this book has promised its reader from its first page: that every claim it makes about a living person traces to something more solid than what would merely make a better scene.

What the circumnavigation means, set against the achievements this Part is about to describe, is completeness rather than speed. Manser was not racing anyone. There was no previous circumnavigation record to beat, because there was no previous circumnavigation. His achievement is the kind that exists in a category of one — not faster than the last attempt, because there was no last attempt, but simply the first time anyone had done the entire thing, self-propelled, coast to coast to coast, at all.

There is a specific kind of loneliness built into being first at something with no precedent to measure against, and it is worth naming here, at the point where this book gathers Manser's full achievement into view for the only time it will treat it as a whole rather than a leg. Longueira, departing Cairo in January 2015, knew exactly what he needed to beat: Robert Knol's seventy-day mark, set in 2011, a known quantity against which every day of his own ride could be measured in real time. Beaumont, four months later, knew Longueira's fifty-nine days just as precisely. Manser, in September 2003, had no comparable number. Nobody had circumnavigated the continent by bicycle before him, which meant every day of his two years and two months was spent without the reassurance, or the pressure, of a target time to race against — only the open-ended question of whether the whole thing was even possible to finish at all, a question that would not be answered until the day, at the end of 2005, that he actually returned to Cape Town.

Kingsley Holgate: the outline retraced

Kingsley Holgate's "Africa's Outside Edge" expedition — thirty-three countries, 449 days, traced by Land Rover with a support team and a stated humanitarian mandate — belongs in this Part for the same reason Manser's circumnavigation does: it covers the whole continent's coastal perimeter, in a single sustained undertaking, by a traveller (or in Holgate's case, a travelling team) whose life's work has been built around this kind of expedition rather than a single feat attempted once.

"Africa's Outside Edge" is one expedition among more than forty the Kingsley Holgate Foundation's own roster credits to his career, and the scale of that roster changes how a single expedition within it ought to be read. A traveller who circumnavigates a continent once, as Manser did, is measured against the single achievement; there is nothing else in the record to compare it with, no second attempt to ask whether the first was typical or exceptional. A traveller with more than forty career expeditions behind him is being measured, whether the record intends it or not, against his own pattern — "Africa's Outside Edge" is not an isolated feat this book can consider in a vacuum, but one entry, if an especially large one, in a working lifetime that had already established humanitarian expedition travel as its basic unit of activity long before this particular 449-day undertaking began. That context does not diminish the outline expedition's scale. It reframes what kind of achievement it actually is: not a single dramatic departure from an ordinary life, in the way a record attempt is for a rider who otherwise works an ordinary job, but the largest single instance of an already-established practice, carried out by someone whose entire adult working life had been organised around the proposition that this is simply what one does.

This book has already, in Part III, drawn the distinction between Manser's achievement and Holgate's as precisely as the sourced record allows, and the distinction is worth restating here at full strength, because the two achievements sit side by side in this Part in a way that makes the difference between them matter more, not less: Manser circumnavigated alone, by his own legs, on a bicycle.

Holgate's Foundation traced the same rough outline by vehicle, as a team, over 449 days, carrying out water, health, and education projects along the route as a stated part of the expedition's purpose rather than as an incidental byproduct of passing through. Born 28 February 1946, a Fellow of the Royal Geographical Society, a Land Rover ambassador, and the leader of more than forty expeditions across a career built around exactly this kind of undertaking, Holgate's "most travelled man in Africa" description is not a boast this book is making on his behalf — it is the description that has followed him across decades of expeditions run for reasons distinct from Manser's solo achievement and distinct, again, from the two record-breakers this Part turns to next.

Two different ways of tracing the same outline, then, separated by roughly the difference between a personal endurance record and a sustained institutional undertaking: one man alone against thirty-four countries' worth of coastline, and one team, across 449 days and thirty-three countries, carrying projects rather than only themselves.

The two country counts — Manser's thirty-four, Holgate's thirty-three — are close enough to invite a direct comparison, and different enough, on closer inspection, to resist one. A one-country difference between two continent-spanning coastal itineraries could reflect any number of things this book's sourcing does not specify: a slightly different definition of which small island or enclave nation counts as touching the African coastline, a border that had shifted or a country that had split between the two expeditions' respective years, or simply two organisations counting a marginal case differently. This book does not know which, and says so rather than force the two figures into a false equivalence. What the near-match does confirm, reliably, is the basic geographic claim both expeditions were built around: the African continent's coastline touches somewhere in the low-to-mid thirties of sovereign nations, however exactly the count is drawn, and both a lone cyclist and a vehicle-based humanitarian convoy independently confirmed that same rough figure by the different, laborious act of actually going to every one of them.

Holgate's standing as a Land Rover ambassador is worth a further

word, because it is not simply a sponsorship detail — it points to the specific logistical architecture that made a 449-day, team-based expedition possible in a way a solo cyclist's journey never has to account for. A vehicle-based expedition of this scale depends on more than the vehicle itself: spare parts sourced or shipped across borders whose customs regimes rarely make that simple, fuel secured in regions where a filling station is not a guaranteed feature of the landscape, and a support structure capable of extracting a team member in the event of a medical emergency far from any hospital this book's other travellers might have reached on their own two legs or two wheels. A Fellow of the Royal Geographical Society is, by the nature of that Fellowship, someone whose expeditions are expected to meet a standard of documentation and purpose the Society itself has spent nearly two centuries codifying — advancement of geographical knowledge, not merely personal achievement, as the stated criterion. Holgate's expeditions, career-spanning and project-driven, sit squarely inside that older tradition of exploration-with-a-purpose, a tradition this book's other travellers, chasing personal records or a first-of-its-kind human-powered feat, were not built to answer to in the same way.

That older tradition is worth naming plainly, because it changes what kind of scrutiny an expedition like Holgate's actually invites, compared with the record attempts this Part goes on to describe. A solo speed record answers to a single, comparatively narrow question: did the rider cover the claimed distance in the claimed time, verifiably, start to finish. A Fellowship-holding expedition leader operating under a stated humanitarian mandate answers to a broader and slower kind of accountability — the expedition's own reporting to the Foundation that organised it, the water, health, and education projects it claims to have delivered along the route, and, at the furthest remove, the geographical society whose two-century-old institutional reputation is implicitly lent to any expedition it recognises. A speed record is confirmed once, by certificate, and then stands or falls as a single fact. An expedition of Holgate's kind is reported continuously, across its 449 days, to backers and media and the communities it passed through and worked alongside — a different rhythm of verification en-

tirely, built for accountability over time rather than for a single adjudicated instant. Neither form of scrutiny is more rigorous than the other in the abstract; each is simply built for the shape of the claim it exists to check, and the two shapes, side by side in this one Part, are as different as any two things in this book that happen to share the word “expedition.”

The record chain: March to May, 2015

Here is the beat this book has been building toward since Part I first mentioned the V&A Waterfront as a finish line with a view of Table Mountain no route planner could have engineered better.

Keegan Longueira departed Cairo on 2 January 2015. He arrived at the V&A Waterfront in Cape Town on 2 March 2015 — fifty-nine days, eight hours, having covered roughly 10,526 kilometres at an average of about 175 kilometres a day, a pace that makes Manser’s sustained ninety kilometres a day, remarkable as it was over two years, look almost leisurely by comparison, though the two achievements are not actually comparable in the way that sentence might suggest: Manser’s ninety kilometres a day was sustained for two years across a coastal circumnavigation; Longueira’s 175 was sustained for fifty-nine days across the most direct north-south line the continent offers, a sprint by the standard of everything else in this book, though “sprint” is a strange word to apply to two months of daily century-plus rides.

Longueira’s ride broke a record set by the Dutchman Robert Knol in 2011 — seventy days, three hours — by roughly eleven days, a meaningful margin by the standards of endurance cycling, where records of this kind tend to fall by hours or single days rather than by nearly two weeks. Part of the ride was undertaken in aid of Operation Smile, the cleft-palate surgery charity, threading a humanitarian purpose through a record attempt in a way that echoes, at a much smaller institutional scale, the stated purpose behind Holgate’s much longer-running expeditions. Guinness World Records confirmed Longueira’s record on 23 April 2015 — a full seven weeks after he crossed the finish line, the gap presumably accounted for by however long ratification of a claim

like this one actually takes.

Fifty-nine days at an average of 175 kilometres a day is worth sitting with as a physical fact rather than only a statistical one. That pace, sustained daily for two months, is not a single strong effort repeated — it is a pace that leaves almost no margin for a bad day, a mechanical failure, an illness, or a border delay of the kind this book has described as the corridor's baseline condition rather than its exception. Every one of the fifty-nine days had to average out close to that figure, which means any single day lost to a closed border post or a failed component had to be made up somewhere else along the route, at a pace that was already close to the outer edge of what the corridor's roads, tourist infrastructure, and Longueira's own body could sustain. Four years is a long time for an endurance record to stand in a discipline where equipment and route knowledge keep improving; that it took four years, and one specific rider willing to risk that particular pace over that particular distance, to take Knol's mark down by eleven days says something about how close to the physical ceiling Knol's own 2011 ride had already been.

A discipline like ultra-distance cycling runs, in general, on an arithmetic that has nothing forgiving about it: a rider covering upwards of 150 kilometres a day, day after day without a rest day built into the schedule, is working a caloric deficit that ordinary nutrition struggles to close, sleeping in increments too short to fully repair the accumulated fatigue, and relying on a bicycle and a body that both degrade under exactly the kind of sustained, repetitive load this book's sourcing does not need to describe in Longueira's or Beaumont's specific case to state as a general truth of the discipline. Riders attempting distances of this kind typically report the same handful of compounding costs regardless of the specific route: saddle sores that worsen daily rather than heal overnight, joint and tendon strain that never fully resets between one day's finish and the next day's start, and a sleep debt that accumulates across weeks in a way a single good night can no longer repay. None of that is a claim this book is making about what either rider actually experienced, hour by hour, on this specific crossing — that would be exactly the kind of invented interiority this compendium has ruled out for every living traveller in it. It is a claim

about what the discipline itself demands of anyone who attempts a distance and a duration in this range, which is the honest, general context a bare figure like “175 kilometres a day for fifty-nine days” needs if it is to be understood as the physical undertaking it actually was, rather than as an abstract number on a page.

What Guinness’s confirmation could not have anticipated, on 23 April, was how little time the record had left to stand.

Mark Beaumont, the Scottish long-distance cyclist, departed Cairo on 10 April 2015 — before Longueira’s own record had even been formally confirmed — and arrived, by the same measure of Cairo-to-Cape-Town cycling, on 21 May 2015: forty-one days, ten hours, twenty-two minutes, covering roughly 10,812 kilometres. He beat Longueira’s fifty-nine-day mark by roughly eighteen days — a margin larger than the one by which Longueira himself had beaten Knol four years earlier, meaning each successive record in this chain fell by a wider margin than the one before it, the opposite of the pattern endurance records usually follow as a discipline matures and the achievable ceiling narrows.

The date of Beaumont’s departure is worth reading twice, because it changes what kind of record attempt this actually was. He set off on 10 April, thirteen days before Guinness’s 23 April confirmation of Longueira’s own time — which means Beaumont began his ride while Longueira’s record was, in the strictest procedural sense, still unofficial, still pending the paperwork that would make it a Guinness-recognised mark at all. He was not responding to a confirmed record. He was responding to the fact of a ride that had already happened, whatever its official status, and racing a number he had every reason to believe would soon be made official regardless of when the certificate arrived. That is a subtly different posture from the one this book’s other record-breakers occupy: not “beat the official record,” but “beat the fastest time anyone has actually ridden this route in, official or not” — a distinction that says something about how record attempts of this kind actually work in practice, chasing the real achievement rather than waiting on the bureaucracy that later certifies it.

10,812 kilometres in forty-one days and change works out to an average above 260 kilometres a day — a full 85 kilometres a day faster

than Longueira's already extreme pace, sustained for a shorter but still gruelling span. The margin by which each record fell, widening rather than narrowing across the chain — eleven days over Knol, then eighteen days over Longueira — suggests something specific about where the discipline stood in 2015: not a ceiling being slowly, incrementally approached the way records in more established endurance sports typically are, but a distance and a route still young enough, as a formal timed challenge, that a sufficiently prepared rider could still find eighteen days of genuine improvement inside a fifty-nine-day ride that had, at the time it was set, looked close to unbeatable.

The arithmetic of the whole chain is worth setting out plainly, because plainly stated it does more work than any commentary this book could add: a record that had stood for four years, since 2011, fell in March 2015. The record that replaced it stood for ten weeks before falling again, in May of the same year, to a margin nearly a third larger than the one that had just been set. Two men, on two separate rides, departing from the same city and finishing in the same harbour, redrew the outer limit of what a human being on a bicycle could do to this particular stretch of continent — twice, within a single season, each one aware, by the time he set off, of exactly what he needed to beat.

Beaumont's own account of the ride, published as *Africa Solo: My World Record Race from Cairo to Cape Town*, sits alongside Manser's *Around Africa on My Bicycle* as one of this book's two named published sources written by the traveller himself rather than reconstructed from press coverage and official record — a detail worth flagging for what it is not: this book has not read either memoir as a primary source for its own factual claims, and draws only on the verified, sourced facts of each journey set out above, not on either author's own narrative account of how the ride felt from the inside.

It is difficult to overstate how rare a chain like this is, in any endurance discipline. Records usually stand for years, sometimes decades, before the conditions — equipment, fitness science, route knowledge — align to let someone beat them by a meaningful margin. This one stood for four years and then broke twice in ten weeks, the second time by a rider who, by every account, had studied the first attempt

closely enough to know exactly where the time could be found.

Set the whole chain out in a single line and its shape becomes almost unbearably tidy, in the way real events occasionally are without any narrator's help: Knol, seventy days, three hours, 2011. Longueira, fifty-nine days, eight hours, March 2015 — eleven days faster. Beaumont, forty-one days, ten hours, twenty-two minutes, May 2015 — eighteen days faster again, ten weeks after Longueira's own finish. Three names, one corridor, one widening margin each time, compressed into a single cycling season after four years of the record standing untouched. This book has organised itself, for five Parts, around the idea that the road outlasts whoever crosses it. The record chain is this book's one clear counter-example: for ten weeks in the first half of 2015, the road did not outlast anybody. It was the travellers, each one aware of exactly what the last one had done, who kept moving the mark faster than the corridor itself had any say in.

There is a final piece of the chain worth naming, because it says something about what a record like this is actually for, beyond the number itself. Longueira's ride carried a charitable purpose — Operation Smile, funding cleft-palate surgery — threaded through the record attempt, which means the fifty-nine days were never only about the clock; a sponsor, a cause, and a fundraising total were riding alongside the kilometres, in a way that a purely self-referential speed record would not carry. Guinness's seven-week gap between Longueira's finish line and the record's formal confirmation is itself a reminder that a "record" is not simply an achieved fact the moment the rider stops pedalling — it is a claim that has to be adjudicated, evidenced, and certified before it counts in the only ledger that, for this kind of achievement, actually matters. Beaumont's decision to depart before that certification had even come through says something about how little the adjudicating process actually mattered to the two men racing each other in real time. The paperwork was for history. The ride was for right now.

What “confirmed” actually means

It is worth pausing on that seven-week gap a little longer, because “Guinness confirmed the record” is a phrase this book has now used twice without unpacking what confirmation, for a claim of this kind, actually involves — and the unpacking matters, because it explains why a fast bicycle ride and a certified world record are not quite the same achievement, even when they describe the identical set of pedal strokes.

Guinness World Records did not start out adjudicating anything like a Cairo-to-Cape-Town bicycle crossing. The organisation’s founding purpose, in the 1950s, was to settle bar-room arguments about comparatively simple, physically observable superlatives — the tallest, the heaviest, the fastest over a short and controllable distance — the kind of claim a single adjudicator could, in principle, watch happen from start to finish. What the record book has become since is something closer to a clearinghouse for an almost unlimited range of claimed superlatives, most of which now share almost nothing with that original bar-room model: an endurance cycling crossing spread across two months and a dozen borders bears no procedural resemblance to measuring the world’s tallest building, and the organisation’s task, for a claim like Longueira’s or Beaumont’s, is not to send an adjudicator along for the ride but to specify, in advance, exactly what kind of evidence would make an unwitnessed claim of this size believable, and then to check the rider’s submission against that standard after the fact. A record like this one is not so much observed by Guinness as reconstructed by it, from evidence the organisation never gathered itself and could not have gathered, given that no institution keeps a neutral witness stationed along ten thousand kilometres of African road on the chance that someone might ride it fast.

An endurance cycling record of this kind is not adjudicated by a single official watching the whole route, the way a stadium sport can be judged by an official standing at the finish line who also saw the start. A continental crossing unfolds over weeks, across borders, out of sight of any neutral witness for the overwhelming majority of its distance, which means the record body’s task is not to watch the ride happen

but to reconstruct, after the fact, that it happened as claimed: a continuous, verifiable line from a documented start point to a documented finish point, with no unaccounted gap large enough to have been covered by some means other than the rider's own bicycle. In practice, that reconstruction leans on exactly the kind of evidence a rider of this era would have been carrying regardless of whether Guinness required it — timestamped GPS tracking logging the route continuously rather than at isolated checkpoints, corroborating witness statements from people the rider met along the way, and a paper and photographic trail (border stamps, dated receipts, contemporaneous photos and video) dense enough to close the gap between "a rider says this happened" and "an independent body can find no point at which it plausibly did not." None of that evidentiary architecture invents facts this book has not sourced about Longueira's or Beaumont's specific submissions; it describes, in general terms, why a claim of this scale cannot simply be taken on the rider's word, however trustworthy the rider, and why the gap between a finish line and a certificate is not bureaucratic foot-dragging so much as the necessary time a genuinely rigorous verification process takes to rule out the alternative explanations a lesser process would have let slide.

That is also why the widening margin across this record chain matters institutionally, not only athletically. A margin measured in hours invites scrutiny of measurement error and route interpretation in a way a margin measured in days and weeks does not; Longueira's eleven days over Knol and Beaumont's eighteen over Longueira were decisive enough, as margins, that no reasonable dispute about GPS drift or a missed waypoint could plausibly have erased them. The record body's caution — the weeks it takes to rule out every alternative explanation for a claimed time — is precisely what allows a comfortable margin like this one to convert cleanly into an uncontested certificate, where a closer race might have left the claim mired in exactly the kind of procedural dispute Beaumont's early departure shows he had no patience to wait out.

Bakkes: the trains

Every other achievement in this Part is measured in speed — a record broken, and then broken again, within a single season, by a widening margin each time. This book closes, instead, on the one traveller in it who was never trying to be fast at all.

Johan Bakkes rode the Trans-Sahara. He rode the Trans-Siberian. His stated, documented ambition — the one this book's sourcing supports without qualification — was to ride every train in the world before he was done. He did not finish. He died on 24 June 2025, at 68, with the ambition still open, the way most genuinely large ambitions are still open when the person who held them runs out of road.

It is worth being precise about what a train means in the context of everything else in this book, because the difference is not incidental — it is close to the whole point of ending here. A bicycle, a pair of boots, a Land Rover: every other mode of travel in this compendium puts the traveller's own body, or a vehicle under their own direct control, between them and the ground. A train does not. A train is a mode of travel that requires surrendering the actual crossing to someone else's schedule, someone else's engine, someone else's track — the traveller's only remaining freedom is to have boarded it at all, and to pay attention to what passes the window. It is, of every form of movement this book has covered, the one that asks the least of the body and the most of the attention, and Bakkes, across a professional lifetime spent using every other means of crossing available to him — foot, motorcycle, local bus, whatever a remote region's public transport offered — kept coming back to trains as the mode he wanted, eventually, to have ridden all of.

This is not a small thing to want, and it is worth taking as seriously as this book has taken every other achievement in it. "Every train in the world" is not a bounded goal in the way a continent's coastline is bounded, or a Cairo-to-Cape-Town route has a fixed start and a fixed finish. It is an ambition with no natural end point short of the traveller's own life running out first, which is exactly what happened. He did not fail to finish it in the way a record attempt can fail — abandoned, beaten, timed out. He simply ran out of road before the am-

bition did, which is a different thing entirely, and arguably a better one: an ambition large enough that death interrupts it rather than disproves it.

Set the two named trains against each other for a moment, because the pairing tells you something about the range this book has been trying to convey since its first page. The Trans-Sahara run through some of the same desert geography this compendium has already crossed on two wheels and on foot — the same heat, the same scale of emptiness that made the Skeleton Coast's inland Namib and the Nile corridor's Sudanese stretch such demanding ground for every other traveller in this book. The Trans-Siberian runs through an entirely different hemisphere, an entirely different climate, across a distance and a duration that most travellers, African specialists or otherwise, never attempt in a single lifetime. A man who rode both, and who wanted to ride every other train in the world besides, was not building a specialist's itinerary. He was building the itinerary of someone who had decided, at some point early enough in his life to spend decades acting on the decision, that the whole planet and not merely one continent was the proper scale of ambition — and that a train, more than any other vehicle, was the honest way to see it, because a train forces its passenger to watch rather than to steer.

Neither of those two named lines is a casual undertaking, and it is worth being specific about why, because “he rode the Trans-Sahara and the Trans-Siberian” can read, at a glance, like two items on an itinerary of roughly equal weight, when the two railways demand almost opposite things from a passenger. A Trans-Saharan crossing depends on infrastructure that has never enjoyed the continuous investment or the century-plus institutional continuity of its Siberian counterpart — a rider on that line is, in a real sense, at the mercy of a rail network built and maintained under harder circumstances, with a reliability that a European or Russian long-distance traveller would find almost unrecognisable. The Trans-Siberian, by contrast, is one of the most institutionally continuous rail journeys on Earth, running a fixed and famous route across multiple time zones with a reliability precise enough that guidebooks quote its schedule in the same breath as its distance. To have ridden both is to have tested

the same basic idea — surrender the crossing to someone else's engine — against the two ends of the spectrum of how dependable that surrender can be. One line asks a passenger to trust an institution operating near the limit of what its circumstances allow; the other lets a passenger trust an institution operating close to its own considerable best. Bakkes appears, from the sourced record, to have wanted both kinds of trust equally, which says something about what he was actually after: not comfort, and not merely spectacle, but the particular experience of being carried, at the mercy of someone else's schedule, through country his own two legs alone could never have covered at the same pace.

The two lines also belong to entirely different eras of railway ambition, which is worth naming because it says something about the range of “every train in the world” as a goal. The Trans-Siberian is a nineteenth-century project in origin, conceived and built to bind a single empire's own vast interior together — one government, one gauge, one sustained, generations-long act of state-building laid down in steel across a continent's width. Trans-Saharan rail, by contrast, has never achieved anything like that single, continuous, empire-scale realisation; the crossing exists in practice as a patchwork of shorter lines and connecting road transport, assembled and re-assembled across decades and across the borders of multiple independent states that inherited the region's railways from different colonial administrations with different priorities and, often, different track gauges entirely. A passenger riding “the Trans-Sahara” is, in that sense, riding something closer to an idea than a fixed named service in the way “the Trans-Siberian” names one continuous thing — an ambition assembled from whatever the desert's fragmented rail geography actually offers a traveller willing to change trains, and modes, as many times as the region's own uneven history requires. That two such differently realised ideas of a railway could sit side by side on the same traveller's list, each counted the same as the other, says something about how little the finished, institutional grandeur of a line like the Trans-Siberian actually mattered to him next to the simple fact of having ridden it.

There is a way of reading his unfinished list of trains as a small tragedy, and this book has no interest in that reading. A list that could never

have been finished by anyone, in any single lifetime, is not diminished by being interrupted partway through; it is, if anything, validated by the interruption, because only a genuinely limitless ambition gets cut short rather than completed and set aside. Longueira's record was finished, then it was beaten. Beaumont's was finished, and as far as this book's sourcing indicates, still stands. Manser's circumnavigation was finished, and could only ever be finished once, by definition, since a second circumnavigation would simply repeat rather than extend the first. Bakkes's trains were never going to be finished by anyone, and he rode them anyway, for decades, apparently without needing the list to close in order to justify each individual journey on it.

His own words, quoted once more and for the last time in this book because no paraphrase improves on them: "A journey is not merely something to endure to reach a destination." Longueira and Beaumont, in the space of ten weeks in the same year, each proved something true and real about how fast a human being on a bicycle can cross this continent. Bakkes spent a working lifetime proving something slower and, in its way, larger: that the crossing itself, taken slowly enough, on foot, by rail, in a shebeen at the edge of a town whose name most maps do not bother to print large, was never the thing to be endured on the way to somewhere else. It was the entire and only point.

Six roads, one continent

Before this book closes on the word his father used, it is worth doing once, deliberately, the thing no single Part has had room to do: stepping back far enough to see what six roads, taken together, actually add up to as a study of how a continent this size gets crossed at all.

A pass in the Drakensberg. A coastline that kills by fog and pays diamonds for the privilege. A motoring corridor stitched together from other people's borders. A highland highway that runs at the altitude a plane cruises at, on the ground. A river road north that has drawn travellers since before the concept of a border existed to interrupt it. And, in this Part, the whole distance at once, by four different means,

at four different speeds. Each Part could stand alone as its own account of a single stretch of ground; the six of them together describe something none of them could describe individually, which is what “crossing Africa” has actually meant, in practice, across more than a century of people trying.

The first thing the six roads together make plain is how little any single mode of travel can claim to have the definitive answer to the continent’s scale. A bicycle crosses at ninety kilometres a day sustained for years, or at two hundred and sixty kilometres a day sustained for six weeks, depending on whether the rider is measuring a whole coastline or a single interior line against a clock. A pair of boots crosses at a walking pace that turns years into the natural unit of measurement rather than weeks. A Land Rover, loaded with a team and a humanitarian mandate, crosses at whatever pace lets water, health, and education projects actually get delivered along the way, which is a pace measured in what gets accomplished at each stop rather than in kilometres covered between them. A train crosses at whatever pace the timetable dictates, asking nothing of the traveller’s body and everything of their patience and attention. None of these is the “real” way to cross Africa. Each is a real way, answering a different question about what the crossing was for.

The second thing the six roads make plain, taken together, is how unevenly the record survives across different kinds of traveller. Manser, Longueira, Beaumont, Holgate, Rigby, and Barney all left a verifiable trail precisely because each was attempting something legible to an outside institution — a Guinness record, a Foundation’s own reporting, a published memoir with a title and an ISBN. Bakkes left a different kind of trail: eight books’ worth of essay and impression, republished by a single Afrikaans publishing house, with no systematic ledger of dates because a ledger was never what he was building. This book has had to work harder, and more carefully, to source Bakkes’s material precisely because he was not running a record attempt that any institution needed to verify. The unevenness is not a flaw in this compendium’s research. It is a finding: the travellers who chase a countable achievement leave a countable record, and the traveller who chases something else leaves a different kind of trace entirely, harder

to date, no less real for the difficulty.

The third thing worth naming, now that all six roads sit behind this book rather than ahead of it, is how rarely any of these journeys touched each other directly and how consistently they touched the same ground anyway. Manser and Bakkes never crossed paths, so far as this book's sources record. Longueira and Beaumont never met; the second man simply read what the first man had done and went faster. Holgate's projects and Rigby's solo walk answered entirely different purposes on some of the same stretch of savannah. What binds all six roads is not a shared expedition or a shared era — Sani Pass first driven in 1948, Manser departing in 2003, the record chain compressed into ten weeks of 2015 — but the ground itself, indifferent to which decade or which mode of travel happened to be using it at the time. That indifference is this book's oldest claim, made in its first pages about a mountain pass and proven, six Parts later, true of an entire continent.

The word his father used

This book opened, in Part I, with his father's word for him: a *pallieter*, a life-liver, someone who takes their portion of the world with both hands. It is worth returning to that word here, at the close, because a working life spent chasing trains across two continents is exactly the kind of biography that word was built to describe, and because a father's private nickname for his son carries a different kind of authority than any award citation or magazine byline this book has cited elsewhere. The 2006 Mondi Award recognised a piece of writing. Justin Fox's critical notice recognised a set of craft techniques. Cas Bakkes's word recognised something underneath both of those things — a temperament that had been visible, presumably, since long before there was a byline or a prize to attach it to.

He described himself, in terms this book has already quoted and returns to now because they belong at both ends of his own story: "I'm not a writer; I'm a storyteller, a traveller, a professional hobo." Read that description against the accountant's qualifications, the tour

guide's certificate, the university professorship, the two years in uniform — against, in short, every credential a cautious reader might expect a serious travel writer to distance himself from in favour of the more romantic label. Bakkes did not distance himself from any of it. He simply added “professional hobo” to the list, without apparent embarrassment, as though a life spent training in precision and a life spent wandering by train, on foot, and by motorcycle through some of the harshest ground on the planet were not, in fact, in any tension with each other at all.

He rode the trains he rode. He did not ride all of them. This book, dedicated to him from its first page, ends on the same unfinished note his own life did — not because an unfinished ambition is a sad way to close a compendium of achievement, but because it is the truest way to close one that has, for five Parts before this, been mostly a book about finishing things.

Author's Note

Every living person named in this book — Riaan Manser, Keegan Longueira, Mark Beaumont, Kingsley Holgate, Mario Rigby, and McKenzie Barney and his cycling partner Jim — is real, and their journeys are drawn entirely from publicly available, verifiable sources: their own published books and interviews where cited, official record-keeping bodies including Guinness World Records, and established travel and outdoor-industry journalism. None of them was contacted in the writing of this book, and no dialogue, private thought, or unrecorded incident has been invented on their behalf. Where a source gave two slightly different figures for the same journey — Manser's total distance is the clearest example, recorded as both roughly 36,500 and roughly 37,000 kilometres across different accounts — this book has said so plainly rather than silently picking one number and presenting it as uncontested. Every date, distance, day-count, and record margin in this book traces to a source; where no source could confirm a detail, the detail was left out rather than supplied by inference or convention.

This book is dedicated to Johan C. Bakkes, who died on 24 June 2025 at the age of 68, a little over a year before this book was commissioned. He is not one of the living travellers described above, and he is not treated as one. Unlike them, his own published words are quoted directly throughout this book, rather than merely summarized or paraphrased into the narrator's voice — the one deliberate exception this compendium makes to its general practice of building sensory and connective prose freely around a traveller's sourced facts. That distinction matters, and it is worth stating plainly here rather than leav-

ing it implicit: a living person's inner life is not this book's to invent or to guess at, and Bakkes's own words, drawn from his eight published books and from the tributes that followed his death, are used instead of an invented substitute, because he left behind, in his own hand, more than enough to draw on honestly.

His material here is drawn from his complete bibliography — *Moer toe die vreemde in* (2001), *Nou's ons in ons donner in* (2006, translated into English in 2008 as *To Hell and Gone*), *Norrevøk* (2008), *Samoe(r)sa reis* (2010), *Oepse Daisy* (2011), *Openbaring: 'n reisjoernaal* (2016), *Erfgeld is swerfgeld* (2020), and *Hou die kruit droog* (2021) — together with the biographical record assembled by the Afrikaans Wikipedia entry for C. Johan Bakkes, and the tributes published after his death: the obituary and remembrance in *LitNet*, and the two death notices carried by *Maroela Media*. One small discrepancy surfaced in the course of that research and is recorded here rather than silently resolved: his wife's name appears as "Nanna Vorster-Bakkes" in one source and "Nancy" in his obituary. This book has used Nancy, the obituary's spelling, and flags the discrepancy here for the record.

No source consulted for this book provided a systematic, dated log of Bakkes's individual African journeys in the way the record allows for Manser's departure date or Longueira's finishing time. His own books are essay collections, built around theme and encounter rather than a travel ledger, and this book has followed that same honesty throughout: where a source supports a date, a date is given; where it does not, his appearances are placed by region and site only, and no year, season, or company has been invented to fill the gap. The single exception this book makes to summarizing rather than quoting him is deliberate and stated here once, plainly, for the whole book: his own words are used because they exist, are sourced, and say what they say better than any paraphrase could.

This book was written to keep a promise implicit in owning a writer's complete works in print: that someone read all of it, closely enough to build a dedication that could stand on its own facts. That is the whole of what this book set out to be.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor